



ACC

GAME GRADER

2025 SEASON			LAST 3 YEARS (2023-2025)			LAST 5 YEARS (2021-2025)			LAST 10 YEARS (2016-2025)		
P4 RANK / 68	TEAM	GRADE	P4 RANK / 68	TEAM	GRADE	P4 RANK / 68	TEAM	GRADE	P4 RANK / 68	TEAM	GRADE
6	MIAMI	78.8	7	MIAMI	70.7	13	CLEMSON	61.2	4	CLEMSON	74.5
17	VIRGINIA	63.7	16	SMU	62.4	16	LOUISVILLE	60.2	17	MIAMI	59.0
20	LOUISVILLE	63.3	17	LOUISVILLE	62.3	18	MIAMI	59.0	25	LOUISVILLE	54.4
23	SMU	62.0	23	CLEMSON	59.7	23	SMU	57.5	33	PITTSBURGH	50.0
25	FLORIDA STATE	59.0	34	GEORGIA TECH	50.2	28	FLORIDA STATE	52.7	34	NC STATE	49.9
29	PITTSBURGH	56.7	35	FLORIDA STATE	50.1	30	PITTSBURGH	51.6	35	SMU	49.5
31	CLEMSON	55.2	36	DUKE	49.4	35	NC STATE	50.4	38	FLORIDA STATE	48.7
33	GEORGIA TECH	54.7	41	NC STATE	47.1	47	NORTH CAROLINA	46.4	45	NORTH CAROLINA	47.3
34	WAKE FOREST	54.0	42	VIRGINIA TECH	46.2	50	WAKE FOREST	45.6	46	VIRGINIA TECH	47.1
37	DUKE	52.5	45	CALIFORNIA	45.0	51	DUKE	45.0	48	WAKE FOREST	45.6
40	NC STATE	50.3	50	NORTH CAROLINA	44.4	55	CALIFORNIA	43.0	52	CALIFORNIA	43.5
51	CALIFORNIA	42.4	51	PITTSBURGH	44.3	57	GEORGIA TECH	42.3	54	DUKE	42.4
59	NORTH CAROLINA	34.9	54	VIRGINIA	43.7	58	SYRACUSE	42.1	55	VIRGINIA	42.3
61	VIRGINIA TECH	33.8	61	SYRACUSE	39.8	59	VIRGINIA	41.6	57	GEORGIA TECH	41.3
64	BOSTON COLLEGE	30.9	62	BOSTON COLLEGE	39.7	60	VIRGINIA TECH	41.4	59	BOSTON COLLEGE	40.7
65	STANFORD	28.8	63	WAKE FOREST	38.2	65	BOSTON COLLEGE	36.8	63	SYRACUSE	39.7
66	SYRACUSE	27.8	68	STANFORD	26.3	68	STANFORD	26.8	65	STANFORD	39.0

OFFENSE

2025 SEASON			LAST 3 YEARS (2023-2025)			LAST 5 YEARS (2021-2025)			LAST 10 YEARS (2016-2025)		
P4 RANK / 68	TEAM	GRADE	P4 RANK / 68	TEAM	GRADE	P4 RANK / 68	TEAM	GRADE	P4 RANK / 68	TEAM	GRADE
10	FLORIDA STATE	1.1	7	MIAMI	1.1	10	LOUISVILLE	0.9	6	LOUISVILLE	1.0
12	GEORGIA TECH	1.0	12	LOUISVILLE	0.8	16	MIAMI	0.6	14	CLEMSON	0.5
15	SMU	0.8	15	GEORGIA TECH	0.7	19	SMU	0.5	15	NORTH CAROLINA	0.5
18	MIAMI	0.8	20	SMU	0.6	23	FLORIDA STATE	0.5	20	MIAMI	0.5
21	LOUISVILLE	0.6	33	NC STATE	0.3	24	NORTH CAROLINA	0.4	22	SMU	0.4
22	DUKE	0.6	34	VIRGINIA TECH	0.2	34	GEORGIA TECH	0.2	26	FLORIDA STATE	0.3
25	NC STATE	0.5	36	FLORIDA STATE	0.2	42	NC STATE	0.1	30	GEORGIA TECH	0.2
37	VIRGINIA TECH	0.1	40	DUKE	0.1	46	WAKE FOREST	0.0	44	VIRGINIA TECH	0.1
39	WAKE FOREST	0.1	41	NORTH CAROLINA	0.1	50	CLEMSON	0.0	46	NC STATE	0.1
41	CLEMSON	0.1	42	CLEMSON	0.1	51	PITTSBURGH	0.0	48	PITTSBURGH	0.1
46	PITTSBURGH	0.0	52	BOSTON COLLEGE	-0.1	52	DUKE	0.0	51	WAKE FOREST	0.0
49	BOSTON COLLEGE	0.0	55	PITTSBURGH	-0.2	55	VIRGINIA	-0.1	56	STANFORD	-0.1
51	VIRGINIA	-0.1	59	CALIFORNIA	-0.2	57	VIRGINIA TECH	-0.1	59	VIRGINIA	-0.2
61	CALIFORNIA	-0.4	60	VIRGINIA	-0.3	58	SYRACUSE	-0.2	60	SYRACUSE	-0.2
62	STANFORD	-0.6	62	WAKE FOREST	-0.3	61	CALIFORNIA	-0.3	62	DUKE	-0.3
66	NORTH CAROLINA	-0.8	63	SYRACUSE	-0.3	63	BOSTON COLLEGE	-0.3	64	BOSTON COLLEGE	-0.4
68	SYRACUSE	-1.0	68	STANFORD	-0.6	66	STANFORD	-0.6	66	CALIFORNIA	-0.5

DEFENSE

2025 SEASON			LAST 3 YEARS (2023-2025)			LAST 5 YEARS (2021-2025)			LAST 10 YEARS (2016-2025)		
P4 RANK / 68	TEAM	GRADE	P4 RANK / 68	TEAM	GRADE	P4 RANK / 68	TEAM	GRADE	P4 RANK / 68	TEAM	GRADE
4	MIAMI	1.5	11	SMU	0.8	9	CLEMSON	0.7	3	CLEMSON	1.1
9	WAKE FOREST	1.1	12	MIAMI	0.8	13	PITTSBURGH	0.7	11	MIAMI	0.7
14	PITTSBURGH	0.9	16	PITTSBURGH	0.6	15	FLORIDA STATE	0.6	16	FLORIDA STATE	0.5
19	LOUISVILLE	0.8	24	LOUISVILLE	0.5	21	MIAMI	0.5	18	PITTSBURGH	0.5
20	VIRGINIA	0.7	25	FLORIDA STATE	0.5	23	LOUISVILLE	0.5	29	CALIFORNIA	0.3
27	FLORIDA STATE	0.5	29	CLEMSON	0.5	29	SMU	0.4	36	NC STATE	0.2
29	NORTH CAROLINA	0.5	35	CALIFORNIA	0.3	33	CALIFORNIA	0.3	44	VIRGINIA TECH	0.1
32	SMU	0.4	38	VIRGINIA TECH	0.2	42	NC STATE	0.2	45	SMU	0.1
39	CLEMSON	0.3	40	WAKE FOREST	0.2	45	VIRGINIA TECH	0.1	48	WAKE FOREST	0.1
44	VIRGINIA TECH	0.0	41	DUKE	0.2	46	WAKE FOREST	0.1	50	LOUISVILLE	0.0
46	STANFORD	0.0	48	VIRGINIA	0.1	49	VIRGINIA	0.0	53	VIRGINIA	0.0
55	NC STATE	-0.2	52	NORTH CAROLINA	0.0	53	SYRACUSE	0.0	56	BOSTON COLLEGE	-0.1
57	CALIFORNIA	-0.2	56	NC STATE	-0.1	59	NORTH CAROLINA	-0.2	57	DUKE	-0.1
63	GEORGIA TECH	-0.5	59	STANFORD	-0.3	60	DUKE	-0.2	58	NORTH CAROLINA	-0.1
64	DUKE	-0.5	62	GEORGIA TECH	-0.3	62	GEORGIA TECH	-0.3	62	GEORGIA TECH	-0.2
66	SYRACUSE	-0.7	63	SYRACUSE	-0.4	63	BOSTON COLLEGE	-0.3	63	STANFORD	-0.2
67	BOSTON COLLEGE	-1.0	65	BOSTON COLLEGE	-0.5	64	STANFORD	-0.4	64	SYRACUSE	-0.3

ALL-TRANSFER TEAM

QB	DARIAN MENSAH	Duke	→	MIAMI	DL	DAMON WILSON	Missouri	→	MIAMI
RB	KENDRICK RAPHAEL	California	→	SMU	DL	KEONA DAVIS	Nebraska	→	MIAMI
RB	JUSTICE HAYNES	Michigan	→	GEORGIA TECH	DL	HARVEY DYSON	Tulane	→	NC STATE
WR	COOPER BARKATE	Duke	→	MIAMI	DL	TYLER THOMPSON	North Carolina	→	LOUISVILLE
WR	IAN STRONG	Rutgers	→	CALIFORNIA	LB	POPO AGUIRRE	Miami	→	NC STATE
WR	QUE'SEAN BROWN	Duke	→	VIRGINIA TECH	LB	MIKAI GBAYOR	North Carolina	→	FLORIDA ST
WR	TRE RICHARDSON	Vanderbilt	→	LOUISVILLE	LB	CHRIS D'APPOLONIA	Toledo	→	SYRACUSE
OL	XAVIER CHAPLIN	Auburn	→	FLORIDA ST	DB	OMAR THORNTON	Boston College	→	MIAMI
OL	JIMARION McCRIMON	East Carolina	→	NC STATE	DB	KOEN ENTRINGER	Iowa	→	LOUISVILLE
OL	ERYX DAUGHERTY	Boston College	→	LOUISVILLE	DB	ELLIOT WASHINGTON	Penn State	→	CLEMSON
OL	KRISTIAN PHILLIPS	Michigan State	→	BOSTON COLL.	DB	RICKY FLETCHER	Ole Miss	→	CALIFORNIA
OL	JOSEPH IONATA	Alabama	→	GEORGIA TECH	DB	KING MACK	Penn State	→	NC STATE



ACC

1 MIAMI



2 LOUISVILLE



3 SMU



4 CLEMSON



5 VIRGINIA TECH



6 VIRGINIA



7 NC STATE



8(TIE) PITTSBURGH



8(TIE) GA TECH



10 FLORIDA ST.



11 CALIFORNIA



12(TIE) WAKE FOREST



12(TIE) DUKE



14 N. CAROLINA



15 SYRACUSE



16 STANFORD



17 BOSTON COLL.



ALL-ACC: OFFENSE

1st TEAM		2nd TEAM		3rd TEAM	
QB	DARIAN MENSAH	MIAMI	QB	KEVIN JENNINGS	SMU
RB	MARK FLETCHER	MIAMI	RB	MALACHI HOSLEY	GEORGIA TECH
RB	ISAAC BROWN	LOUISVILLE	RB	NATE SHEPPARD	DUKE
WR	MALACHI TONEY	MIAMI	WR	BRYANT WESCO	CLEMSON
WR	DUCE ROBINSON	FLORIDA ST	WR	TJ MOORE	CLEMSON
WR	COOPER BARKATE	MIAMI	WR	IAN STRONG	CALIFORNIA
TE	JEREMIAH HASLEY	DUKE	TE	LUKE REYNOLDS	VIRGINIA TECH
OL	PJ WILLIAMS	SMU	OL	SAMSON OKUNLOLA	MIAMI
OL	McKALE BOLEY	VIRGINIA	OL	MATTHEW MCCOY	MIAMI
OL	NOAH JOSEY	VIRGINIA	OL	JOSHUA BATES	SMU
OL	LANCE ROBINSON	LOUISVILLE	OL	MALACHI CARNEY	GEORGIA TECH
OL	SPIKE SOWELLS	NC STATE	OL	ETHAN MacKENNY	GEORGIA TECH
QB	J-K SAGAPOLTELE	CALIFORNIA	RB	KENDRICK RAPHAEL	SMU
RB	JUSTICE HAYNES	GEORGIA TECH	WR	TRE RICHARDSON	LOUISVILLE
WR	YAMIR KNIGHT	SMU	WR	JORDAN SHIPP	UNC
TE	BRODY FOLEY	LOUISVILLE	TE	JACKSON CANTWELL	MIAMI
OL	RYAN BAER	PITTSBURGH	OL	BJ WILLIAMS	PITTSBURGH
OL	NIKI PRONGOS	STANFORD	OL	JIMARION McCRIMON	NC STATE

ALL-ACC: DEFENSE

1st TEAM		2nd TEAM		3rd TEAM	
DL	MELKART ABOU JAOUDE	UNC	DL	KEMARI COPELAND	VIRGINIA TECH
DL	WILL HELDT	CLEMSON	DL	JUSTIN SCOTT	MIAMI
DL	CLEV LUBIN	LOUISVILLE	DL	MANDRELL DESIR	FLORIDA ST
DL	AHMAD MOTEN	MIAMI	DL	NICK JAMES	PITTSBURGH
LB	SAMMY BROWN	CLEMSON	LB	MO TOURE	MIAMI
LB	KAM ROBINSON	VIRGINIA	LB	BRAYLAN LOVELACE	PITTSBURGH
LB	MATT ROSE	STANFORD	LB	STANQUAN CLARK	LOUISVILLE
DB	TAYON HOLLOWAY	LOUISVILLE	DB	ASHTON HAMPTON	CLEMSON
DB	BRYCE FITZGERALD	MIAMI	DB	KOEN ENTRINGER	LOUISVILLE
DB	XAVIER LUCAS	MIAMI	DB	JAY GREEN	STANFORD
DB	CHRIS PEAL	SYRACUSE	DB	DAVAUGHN PATTERSON	WAKE FOREST
DL	LANGSTON HARDY	WAKE FOREST	DL	DEMECO KENNEDY	LOUISVILLE
DL	ELHADJ FALL	VIRGINIA TECH	DL	DAMON WILSON	MIAMI
LB	KALEB SPENCER	VIRGINIA TECH	LB	ANTONIO WATTS	LOUISVILLE
DB	ZECHARIAH POYSER	MIAMI	DB	JA'BRIL RAWLS	FLORIDA ST
DB	RICKY FLETCHER	CALIFORNIA	DB	SHAWN LEE	PITTSBURGH
DB	CRUCE BROOKINS	PITTSBURGH			



ACC - UNIT RANKS

TEAM	QB	RB	WR/TE	OL	DL	LB	DB
MIAMI	1	1	1	1	1	3	1
LOUISVILLE	6	3	3	3	2	2	2
SMU	2	6	5	5	10	5	11
CLEMSON	11	5	2	6	3	1	3
VIRGINIA TECH	7	9	7	10	4	10	9
VIRGINIA	8	12	12	4	7	4	8
NC STATE	4	7	9	8	12	9	5
GEORGIA TECH	13	2	13	2	11	6	13
PITTSBURGH	5	11	15	9	5	7	4
FLORIDA ST	14	4	4	7	6	8	10
CALIFORNIA	3	10	6	12	13	14	6
WAKE FOREST	12	15	11	16	8	12	7
DUKE	16	8	14	11	15	15	17
UNC	9	13	8	13	9	13	12
SYRACUSE	10	17	10	17	17	16	14
STANFORD	17	16	17	14	14	11	16
BOSTON COLL.	15	14	16	15	16	17	15



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OVERALL



MIAMI 5-YEAR WIN TREND				
16				(NC) Indiana
15				SMU
14				LOUISVILLE
13			(B) Rutgers	
12	FSU	PITTSBURGH	LOUISVILLE	SYRACUSE
11	UNC	CLEMSON	FSU	GA TECH
10	VIRGINIA	FSU	NC STATE	WAKE FOREST
9	Mich State	DUKE	UNC	DUKE
8	Alabama	UNC	GA TECH	PITTSBURGH
7	DUKE	Middle Tenn.	BC	LOUISVILLE
6	VA TECH	Texas A&M	VIRGINIA	CAL
5	GA TECH		CLEMSON	VA TECH
4	PITTSBURGH	VIRGINIA	Temple	FSU
3	NC STATE	VA TECH	Beth-C (FCS)	Florida
2	C. Conn (FCS)	S. Miss	Texas A&M	USF
1	App State	Beth-C (FCS)	Miami OH	Beth-C (FCS)
	2021	2022	2023	2024
	DIAZ	MARIO CRISTOBAL		
			2025	

MIAMI				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
NOTRE DAME	W 27-24	25	2	77.8
Beth-Cook (FCS)	W 45-3	352	2	76.8
USF	W 49-12	244	0	114.7
FLORIDA	W 26-7	203	-1	94.3
FLORIDA ST	W 28-22	-66	3	58.8
LOUISVILLE	L 21-24	-33	-3	42.5
STANFORD	W 42-7	260	2	90.9
SMU	L 20-26	45	-1	48.9
SYRACUSE	W 38-10	99	3	74.5
NC STATE	W 41-7	438	1	120.9
VA TECH	W 34-17	23	1	65.7
PITTSBURGH	W 38-7	187	0	108.8
(P) TEXAS A&M	W 10-3	-48	2	73.7
(P) OHIO ST	W 24-14	-41	1	82.3
(P) OLE MISS	W 31-27	61	-1	78.8
(NC) INDIANA	L 21-27	25	-1	52.0
OVERALL: 6th / 68	ACC: 1st / 17			78.8

MIAMI UNIT RANKS		
ACC RANK (of 17)	NATIONAL TOP 15	
QUARTERBACK	1	5
RUNNING BACKS	1	5
RECEIVERS & TE	1	2
OFFENSIVE LINE	1	8
DEFENSIVE LINE	1	4
LINEBACKERS	3	
DEFENSIVE BACKS	1	7

MIAMI			RANK
Scoring Offense	30.9 ppg		35
Points per Play	0.47		37
Total Offense	405 ypg		47
Yards per Play	6.1		34
Rushing Offense	152 ypg		77
Yards per Carry	4.3		73
O-Line Run Push	4.3		49
Explosive Rush	4.3		111
Passing Offense	253 ypg		41
Yards / Attempt	8.2		25
QB Rating	157		13
TD / INT Ratio	2.7		42
Sacks / Attempt	4%		19
Explosive Pass	7.6		44
Return. Production	48%		85
Returning Snaps	10,767		53
29.8 SECONDS/PLAY #65 of 68 P4	DAWSON (2025 MIAMI) SLOW		

Behind their nation-best lines of scrimmage, and one of the most improved defenses, Miami closed out another 10-2 regular season. They swept their in-state rivals again, and then closed with four wins by an average of 28 points/game.

Their most important win actually came way back in the opener. Miami's pass rush finished off a physical 27-24 win over Notre Dame and they snapped their eight-year drought against Top 10 opponents.

In 2024, Miami's 10-2 record landed them just outside the Playoff field. This time 10-2 was enough, due to their critical head-to-head win over the other final 10-2 team in question: Notre Dame.

It was the correct decision. "Let us never, ever devalue the importance of head-to-head competition, please," said head coach Mario Cristobal.

Miami found another gear in the postseason. They went into Kyle Field and beat Texas A&M 10-3 behind a breakout performance by running back Mark Fletcher and a game-sealing pick in the endzone by Bryce Fitzgerald.

Another interception flipped the Cotton Bowl, as Keionte Scott jumped a screen pass and took back a Pick Six 72 yards as Miami knocked out the defending champs Ohio State – 2002 payback.

Miami got more late-game heroics from the offense in the semifinal as freshman phenom Malachi Toney zig-zagged through the Ole Miss defense for a score. Then veteran Carson Beck scrambled in for the game-winner in the final seconds.

Miami returned to the national title stage for the first time in a generation, and like the old days, they got to play for it on their home turf. Ultimately, Indiana made two critical fourth-down plays – the back shoulder fade to Charlie Becker, and a Heisman-tier scramble by Fernando Mendoza – and Miami fell six points short of their sixth ring.

As Cristobal put it: we say, 'The U is Here,' we are here right now.

Despite falling a few plays short, the postseason run accelerated Cristobal's program build, and all the elite talent acquisition is paying dividends.

OFFENSE

Beck went pro, so the staff went back for a third-straight transfer quarterback. They hit home runs with Cam Ward and Beck, and this round should be no different.

Darian Mensah led Duke to a rare ACC title with his 3,973 passing yards, 35 touchdowns, and high 67% completion rate. He was graded a Top 5 transfer quarterback this cycle and all season long he showed off both touch and arm strength, and a gunslinger attitude.

Mensah had the most downfield pass attempts in Power 4 last year. Their quarterback selection addresses one of the only weaknesses of the offense last year: a lack of downfield, vertical shots in the pass game.

Miami was one of five Power 4 offenses to feature a 3,000-yard passer, 1,000-yard rusher, and 1,000-yard receiver. Duke was one of the others, and Mensah brought his receiver Cooper Barkate with him to join Miami's workhorse back Fletcher, and highlight-reel Toney.

Fletcher found an extra gear in the Playoffs, averaging 126 rushing yards/game which was nearly double his regular season average. Marty Brown also returns, plus another round of Top200 blue-chippers in Jordan Lyle and Girard Pringle.

The receiver room could be the nation's best. Toney is a no-brainer All-America pick after breaking Miami's school records for receptions (109) and yards (1,211) as a true freshman. Barkate put up 1,106 yards for Duke last year, earned All-ACC, and was ranked a Top 10 transfer receiver this cycle. Toney is the best screen pass receiver, while Barkate actually led the nation in the 10-19 yard intermediate range last year. The staff signed four-star transfers Vandrevius Jacobs (South Carolina) and Cam Vaughn (West Virginia) who were Power 4 starters and combined for 1,089 yards last year.

The spring surprise was sophomore Joshua Moore's surge up the depth chart to a starting role. The 6'4, 220-pound former Top100 moved ahead of the veteran transfers. Plus, another round of Top100's are incoming from the 2026 class: Milan Parris and Somourian Wingo.

MIAMI OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)										
O	18	1	21	52	46	24	42	46	17	17
F	SHANNON DAWSON GATTIS RHETT LASHLEE ENOS THOMAS BROWN									
F	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016
D	HETHERMAN	GUIDRY	STEELE	DIAZ*	BLAKE BAKER	MANNY DIAZ				
E	4	35	26	57	21	18	20	4	13	7
F										11th

MIAMI		RANK
Scoring Defense	14.8 ppg	5
Points per Play	0.24	6
Total Defense	294 ypg	12
Yards per Play	4.7	12
3rd Down Conv%	31%	11
Rushing Defense	89 ypg	6
Yards per Carry	3.0	9
Negative Play %	10%	14
Explosive Rush	5.2	30
Passing Defense	205 ypg	43
Yards / Attempt	6.3	24
QB Rating	115	18
Completion %	59.9%	40
Explosive Pass	4.2	8
Return. Production	51%	74
Returning Snaps	14,972	9

MIAMI		RANK / 68
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play		
Offense Overall		18
Rushing Offense	0.5	21
Passing Offense	27.1	8
Defense Overall		4
Rushing Defense	1.7	3
Passing Defense	33.5	4

moved up into a starting role in spring.

The secondary loses nickelback Scott and safety Jakobe Thomas, but the room is overflowing with talent. All four of the starting corners are back: Xavier Lucas, OJ Frederique, Damari Brown, and Ethan O'Connor. The staff signed four-star transfer Omar Thornton who started for Boston College last year and showed off excellent open-field tackling and got ACC honorable mention. Zechariah Poyser is back at safety, then three more Top100s pack the room with playoff hero Fitzgerald and incoming freshmen JJ Dunnigan and Camdin Portis.

OUTLOOK

The U came alive in the Playoff spotlight and accelerated Cristobal's program build. I projected Playoff bids in 2024 and 2025 – the '24 team was one of the last teams out, '25 was the final team in – and a college football giant is awakening.

It seems odd, since they still haven't won the conference title game, but Miami is the new ACC dynasty program. The talent that Cristobal has stockpiled is head and shoulders above the rest of the league and they are my pick to win the ACC, and make another Playoff run in January.

MIAMI		RANK / 68
All-Time Wins	678	41
All-Time Win %	0.630	14
Wins (Last 100)	678	14
Wins (Last 50)	425	11
Wins (Last 25)	206	18
Wins (Last 10)	82	16
Wins (Last 5)	42	18
Game Grader (10 yr)	59.0	17
Game Grader (5 yr)	59.0	18
Game Grader (3 yr)	70.7	7
Draft Picks s' 2000	148	6
Draft Picks s' 2010	85	9
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		19
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		43

The tight end room had one of its lowest outputs in decades last year. Elija Lofton is a returning starter and more top recruits join the rotation with four-star Luka Gilbert and Top100 Gavin Mueller.

Cristobal's program was built intentionally from the inside out, with attention on the lines of scrimmage. He and ace line coach Alex Mirabal built one of the nation's best last year. Four linemen earned All-ACC honors, all four are gone, and anchor Francis Mauigoa was drafted in the first round.

Miami signed the #1 offensive lineman this cycle Jackson Cantwell and he is projected to start at left tackle right away. Cristobal has started true freshmen successfully in the past like Penei Sewell and Mauigoa. Another five-star Samson Okunlola is next to him at left guard, oft-injured Ryan Rodriguez takes over at center, and veteran Matthew McCoy shifted out to right tackle. The final guard spot is a battle between four-star Max Buchanan and Top100 SJ Alofaituli who are both second-years.

DEFENSE

Cristobal made one of the best coordinator hires of the entire 2025 cycle with Corey Hetherman here on defense. Hetherman inherited a below-average unit and with a more aggressive scheme, and an elite pass rush, vaulted Miami up to #4 in my opponent-adjusted number.

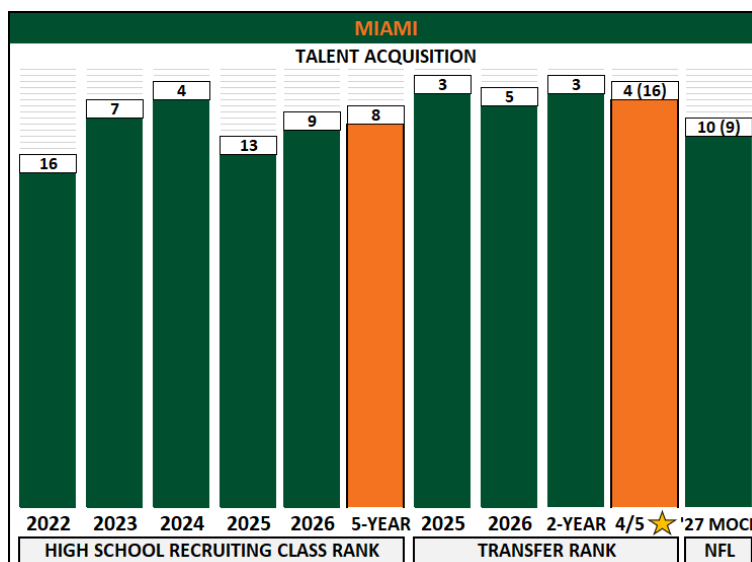
Six starters are gone, including two first-round draft picks off the edges. Rueben Bain and Akheem Mesidor were game-wreckers and combined for an insane 150 quarterback pressures, 33 tackles for loss, and 22 sacks. Normally that loss of star power would be enough to sink the defense, but Miami is absolutely stacked in the trenches. Of the eight linemen in the two-deep, four are five-stars, three more are Top200's, and the other is All-ACC tackle Ahmad Moten.

Former five-star tackle Justin Scott (Saint Ignatius) is poised for an All-ACC season, Keona Davis (Nebraska) was a full-year starter, and Jarquez Carter (Ohio State) was Top200 in the 2025 class. At end, five-stars Armondo Blount and Marquise Lightfoot are joined by the nation's #2 transfer edge Damon Wilson (Missouri) who posted 10 sacks last year.

Wesley Bissainthe is gone but All-ACC Mo Toure was granted an eighth college season and is the leader in the middle. Chase Smith enters his sixth season and

MIAMI	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 4	@ Stanford
S. 10	FLORIDA A&M (FCS)
S. 18	@ Wake Forest
S. 26	C. MICHIGAN
O. 3	@ Clemson
O. 10	--- BYE ---
O. 17	FLORIDA STATE
O. 24	PITTSBURGH
O. 31	@ UNC
N. 7	@ Notre Dame
N. 14	DUKE
N. 21	VIRGINIA TECH
N. 28	BOSTON COLL.

MIAMI				GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)						
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR
78.8 (6)	74.8 (7)	58.6 (24)	36 (55)	46.9 (43)	58.5 (25)	49.9 (35)	53.5 (29)	64.2 (15)	68.4 (12)	59 (17)



CANESWEAR
MIAMI FANWEAR



LOUISVILLE

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#2

ACC

#19

OVERALL



LOUISVILLE				
5-YEAR WIN TREND				
14	(B) Air Force	Kentucky	(B) USC	STANFORD
13	Kentucky	CLEMSON	(CG) FSU	MIAMI
12	CLEMSON	BC	Kentucky	SMU
11	NC STATE	FSU	PITTSBURGH	Notre Dame
10	VIRGINIA	SYRACUSE	MIAMI	(B) Washington
9	WAKE FOREST	(B) Cincinnati	VIRGINIA	(B) Toledo
8	Ole Miss	NC STATE	VA TECH	Kentucky
7	DUKE	James Madison	DUKE	PITTSBURGH
6	SYRACUSE	WAKE FOREST	Notre Dame	CLEMSON
5	BC	PITTSBURGH	NC STATE	BC
4	FSU	VIRGINIA	BC	VIRGINIA
3	UCF	USF	Indiana	GA TECH
2	EKU (FCS)	UCF	Murray (FCS)	Jax State
1			GA TECH	Austin Peay (FCS)
2021		2022	2023	2024
SCOTT SATTERFIELD		JEFF BROHM		

LOUISVILLE				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
E. Kentucky (FCS) W 51-17	392	-3	72.2	
JMU W 28-14	1	1	81.3	
BOWLING GREEN W 40-17	118	1	65.1	
PITTSBURGH W 34-27	53	4	77.0	
VIRGINIA L 27-30	146	-2	61.0	
MIAMI W 24-21	33	3	78.3	
BOSTON COLL. W 38-24	144	0	67.0	
VA TECH W 28-16	131	-1	66.6	
CALIFORNIA L 26-29	-76	-1	29.9	
CLEMSON L 19-20	77	0	62.4	
SMU L 6-38	-257	-1	2.7	
KENTUCKY W 41-0	300	2	104.7	
(B) TOLEDO W 27-22	-3	0	54.6	
OVERALL: 20th / 68	ACC: 3rd / 17	63.3		

LOUISVILLE	UNIT RANKS	
ACC RANK	NATIONAL	
(of 17)	TOP 15	
QUARTERBACK	6	
RUNNING BACKS	3	12
RECEIVERS & TE	3	
OFFENSIVE LINE	3	
DEFENSIVE LINE	2	15
LINEBACKERS	2	
DEFENSIVE BACKS	2	

LOUISVILLE	RANK	
Scoring Offense 29.9 ppg	47	
Points per Play 0.46	38	
Total Offense 385 ypg	71	
Yards per Play 6.0	42	
Rushing Offense 164 ypg	59	
Yards per Carry 5.1	24	
O-Line Run Push 4.4	37	
Explosive Rush 7.7	8	
Passing Offense 221 ypg	77	
Yards / Attempt 6.9	82	
QB Rating 132	74	
TD / INT Ratio 2.0	72	
Sacks / Attempt 6%	62	
Explosive Pass 5.4	115	
Return. Production 52%	73	
Returning Snaps 14,101	21	
27.3 SECONDS/PLAY #44 of 68 P4		
BROHM (2025 LOUISVILLE)		

Jeff Brohm made it three-in-a-row at his alma mater: three transfer quarterbacks, three 9-win seasons.

But this time Louisville did it with defense and a run game.

Ron English's defense made drastic improvements, especially against the pass, and Louisville finished ranked in the national Top 40 in all 17 of my defensive stat categories. They joined Oregon as the only units to do so.

That pass defense made the difference by picking off Carson Beck four times in Louisville's 24-21 win over #2 Miami for their second Top 2 win in program history (2016 FSU). The statement win helped push Louisville up as high as #15 in the polls.

Instead of his usual pass-heavy scheme, Brohm doubled down on the run game with his trio of explosive running backs and they finished with the #7 rushing attack in my opponent-adjusted numbers. Even with the roster crushed with injuries, Louisville lined up and powered the ball between the tackles in their 41-0 destruction of rival Kentucky.

It was a nice consolation prize for a season that had several missed opportunities separating Louisville from a potential ACC title spot in such a wide-open league race.

Their first three losses came by a combined seven points. Louisville gave away two defensive touchdowns to Virginia in the 30-27 overtime loss, lost another overtime game to California 29-26, and then held Clemson to 1/13 on third downs but blew it late 20-19 with a run of self-inflicted penalties.

Brohm now has eight one-score losses in his three seasons, but opponent-adjusted Game Grader shows just how close they are to a breakthrough: 2nd in the ACC (2023), 4th (2024), and 3rd (2025).

The staff has excelled in talent acquisition and this 2026 transfer haul has Louisville reloaded for perhaps Brohm's best roster yet.

OFFENSE

Miller Moss posted an average passing season – 10th in the ACC in both yards/attempt and QB Rating – but struggled in crunch time. His sack-turned Pick Six cost them the Virginia loss, and then in the three-game November stretch he threw just one touchdown. Explosiveness was missing from the pass game and Louisville dropped 90 spots year-over-year in long-yardage passing.

Brohm went back to the portal for a fourth-straight transfer quarterback but this is the first one without Power 4 starting experience. Louisville signed Lincoln Kienholz (Ohio State) who spent his freshman seasons backing up Kyle McCord and Will Howard, and then lost the fall camp competition to Julian Sayin in 2025.

Stuck in a crowded NFL quarterback room, he comes to Louisville with minimal game experience but last year in blowouts he showed off a strong arm, good reads in the RPO game, mobility in the pocket, and even some strength in QB power runs. The former Top200 high school recruit brings the most athletic skillset that Brohm has had here.

Louisville lost their top four receivers including the productive All-ACC duo of Chris Bell and Caullin Lacy (1,552 combined receiving yards) but they reloaded with highly-touted transfers for Kienholz to throw to.

They signed a one-two punch with speedster Tre Richardson (Vanderbilt) and Lawayne McCoy (Florida State) who were both graded as four-star transfers. Richardson led Vanderbilt with 806 receiving yards and seven touchdowns and also ranked #7 in the SEC in yards after catch. Both guys should help fix the offense's lack of explosive pass plays. TreyShun Hurry returns as the third receiver.

LOUISVILLE										OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)	
O	21	4	25	22	5	15	10	51	2	2	6th
F	BRIAN BROHM		TAYLOR	SATTERFIELD	DWAYNE LEDFORD		LONNIE GALLOWAY				
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR
D	RON ENGLISH			BRYAN BROWN			VanGORDER	SIRMON	GRANTHAM		
E	19	39	24	20	46	46	67	67	55	13	50th
F											

LOUISVILLE		RANK	
Scoring Defense	21.2 ppg	38	
Points per Play	0.33	40	
Total Defense	303 ypg	16	
Yards per Play	4.7	15	
3rd Down Conv%	33%	18	
Rushing Defense	114 ypg	23	
Yards per Carry	3.5	23	
Negative Play %	9%	38	
Explosive Rush	4.9	21	
Passing Defense	189 ypg	25	
Yards / Attempt	6	15	
QB Rating	115	17	
Completion %	59.2%	34	
Explosive Pass	4.8	30	
Return. Production	55%	61	
Returning Snaps	11,770	42	

LOUISVILLE		RANK / 68	
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play			
Offense Overall		21	
Rushing Offense	1.2	7	
Passing Offense	3.8	40	
Defense Overall		19	
Rushing Defense	0.6	28	
Passing Defense	22.9	11	

Brody Foley (Tulsa) earned first-team All-AAC honors and was ranked the #4 transfer tight end. Another four-star, Foley will be a mismatch nightmare and will pair up well with returning starter Jaleel Skinner.

The running back room was the strength of the offense last year and two of the three return for 2026. Isaac Brown was a 2024 Freshman All-American and was off to an insane pace in 2025 with an 8.6 per-carry average and five 100+ yard games in the first eight. He was injured but then Keyjuan Brown stepped up and averaged a high 7.3 per carry. Both Brown's are back, and the staff added a Top200 recruit in redshirt freshman Marquise Davis (Missouri).

Three multi-year starting offensive linemen graduated – center Pete Nygra and tackles Rasheed Miller and Trevonte Sylvester – and the staff hit the portal hard. Eryx Daugherty (Boston College) and Cason Henry (South Carolina) are both Power 4 starters with a combined 25 starts while Anwar O'Neal (Delaware) and Johnnie Brown (Georgia Southern) were all-league linemen at the non-AQ level. All-ACC honorable mention guard Lance Robinson is the lone returning starter.

DEFENSE

The staff hit home runs in the transfer portal last cycle and it paid off with an elite pass rush, #11 pass defense, and #19 overall defense per my opponent-adjusted numbers. Coordinator Ron English stepped down for family reasons and Brohm hired from within, elevating cornerbacks coach Steve Ellis and defensive line coach Mark Ivey to be co-coordinators. They will continue the 4-2-5 scheme that has worked here.

Their pass rush duo of Clev Lubin and AJ Green combined for 12.5 sacks and 19.5 tackles-for-loss. Both return, and while Wesley Bailey graduated, the staff backfilled with Tyler Thompson (UNC) who placed in the ACC's top ten in sacks last year. The ends are a clear strength, but they lost three tackles: Rene Konga, Jordan Guerad, and Jerry Lawson (Oklahoma State). They added three Power 4 transfers and Demeco Kennedy (Purdue) got huge spring praise from Brohm.

There are no question marks at linebacker, as they return a top unit for 2026. TJ Quinn graduates after leading the team in tackles for three straight seasons, but the other three are back including All-ACC Antonio Watts, veteran Stanquan Clark, and TJ Capers who had the game-sealing pick against Miami.

Tayon Holloway had two picks in the Kentucky win and also earned All-ACC honors as a lockdown corner. The other starting spots in the secondary are up for grabs, but again, the staff pumped in highly-touted transfers. Koen Entringer (Iowa) was ranked a Top 10 safety transfer, and Kaleb Beasley (Tennessee) and TJ Banks (Ole Miss) are former Top200 recruits. DJ Waller (Kentucky) is projected to start at the other corner spot and he brings several years of Power 4 experience.

OUTLOOK

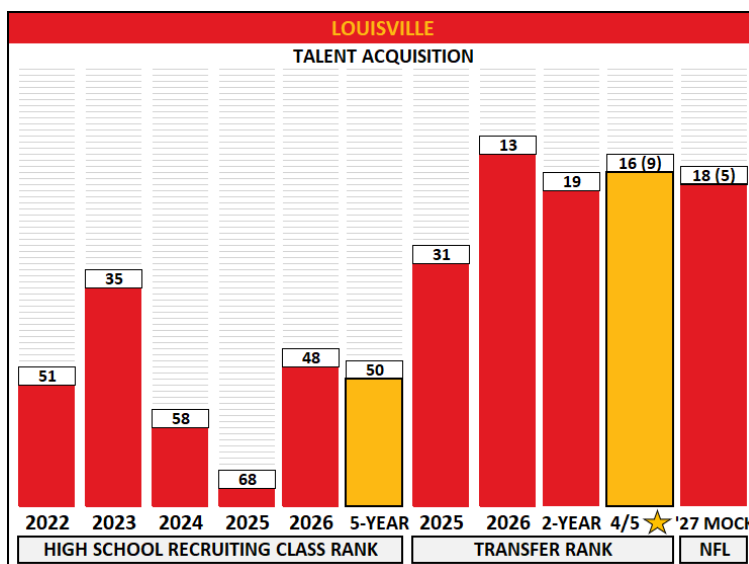
Louisville joined national runner-up Miami as the only ACC teams to place in the Top 25 of both my opponent-adjusted Offense and Defense rankings. They were painfully close to an ACC title breakthrough, but now Brohm has his best roster yet.

The staff excelled in the transfer portal again and now Louisville ranks in the ACC top three in every position unit ranking except quarterback, but few coaches can match Brohm's track record developing signal-callers. Louisville faces only one of the ACC's top six, and is my pick to play Miami in the ACC title game.

LOUISVILLE	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 6	*OLE MISS (NASH)
S. 11	VILLANOVA (FCS)
S. 19	SMU
S. 26	WAKE FOREST
O. 3	@ NC State
O. 9	FLORIDA STATE
O. 17	@ Syracuse
O. 24	--- BYE ---
O. 31	STANFORD
N. 7	@ Georgia Tech
N. 14	@ UNC
N. 21	PITTSBURGH
N. 28	@ Kentucky

LOUISVILLE		RANK / 68	
All-Time Wins	568	61	
All-Time Win %	0.529	47	
Wins (Last 100)	536	49	
Wins (Last 50)	334	32	
Wins (Last 25)	201	20	
Wins (Last 10)	73	29	
Wins (Last 5)	42	18	
Game Grader (10 yr)	54.4	25	
Game Grader (5 yr)	60.2	16	
Game Grader (3 yr)	62.3	17	
Draft Picks s' 2000	68	35	
Draft Picks s' 2010	39	40	
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)	6		
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)	5		

LOUISVILLE		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
63.3 (20)	61.1 (22)	62.7 (18)	61.9 (18)	52 (35)	50.1 (33)	43.9 (44)	12.9 (68)	61 (21)	75.4 (6)	54.4 (25)	





SMU

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#3

ACC

#21

OVERALL



SMU				
5-YEAR WIN TREND				
14		(B) BC	(P) Penn State	CALIFORNIA
13		TCU	(CG) Clemson	WAKE FOREST
12	(B) BYU	Oklahoma	BYU	TCU
11	TULSA	(CG) TULANE	CALIFORNIA	Baylor
10	CINCINNATI	NAVY	BC	(B) Arizona
9	MEMPHIS	MEMPHIS	VIRGINIA	LOUISVILLE
8	HOUSTON	TCU	DUKE	BC
7	UCF	Maryland	PITTSBURGH	MIAMI
6	TULANE	MEMPHIS	STANFORD	CLEMSON
5	NAVY	RICE	FSU	STANFORD
4	USF	TULSA	TCU	SYRACUSE
3	TCU	TEMPLE	Hou Chr. (FCS)	Missouri St
2	LA Tech	ECU	Nevada	E.TX A&M (FCS)
1	North Texas	CHARLOTTE		
	Lamar (FCS)	PV A&M (FCS)		
	North Texas	LA Tech		
2021		2022	2023	2024
DYKES		RHETT LASHLEE		

SMU				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
E.TX A&M (FCS) W 42-13	49	0	59.5	
BAYLOR L 45-48	-143	1	29.1	
MISSOURI ST W 28-10	120	1	63.9	
TCU L 24-35	-133	-1	22.7	
SYRACUSE W 31-18	-19	2	55.5	
STANFORD W 34-10	16	2	69.7	
CLEMSON W 35-24	77	0	85.1	
WAKE FOREST L 12-13	-55	2	45.5	
MIAMI W 26-20	-45	1	72.9	
BOSTON COLL. W 45-13	184	3	85.4	
LOUISVILLE W 38-6	257	1	119.8	
CALIFORNIA L 35-38	25	-1	39.3	
(B) ARIZONA W 24-19	-49	-2	57.7	
OVERALL: 23rd / 68		ACC: 4th / 17	62.0	

SMU	UNIT RANKS	
ACC RANK (of 17)	NATIONAL	TOP 15
QUARTERBACK	2	8
RUNNING BACKS	6	
RECEIVERS & TE	5	
OFFENSIVE LINE	5	
DEFENSIVE LINE	10	
LINEBACKERS	5	
DEFENSIVE BACKS	11	

SMU	RANK	
Scoring Offense	32.2 ppg	27
Points per Play	0.49	26
Total Offense	417 ypg	31
Yards per Play	6.3	24
Rushing Offense	134 ypg	95
Yards per Carry	4.3	69
O-Line Run Push	4.0	98
Explosive Rush	5.4	66
Passing Offense	283 ypg	13
Yards / Attempt	8	34
QB Rating	147	35
TD / INT Ratio	2.0	70
Sacks / Attempt	4%	21
Explosive Pass	8.0	34
Return. Production	66%	23
Returning Snaps	14,908	14
24.2 SECONDS/PLAY #10 of 68 P4		
LASHLEE (2025 SMU)	FAST	

In 2024 SMU moved back up to the Power 4 level, ending a decades-long rebuild from their crippling NCAA sanctions. They became the first program ever to move up and post an 8-0 regular season in their new league, and then came a field goal short from winning the ACC title game.

Far from a one-hit wonder, the 2025 team showed the program has staying power. SMU went into Clemson's Death Valley and avenged the ACC title loss, gave their home fans a field-stormer by beating #10 Miami in overtime, and went into the final day of the season with a win-and-in scenario to another ACC title game.

SMU rallied from a 17-point deficit to take a late lead on California, but the Bears drove right down the field to steal back the win, leaving SMU on the bad end of a five-team title tiebreaker.

It was a missed opportunity, and along with the Baylor, TCU, and Wake Forest games, SMU held fourth-quarter leads in all their eventual losses.

Even though it ended without a return trip to Charlotte or another Playoff appearance, head coach Rhett Lashlee found plenty of positives – and

rightfully so: “this senior class is special, they put SMU back on the national stage, and we’re just getting started.”

The seniors set a program record with 31 wins over three years and added SMU’s first ranked bowl win since the 1984 Aloha Bowl over Notre Dame. Along with the 2024 accolades, Lashlee’s comments are certainly backed up.

The on-field success is paying off in other areas too. Gerald Ford Stadium had the nation’s highest year-over-year boost in attendance from 2023 to 2024-25. Then they signed consecutive #32 ranked recruiting classes – 12 four-stars -- to set a program record in the modern recruiting era.

OFFENSE

SMU retained their most important star in quarterback Kevin Jennings. The dual-threat gunslinger enters his third and final season as the starter. Simply put, he is a highlight reel and with him under center SMU can score on any given snap.

Jennings posted back-to-back 3,000+ yard seasons and placed in the ACC’s top five in QB Rating both times. In 2025, he cut down on his turnover-collapse games and did so despite suffering a leg injury that limited his mobility. When he gets back to 100% this fall, his elusiveness and speed add another element to his game, and he should contend for All-ACC honors.

He loses his top two targets with Jordan Hudson and Romello Brinson both graduating. Yamir Knight caught 54 balls for 637 yards last year and emerged over the second half of the season. Knight steps up as the featured receiver this fall and is joined by two impact transfers in four-star Yannick Smith (East Carolina) and Jalen Hale (Alabama) who was a former five-star recruit. Top200 Jalen Cooper impressed as a freshman last season, true freshman Aljour Miles got huge praise from Lashlee this spring, and SMU stocked the room with another round of young blue-chippers.

The staff has also stacked recruiting wins in the trenches, with *four* four-star linemen in the past two recruiting cycles. While the freshmen spend 2026 as a developmental growth year, SMU has a veteran starting five again.

First-team All-ACC guard Logan Parr leaves as a program legend, but the right side of the line is back. Right tackle PJ Williams is the star this season, center Joshua Bates also received ACC honors, and Addison Nichols returns at right guard. Alex Woods and Andrew Chamblee are projected starters on the left side, though Top100 Dramodd Odoms could push at left tackle as a redshirt freshman. They need some improvement in Offensive Line Run Push (#98) but landed another Top 25 rank in Pass Protection, even with a less-mobile Jennings in November.

SMU loses their one-two punch in the backfield with the physical TJ Harden graduating and the explosive Chris Johnson transferring out to Clemson. The staff signed California starter Kendrick

SMU					OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)									
O	15	21	35	26	32	17	24	62	24	47				22nd
F	CASEY WOODS					GARRETT RILEY					RHETT LASHLEE			
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR			
D	SCOTT SYMONS					LEAVITT					KEVIN KANE			
E	32	12	10	56	55	51	42	33	68	58				45th
F														

SMU		RANK	
Scoring Defense	20.5 ppg	32	
Points per Play	0.27	11	
Total Defense	395 ypg	89	
Yards per Play	5.3	42	
3rd Down Conv%	37%	45	
Rushing Defense	112 ypg	19	
Yards per Carry	3.2	13	
Negative Play %	8%	65	
Explosive Rush	4.2	11	
Passing Defense	283 ypg	135	
Yards / Attempt	7.1	65	
QB Rating	130	56	
Completion %	60.9%	57	
Explosive Pass	5.6	65	
Return. Production	58%	38	
Returning Snaps	14,110	14	

SMU		RANK / 68	
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play			
Offense Overall		15	
Rushing Offense	0.2	35	
Passing Offense	20.5	13	
Defense Overall		32	
Rushing Defense	0.7	24	
Passing Defense	5.1	34	

There's even more attrition up front with all four defensive linemen gone: Isaiah Smith, Jeffrey M'ba, Terry Webb, and Cam Robertson. SMU does get two original starters back from injury recoveries with former Liberty transfer Aakil Washington at edge, and Jonathan Jefferson finally back at tackle. Former Missouri transfer Jahkai Lang started four games at end here last year, and a pair of three-star transfers battle at tackle: Malcolm Alcorn-Crowder (Kansas State) and All-MAC Marques White (UMass).

OUTLOOK

Lashlee is leveling up the roster talent from the high school ranks, and each year of development it will pay off more and more. SMU is on an upward trajectory but in the short-term, there are some obstacles in 2026: a double coordinator change, and the loss of *nine* of their 12 All-ACC stars.

Jennings is a Heisman darkhorse, he's got plenty of weapons to throw to and a stout line blocking for him. SMU is a legit ACC title contender but the talent drain on defense, as well as the loss of ace coordinator Symons, keeps them in the #3 spot.

SMU		RANK / 68	
All-Time Wins	557	63	
All-Time Win %	0.493	59	
Wins (Last 100)	514	54	
Wins (Last 50)	254	59	
Wins (Last 25)	141	57	
Wins (Last 10)	80	17	
Wins (Last 5)	46	11	
Game Grader (10 yr)	49.5	35	
Game Grader (5 yr)	57.5	23	
Game Grader (3 yr)	62.4	16	
Draft Picks s' 2000	24	67	
Draft Picks s' 2010	21	62	
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		37	
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		1	

Raphael who grinded out a 900-yard season and ACC honorable mention despite getting no help from the #135 offensive line at Cal. Dramekco Green got experience in the bowl game, and versatile pass-threat Derrick McFall returns and may even get some reps in the slot.

All three tight ends depart, including All-ACC Matthew Hibner. The staff signed three Power 4 tight ends from the portal: Florida State starter Randy Pittman, four-star Theo Melin Ohrstrom (Texas A&M), and Trey Jackson (Texas Tech).

Offensive coordinator Casey Woods took the head coach job at Missouri State, and Lashlee promoted receivers coach Rob Likens. Lashlee is still the playcaller though, so there won't be changes to the high-tempo spread offense. This should be a Top 15 offense again.

DEFENSE

The coordinator change on this side is more uncertain. Over the past three-year average, SMU ranks #10 in my opponent-adjusted defense rankings and they lose mastermind Scott Symons to the NFL. Lashlee promoted internally here too – linebackers coach Maurice Crum and cornerbacks coach Rickey Hunley – but the loss of Symons is an uncertainty.

It doesn't help losing six All-ACC stars. The entire starting defensive line is gone along with four starting defensive backs.

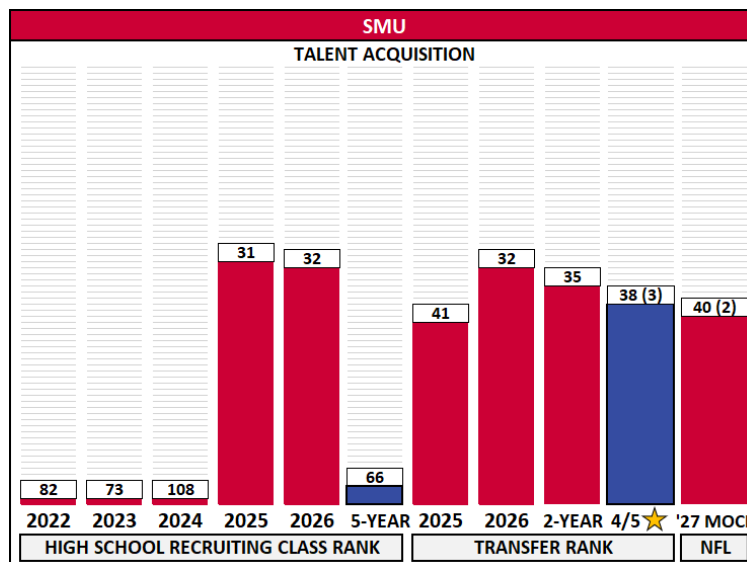
The linebacker trio returns as one of ACC's best groups. Alex Kilgore is a proven star, Brandon Booker is ready for a breakout season, and former walk-on Brandon Miyazono continues to impress. The trio combined for 174 tackles, 11 for loss, and 3 picks.

Outside of the linebacker room it is a complete rebuild.

SMU allowed 283 pass yards/game, second-worst nationally, but from a per-play, efficiency perspective they checked in at #56 in QB Rating, and #34 of 68 Power 4 in my opponent-adjusted passing number. All-ACC stars Ahmaad Moses, Isaiah Nwokobia, and Deuce Harmon are all gone, and corner Marcellus Barnes is the only returning starter in the secondary. Jarvis Lee (USF) and All-AAC Jimmy Wyrick (UTSA) are three-star transfers projected as starters at nickel and safety.

SMU	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 7	@ Florida St
S. 12	UC DAVIS (FCS)
S. 19	@ Louisville
S. 26	MISSOURI ST
O. 3	BOSTON COLL.
O. 10	--- BYE ---
O. 17	VIRGINIA
O. 24	CALIFORNIA
O. 31	@ Syracuse
N. 6	VIRGINIA TECH
N. 14	WAKE FOREST
N. 21	@ Notre Dame
N. 28	@ Stanford

SMU		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	2015	10-YEAR
62 (23)	65.9 (15)	59.2 (22)	48.7 (42)	51.7 (36)	47.8 (36)	54 (28)	30.8 (64)	40 (54)	34.8 (58)	49.5 (35)	





CLEMSON

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#4

ACC

#23

OVERALL



CLEMSON				
5-YEAR WIN TREND				
14		(B) Tennessee		(P) Texas
13	PITTSBURGH	S. Carolina	NC STATE	S. Carolina
12	NC STATE	Notre Dame	MIAMI	LOUISVILLE
11	Georgia	(CG) UNC	FSU	Georgia
10	(B) Iowa State	MIAMI	DUKE	(CG) SMU
9	S. Carolina	LOUISVILLE	(B) Kentucky	The Citadel (FCS)
8	WAKE FOREST	SYRACUSE	S. Carolina	PITTSBURGH
7	UConn	FSU	UNC	VA TECH
6	LOUISVILLE	BC	GA TECH	VIRGINIA
5	FSU	NC STATE	Notre Dame	WAKE FOREST
4	SYRACUSE	WAKE FOREST	WAKE FOREST	FSU
3	BC	LA Tech	SYRACUSE	STANFORD
2	GA TECH	Furman (FCS)	FAU	NC STATE
1	SC State (FCS)	GA TECH	Charl. S (FCS)	App State
	2021	2022	2023	2024
	2025			
DABO SWINNEY				

The transfer portal has exploded since 2020 and changed how programs build their rosters. Thousands of players shift schools every offseason in what has become the biggest Musical Chairs in sports. While every other program doubled down and tripled down on the transfer market, Clemson and head coach Dabo Swinney remained committed to traditional recruiting with an anti-transfer stance.

Without the steady influx of proven college talent to patch up roster holes or cover for recruiting/scouting misses, the Dabo model meant the strength of the team would be cyclical year to year: developmental years with younger rosters, but then eventually the proven, veteran roster to cash in for championship runs.

With 17 starters returning from an ACC title team, Clemson was set to cash in. This was it – the year of vindication for Dabo's model. They entered 2025 as unanimous ACC favorites to repeat, and started with a high #4 preseason ranking.

Far from a title run, the whole thing collapsed in September.

CLEMSON					
2025 RESULTS		Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
LSU	L	10-17	-95	1	32.6
TROY	W	27-16	15	1	56.3
GA TECH	L	21-24	23	-2	47.3
SYRACUSE	L	21-34	70	-2	28.6
UNC	W	38-10	223	-1	81.1
BOSTON COLL.	W	41-10	283	-1	84.9
SMU	L	24-35	-77	0	29.8
DUKE	L	45-46	121	-1	63.3
FLORIDA ST	W	24-10	-41	2	70.5
LOUISVILLE	W	20-19	-77	0	49.4
Furman (FCS)	W	45-10	185	2	70.3
S. CAROLINA	W	28-14	-7	3	78.3
(B) PENN ST	L	10-22	-161	0	25.5
OVERALL: 31st / 68 ACC: 7th / 17 55.2					

Clemson lost the opener to LSU, needed a 16-point comeback to survive against Troy, and then lost ACC games to Georgia Tech and Syracuse. The offense was unproductive, the defense couldn't get the ACC offenses off the field, and they hit their first 1-3 start to a season since 2004.

Another wave of losses dropped Clemson to its worst season in 15 years. "I feel like I'm in 2010 all over again," Swinney said.

Though they did take back the rivalry crown from South Carolina, Swinney's "greatest turnaround team in Clemson history" praise rings hollow.

Clemson remained committed to the old strategy and signed the ACC's second-fewest transfers this cycle and notably did not sign a quarterback or a single offensive lineman. Multi-year starter Cade Klubnik graduated, the entire starting line is gone, but they kept the reload in-house.

That strategy, along with Swinney's change at offensive coordinator, will define the 2026 season.

OFFENSE

It does feel like 2010 with the hire at offensive coordinator. Clemson brought back Chad Morris, whose so-called "Smashmouth Spread" offense helped end the school's ACC title drought in 2011 and eventually his successors kept the scheme through the dynasty years.

Morris said he wants a two-back offense, a commitment to a physical rushing attack, and vertical shots downfield in the pass game.

That was all missing last year, as Clemson fell to #105 in rushing yards/game – Swinney's lowest – and below average marks in Offensive Line Run Push and Explosive Passing. And that was *with* the most veteran offense in America.

It's a full transition heading into 2026 with just three returning starters. Multi-year starter Klubnik graduated and Clemson doubled down on their quarterback room. Chris Vizzina was the #6 ranked quarterback in the 2023 recruiting class, and the former Top100 prospect spent three years as a backup. Vizzina started the SMU game and went 29/42 for 317 yards and three touchdowns but is otherwise an unknown. Against Furman, dual-threat Chris Denson posted Clemson's first 100-yard quarterback rushing game since Trevor Lawrence. But after spring, Swinney said the fall camp battle will be between Vezzina and incoming freshman three-star Tait Reynolds.

The other surprise was Clemson signing zero linemen from the portal to help fuel a reload as all five starters depart. Blake Miller earned first-team All-ACC honors after 50+ career starts while three others joined him with all-league honors. Despite the individual accolades, the unit struggled to get a run push and fell by 60 spots in all key stat categories.

Aside from Harris Sewell and Collin Sadler getting bowl game starts, this is a completely fresh starting five. Four of them are former Top200 four-star recruits but they collectively lack game experience.

CLEMSON	UNIT RANKS	
ACC RANK	NATIONAL	
(of 17)	TOP 15	
QUARTERBACK	11	
RUNNING BACKS	5	
RECEIVERS & TE	2	7
OFFENSIVE LINE	6	
DEFENSIVE LINE	3	
LINEBACKERS	1	6
DEFENSIVE BACKS	3	

CLEMSON	RANK	
Scoring Offense	27.2 ppg	71
Points per Play	0.4	72
Total Offense	392 ypg	65
Yards per Play	5.8	62
Rushing Offense	124 ypg	105
Yards per Carry	4.0	95
O-Line Run Push	4.1	86
Explosive Rush	4.5	107
Passing Offense	268 ypg	24
Yards / Attempt	7.3	63
QB Rating	139	56
TD / INT Ratio	3.1	27
Sacks / Attempt	4%	26
Explosive Pass	6.8	65
Return. Production	46%	94
Returning Snaps	10,002	61
26.7 SECONDS/PLAY #39 of 68 P4		
SWINNEY (2025 CLEMSON)		

CLEMSON										OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)	
O	41	23	55	41	55	14	5	3	32	9	14th
F	GARRETT RILEY		STREETER		TONY ELLIOTT		TONY ELLIOTT / JEFF SCOTT				
F	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR
D	ALLEN		WES GOODWIN		BRENT VENABLES						
E	39	43	9	9	4	8	1	2	2	6	3rd
F											

CLEMSON		RANK	
Scoring Defense	20.5 ppg	30	
Points per Play	0.31	24	
Total Defense	357 ypg	55	
Yards per Play	5.3	48	
3rd Down Conv%	32%	14	
Rushing Defense	105 ypg	16	
Yards per Carry	3.5	25	
Negative Play %	10%	22	
Explosive Rush	6.2	58	
Passing Defense	251 ypg	120	
Yards / Attempt	6.7	50	
QB Rating	126	46	
Completion %	60.7%	52	
Explosive Pass	4.5	17	
Return. Production	61%	26	
Returning Snaps	10,889	54	

CLEMSON		RANK / 68	
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play			
Offense Overall		41	
Rushing Offense	(0.5)	58	
Passing Offense	6.8	36	
Defense Overall		39	
Rushing Defense	0.5	31	
Passing Defense	8.9	27	

Three more all-league stars are gone from the secondary as Avieon Terrell graduated and safeties Ricardo Jones (Vanderbilt) and Khalil Barnes (Georgia) transferred out. The staff used the transfer portal here and signed three projected starters in three-stars Corey Myrick (Southern Miss), Jerome Carter (Old Dominion), and Elliot Washington (Penn State). Myrick and All-Sun Belt Carter will be the safety pair, while Washington drew huge Dabo praise: "by far the best guy in camp."

Ashton Hampton takes over as the new #1 corner, Corian Gipson is back at nickel, and Donovan Starr (Auburn) and Branden Strozier add talent to the room.

OUTLOOK

2025 was a total disappointment. With nine eventual NFL Draft picks, and the most veteran lineup in the league, they fell to their worst season since 2010.

Swinney doubled down on his anti-transfer plan, added zero offensive linemen or quarterbacks, but Clemson's high school recruiting still keeps them in ACC contention. They are no longer on the Dynasty Tier but should remain a Top 25 team with a roster packed with former four-star recruits.

All-ACC Adam Randall graduates and the staff signed SMU co-starter Chris Johnson who brings explosiveness, speed, and a high 7.1 yard/carry average. 2025 Top100 Gideon Davidson got some carries as a true freshman and gets a bigger role this year.

Clemson was able to retain two all-league stars in outside receivers Bryant Wesco and TJ Moore. Wesco had a season-ending injury but at full strength he is a potential All-American. They do lose Antonio Williams in the slot, but Tyler Brown returns there, and they signed near-five-star Naeem Burroughs.

Both tight ends return, and it sounds like Morris will be using both much more this season. Christian Bentancur and Olsen Patt-Henry combined for 36 catches last year but should get more this fall with one at end and one in an H-back role.

DEFENSE

From 2014-2023 Clemson posted 10 straight Top 10 defenses in my opponent-adjusted rankings – a full decade of elite defense. The 2024 and 2025 units ranked #43 and #39 of 68 Power 4.

Tom Allen took over as coordinator last year and helped boost the rush defense into the Top 25. The second-year coach bonus may be muted due to the loss of star power with six All-ACC defenders leaving.

TJ Parker and defensive tackles Peter Woods and Demonte Capehart all depart, but the productive Will Heldt is back at end after a 15.5 tackle-for-loss, 7.5 sack season. Jahiem Lawson moves up into the other end spot and the staff signed All-Freshman London Merritt (Colorado) who was second on his team in tackles-for-loss.

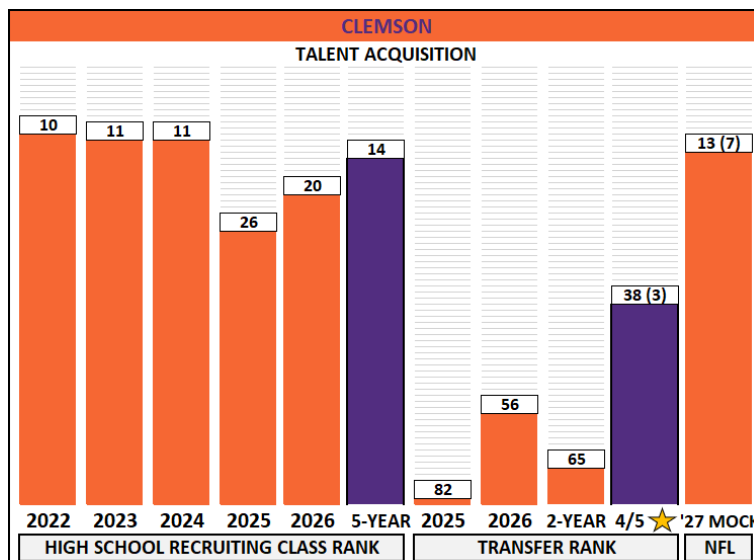
Both tackle spots are open but could remain a strength again with Oklahoma transfer Markus Strong and five-star Amare Adams in his second season.

First-team All-ACC Sammy Brown returns at linebacker as the star of the defense. Brown finished second in the ACC with 106 tackles and should push for All-America consideration. His co-star Wade Woodaz graduated, and Clemson lost a late transfer battle for Cal's Luke Ferrelli, so Kobe McCloud will battle former five-star Jeremiah Alexander for the starting role.

CLEMSON	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 5	@ LSU
S. 12	GA SOUTHERN
S. 19	UNC
S. 25	@ California
O. 3	MIAMI
O. 10	--- BYE ---
O. 17	CHARLESTON S (FCS)
O. 24	VIRGINIA TECH
O. 31	@ Florida State
N. 7	@ Syracuse
N. 14	GEORGIA TECH
N. 20	@ Duke
N. 28	S. CAROLINA

CLEMSON		RANK / 68	
All-Time Wins	815	13	
All-Time Win %	0.624	15	
Wins (Last 100)	704	13	
Wins (Last 50)	439	7	
Wins (Last 25)	244	5	
Wins (Last 10)	112	4	
Wins (Last 5)	47	10	
Game Grader (10 yr)	74.5	4	
Game Grader (5 yr)	61.2	13	
Game Grader (3 yr)	59.7	23	
Draft Picks s' 2000	115	13	
Draft Picks s' 2010	91	7	
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		45	
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		39	

CLEMSON		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
55.2 (31)	61.2 (21)	62.6 (19)	67.2 (15)	59.6 (22)	81.8 (3)	87.9 (3)	97.5 (1)	84.4 (1)	87.8 (2)	74.5 (4)	



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VIRGINIA TECH

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#5

#34

ACC

OVERALL



VIRGINIA TECH 5-YEAR WIN TREND				
13 (B) Maryland				
12 MIAMI				
11 BC	DUKE	NC STATE	(B) Minnesota	VIRGINIA
10 SYRACUSE	GA TECH	LOUISVILLE	CLEMSON	MIAMI
9 PITTSBURGH	NC STATE	Marshall	SYRACUSE	FLORIDA ST
8 Notre Dame	MIAMI	Rutgers	MIAMI	LOUISVILLE
7 WVU	PITTSBURGH	Purdue	Rutgers	GA TECH
6 VIRGINIA	UNC	(B) Tulane	Vanderbilt	WAKE FOREST
5 DUKE	WVU	VIRGINIA	VIRGINIA	Old Dominion
4 GA TECH	Old Dominion	BC	GA TECH	Vanderbilt
3 Richmond (FCS)	Liberty	SYRACUSE	BC	S. Carolina
2 M. Tennessee	Wofford (FCS)	WAKE FOREST	STANFORD	CALIFORNIA
1 UNC	BC	PITTSBURGH	Old Dominion	NC STATE
		Old Dominion	Marshall	Wofford (FCS)
2021	2022	2023	2024	2025
FUENTE	BRENT PRY			

VIRGINIA TECH				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
S. CAROLINA L 11-24	8	-2	32.1	
VANDERBILT L 20-44	-242	1	10.8	
OLD DOMINION L 26-45	-93	-1	17.7	
Wofford (FCS) W 38-6	320	0	71.0	
NC STATE W 23-21	107	0	68.8	
WAKE FOREST L 23-30	-84	0	28.6	
GA TECH L 20-35	-114	-1	20.6	
CALIFORNIA W 42-34	151	-1	65.5	
LOUISVILLE L 16-28	-131	1	26.4	
FLORIDA ST L 14-34	-68	-2	20.1	
MIAMI L 17-34	-23	-1	29.5	
VIRGINIA L 7-27	-183	-2	14.6	
OVERALL: 61st / 68	ACC: 14th / 17		33.8	

VIRGINIA TECH		UNIT RANKS	
ACC RANK	NATIONAL		
(of 17)	TOP 15		
QUARTERBACK	7		
RUNNING BACKS	9		
RECEIVERS & TE	7		
OFFENSIVE LINE	10		
DEFENSIVE LINE	4		
LINEBACKERS	10		
DEFENSIVE BACKS	9		

VIRGINIA TECH		RANK	
Scoring Offense	21.4 ppg	114	
Points per Play	0.34	108	
Total Offense	349 ypg	97	
Yards per Play	5.5	84	
Rushing Offense	182 ypg	34	
Yards per Carry	4.9	28	
O-Line Run Push	4.8	12	
Explosive Rush	6.7	29	
Passing Offense	166 ypg	119	
Yards / Attempt	6.2	124	
QB Rating	121	112	
TD / INT Ratio	1.9	77	
Sacks / Attempt	9%	114	
Explosive Pass	6.1	89	
Return. Production	71%	9	
Returning Snaps	14,394	20	
27.2 SECONDS/PLAY #44 of 68 P4			
FRANKLIN (2024 PENN STATE)			

Virginia Tech lost the opener to Shane Beamer's South Carolina program – with a dose of their old Beamerball – then collapsed in the second half against Vanderbilt. After halftime they were outscored 34-0, and then opened up the next game with a 28-0 halftime deficit.

That 62-0 run over four quarters brought a chorus of boos from the home crowd in Lane Stadium, the 0-3 start was the program's worst since 1987, and the next day Brent Pry was fired.

Pry finished with a 16-24 overall record which was the worst here since the 1970s and third-worst all-time. Worse than the record, the two main strategic goals with the hire were totally missed: defensive excellence and a resurgence of in-state recruiting.

With an "elite coordinator, first-time head coach" hire, that side of the ball is expected to be strong enough on its own. Instead, Virginia Tech's defense never placed in the Top 25 of my opponent-adjusted metrics and had a four-year average of just #39 of 68 Power 4.

In-state recruiting came up short, too. The state of Virginia produced 40 four-stars over Pry's tenure. Penn State signed seven, UNC signed six, Clemson took four ... and Virginia Tech got just three of them. In his final game, Pry's starting 22 only featured three former Virginia high school prospects.

Young, inexperienced coordinator hires, broken offensive lines, and struggles in one-score games (1-12 record) were other consistent themes.

By moving early in what would become the most crowded coaching carousel of all-time, Virginia Tech ended up hiring one of the most proven head coaches in college football in Penn State's James Franklin.

Franklin was fired at Penn State after a 3-3 start to what was seen as a "National Title or Bust" season for the program. That doesn't discount his long-term success there – 104-45 (.697) record at Penn State – and his program turnaround at Vanderbilt before that.

Virginia Tech added a significant financial commitment of \$229 million over four years to primarily boost football resources. The funds are a perfect match with Franklin's strong track record recruiting VA and the surrounding region.

Franklin went on ESPN's *College Gameday* and declared he would win a national title at his next school. Whether or not that goal comes to fruition, this home run hire signals Virginia Tech is serious about returning to their winning ways from the Beamer Era.

OFFENSE

In an attempt to continue what was working for him, there are Penn State connections all over the place. Franklin brought his co-offensive coordinator Ty Howle, quarterbacks coach Danny O'Brien, 12 transfers off the Penn State roster, and he flipped 11 former Penn State commits to sign with Virginia Tech.

The most important transfer of all is at quarterback with former Top100 four-star Ethan Grunkemeyer taking over after starting the last seven games for Penn State. He was rated the #7 quarterback of the 2024 recruiting class and the #13 transfer quarterback this cycle.

Grunkemeyer was thrown into action as a redshirt freshman once Drew Allar was lost for the season, and the pocket passer completed a high 69% of passes. Even after accounting for screens and short passes, he was sharp as a first-time starter and should get a second-year bonus here. They also signed dual-threat Bryce Baker (UNC) who was also a Top100 four-star from the 2025 class.

Virginia Tech didn't use the tight ends enough in the pass game last year but that will change given Howle's success with the position at Penn State. Co-starter Benji Gosnell returns, but the staff brought two Penn State tight ends with them. Luke Reynolds was ranked a five-star as the #1 tight end in the entire 2024 recruiting class, and again was named the #1 top transfer at the position.

VIRGINIA TECH		OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)									
O	37	41	28	66	48	9	35	29	55	39	44th
F	Montgomery	TYLER BOWEN				BRAD CORNELSEN					
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR
D	SIEFKES	CHRIS MARVE			JUSTIN HAMILTON		BUD FOSTER				
E	44	33	37	43	52	52	40	66	21	15	44th
F											

VIRGINIA TECH		RANK	
Scoring Defense	30.2 ppg	107	
Points per Play	0.47	117	
Total Defense	378 ypg	71	
Yards per Play	5.9	95	
3rd Down Conv%	45%	125	
Rushing Defense	153 ypg	75	
Yards per Carry	4.3	79	
Negative Play %	8%	92	
Explosive Rush	6.8	80	
Passing Defense	225 ypg	81	
Yards / Attempt	7.8	114	
QB Rating	147	116	
Completion %	67.2%	128	
Explosive Pass	6.4	91	
Return. Production	67%	8	
Returning Snaps	14,045	16	

VIRGINIA TECH		RANK / 68	
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play			
Offense Overall		37	
Rushing Offense	1.1	11	
Passing Offense	(11.7)	61	
Defense Overall		44	
Rushing Defense	0.2	42	
Passing Defense	(13.5)	62	

Woodson and Jaden Keller both depart, Noah Chambers impressed as a freshman and should earn a starting spot. He'll be challenged by Penn State transfer Keon Wylie.

Entering 2025, the secondary had to replace their elite duo of Mansoor Delane and Dorian Strong and then Dante Lovett entered the portal after four games. As expected, the pass defense took a statistical hit and dropped 75 spots in Opponent QB Rating down to #116, and #114 in yards/attempt.

Tyson Flowers, Jordan Bass, and original starter Quentin Reddish are all back at safety but this position needs to improve on tackling. The corners also return with Thomas Williams and Isaiah Brown-Murray and they will be pushed by two-year UConn starter Cam Chadwick and All-Sun Belt Jaquez White (Troy).

OUTLOOK

Virginia Tech hit a home run with the Franklin hire and he brought 12 Penn Staters and 11 more flipped commits with him. Their roster talent is improved and in the blink of an eye, Virginia Tech seems poised for a program revival.

With so many other ACC teams losing stars to the transfer portal, Virginia Tech was an example that benefitted from it and they earn a spot in my ACC top five.

Marcellous Hawkins returns after leading the team in rushing with 749 yards and his explosive 6.4 per-carry average is the highest among returning ACC backs with 100+ carries. Jeff Overton flashed as a freshman, and 5'9 250-pound bowling ball Bill Davis (UL-Lafayette) earned All-Sun Belt honors.

Ayden Greene is back at outside receiver and the staff added four more to the room. Que'Sean Brown (Duke) earned four-star transfer grades and will start in the slot after catching 107 balls (just two drops) the past two seasons. Tyseer Denmark and Jeff Exinor are both Penn State transfers who will join the rotation, and backup slot Takye Heath returns.

The offensive line is the biggest rebuilding project on offense and needs to improve on pass protection after finishing #114 in sack rate – and that was *with* mobile Kyron Drones at quarterback. Center Kyle Altuner and guard Layth Ghannam are returning starters, Montavious Cunningham started four games at guard, and Brody Meadows is back from injury. The tackle spots are wide open with an influx of three-star transfers from Power 4 rosters: Logan Howland (Oklahoma), Michael Troutman (Penn State), Justin Terry (Ohio State), Justin Bell (Michigan State).

DEFENSE

In a rare twist, Pry was actually re-hired by Virginia Tech three months after being fired. Franklin picked him as his defensive coordinator with hopes of recreating what worked together at Penn State when all six of his defenses finished in the Top 25 from 2016 to 2021.

The staff pumped the defensive line with transfers to jumpstart the transition. They signed four former four-star defensive ends and a fifth Samuel Okunlola who had productive starting experience at Colorado and Pittsburgh. Former Top100 prospect Javion Hilson (Missouri) is the headliner and is projected to start opposite of returner Ayden Stevens. Cortez Harris, Mylachi Williams, and Daniel Jennings are all redshirt freshmen who followed the staff from Penn State.

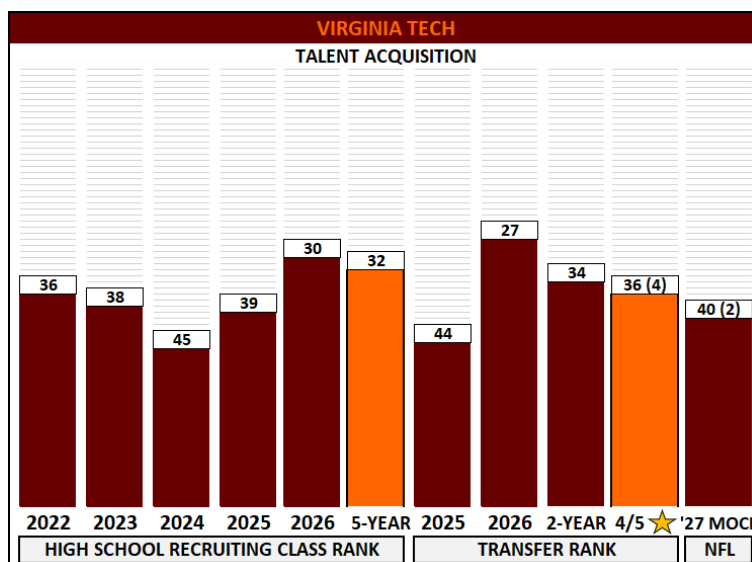
The defensive tackle starters both return with Elhadj Fall moving back inside and Kemari Copeland poised for All-ACC consideration.

Leading tackler Kaleb Spencer returns at inside backer, and although Caleb

VIRGINIA TECH	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 5	VMI (FCS)
S. 12	OLD DOMINION
S. 19	@ Maryland
S. 26	@ Boston Coll.
O. 2	PITTSBURGH
O. 10	@ California
O. 17	GEORGIA TECH
O. 24	@ Clemson
O. 31	--- BYE ---
N. 6	@ SMU
N. 14	STANFORD
N. 21	@ Miami
N. 28	VIRGINIA

VIRGINIA TECH		RANK / 68	
All-Time Wins	782	18	
All-Time Win %	0.597	22	
Wins (Last 100)	609	29	
Wins (Last 50)	374	22	
Wins (Last 25)	202	19	
Wins (Last 10)	63	43	
Wins (Last 5)	25	63	
Game Grader (10 yr)	47.1	46	
Game Grader (5 yr)	41.4	60	
Game Grader (3 yr)	46.2	42	
Draft Picks s' 2000	91	21	
Draft Picks s' 2010	44	32	
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		49	
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		63	

VIRGINIA TECH		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
33.8 (61)	52.8 (34)	52 (36)	28.7 (62)	39.7 (55)	46.8 (37)	49.1 (37)	39 (58)	63.2 (19)	66.1 (13)	47.1 (46)	



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VIRGINIA

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#6

ACC

#35

OVERALL



VIRGINIA				
5-YEAR WIN TREND				
14				(CG) Duke
13				WAKE FOREST
12	VA TECH		VA TECH	NC State
11	PITTSBURGH		LOUISVILLE	(B) Missouri
10	Notre Dame	PITTSBURGH	GA TECH	VA TECH
9	BYU	UNC	MIAMI	UNC
8	WAKE FOREST	MIAMI	BC	CLEMSON
7	UNC	LOUISVILLE	NC STATE	LOUISVILLE
6	GA TECH	DUKE	Maryland	Maryland
5	DUKE	SYRACUSE	JMU	PITTSBURGH
4	LOUISVILLE	Illinois	Tennessee	BC
3	MIAMI	GA TECH	DUKE	Coastal Car.
2	Illinois	Old Dominion	UNC	WAKE FOREST
1	W&M (FCS)	Richmond (FCS)	W&M (FCS)	Richmond (FCS)
2021		2022	2023	2024
MENDENHALL		TONY ELLIOTT		

VIRGINIA				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
C. CAROLINA W 48-7	200	3	80.8	
NC STATE L 31-35	98	-1	54.8	
W&M (FCS) W 55-16	437	-1	74.8	
STANFORD W 48-20	269	1	86.4	
FLORIDA ST W 46-38	-74	0	58.8	
LOUISVILLE W 30-27	-146	2	49.4	
WASH. ST W 22-20	-17	2	50.0	
UNC W 17-16	-94	2	36.7	
CALIFORNIA W 31-21	193	2	70.9	
WAKE FOREST L 9-16	124	-3	44.0	
DUKE W 34-17	285	-1	94.7	
VA TECH W 27-7	183	2	77.8	
(CG) DUKE L 20-27	11	-1	37.8	
(B) MISSOURI W 13-7	48	0	74.8	
OVERALL: 17th / 68	ACC: 2nd / 17	63.7		

VIRGINIA		UNIT RANKS	
ACC RANK	NATIONAL		
(of 17)	TOP 15		
QUARTERBACK	8		
RUNNING BACKS	12		
RECEIVERS & TE	12		
OFFENSIVE LINE	4		
DEFENSIVE LINE	7		
LINEBACKERS	4		
DEFENSIVE BACKS	8		

VIRGINIA		RANK	
Scoring Offense	30.8 ppg	39	
Points per Play	0.41	59	
Total Offense	418 ypg	29	
Yards per Play	5.6	74	
Rushing Offense	179 ypg	38	
Yards per Carry	4.6	49	
O-Line Run Push	4.2	77	
Explosive Rush	4.7	97	
Passing Offense	239 ypg	56	
Yards / Attempt	6.8	86	
QB Rating	129	80	
TD / INT Ratio	1.8	80	
Sacks / Attempt	4%	11	
Explosive Pass	5.8	100	
Return. Production	55%	65	
Returning Snaps	20,870	1	
25.6 SECONDS/PLAY #22 of 68 P4			
ELLIOTT (2025 VIRGINIA)			

Rather than start over with a coaching change, Virginia doubled down on head coach Tony Elliott and they rallied up enough financial commitment to sign a Top 25 transfer class.

Their strategy was to target transfers with significant game experience – no matter the level – over former top recruits who hadn't gotten onto the field yet.

Elliott won 11 games in his first three seasons combined from 2022 to 2024. But with 50+ new players, the 2025 team doubled that total, clinched the school's first 11-win season and reinvigorated the UVA fan base. They earned the nickname "Cardiac Cavs" after a wild string of close wins to keep their ACC title hopes alive.

Reminiscent of their major upset wins in 1995 and 2005, Virginia hosted #8 Florida State and won the 46-38 overtime shootout. As the final pass hit the turf, UVA fans swarmed the field faster than I've ever seen.

Then they did it with defense. Virginia had two defensive scores in an overtime win over Louisville, got a game-winning safety in the final minute to beat Washington State 22-20, and then stuffed UNC at the goal-line on a game-deciding two-point attempt. Then, Kam Robinson grabbed a Pick Six in the final thirty seconds to hold off California's comeback attempt.

Five games – three overtime wins, and all five decided in the final minute. This run got them to an 8-1 start, their first Top 15 ranking since 2004, and their longest winning streak since 2007.

In front of 58,800 fans they dominated Virginia Tech 27-7 to win the Commonwealth Cup for just the second time in 21 years. After years of fan apathy, Scott Stadium came alive. Even better, the win punched their ticket to Charlotte for the ACC title game with a Playoff berth on the line.

Even though they dominated Duke a few weeks earlier, the rematch wasn't a repeat. In fact Duke beat them with their own formula: ball control, clutch overtime moments, and a game-ending defensive turnover. The Gator Bowl win over Missouri got UVA to their 11-win milestone and this goes down as an all-time season for the school.

Though not even the most optimistic Virginia fan could have predicted 11 wins, the expectations shifted so quickly that there will be a feel of missed opportunity mixed in. A 7-5 opponent they already beat by 17 was the only barrier to their first ACC outright title and first Playoff appearance.

OFFENSE

After a taste of postseason football, can Elliott make it two-in-a-row? On offense, it is a complete rebuild as they have to replace their quarterback, top two running backs, top three receivers, All-ACC tight end, and two linemen.

When a program ascends to an all-time season, the hope is that an influx of talent would follow. Instead, Virginia finished the 2026 talent acquisition cycle as the only Power 4 program to not sign a single four-star recruit or four-star transfer.

Rankings aside, I'd say they did well reloading at quarterback. Chandler Morris threw for 3,000 yards and powered their fast start but was denied an extra year of eligibility. The staff signed *two* former Power 4 starters in Beau Pribula (Missouri) and Eli Holstein (Pittsburgh). Pribula was Drew Allar's backup at Penn State then won the starting job at Missouri and posted a 2,000-yard, 11 touchdown (9 picks) season, and added 10 carries/game. Holstein won the Pitt job in 2024 and got them off to a 7-0 start before cooling off and then eventually getting benched four games into 2025.

Pribula brings a dual-threat skillset and is the projected starter, though Holstein has more game experience, a higher QB Rating, and big stat line: 3,306 yards & 29 touchdowns over the 1.5 seasons.

Virginia finally established a traditional run game and J'Mari Taylor took a 200-carry workload and earned first-team All-ACC honors. Taylor and #2 back Harrison Waylee are both gone, and Elliott mentioned he wants to return to more of a "committee" approach. Peyton Lewis (Tennessee) is a former Top200 prospect and a Top 10 running back from the 2024 class. Jekail Middlebrook (Middle Tennessee) earned All-CUSA honors after his 750-yard season and can help in the pass game with 40 catches last year. Veteran Xavier Brown is also back from injury to round out the trio.

VIRGINIA		OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)									
O		51	62	49	58	11	47	32	47	60	61
F											59th
F		DESMOND KITCHINGS					ROBERT ANAE				
		2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016
D		JOHN RUDZINSKI					NICK HOWELL				
E		20	55	53	17	63	58	48	26	37	51
F											53rd

VIRGINIA		RANK	
Scoring Defense	19.6 ppg	22	
Points per Play	0.31	32	
Total Defense	310 ypg	20	
Yards per Play	4.9	25	
3rd Down Conv%	28%	2	
Rushing Defense	114 ypg	22	
Yards per Carry	3.4	21	
Negative Play %	8%	83	
Explosive Rush	4.6	17	
Passing Defense	196 ypg	33	
Yards / Attempt	6.6	40	
QB Rating	121	33	
Completion %	59.5%	37	
Explosive Pass	5.7	66	
Return. Production	62%	20	
Returning Snaps	18,288	2	

VIRGINIA		RANK / 68
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play		
Offense Overall		51
Rushing Offense	0.3	26
Passing Offense	(4.0)	50
Defense Overall		20
Rushing Defense	0.9	18
Passing Defense	15.7	19

linemen are gone, they rotated this group more than most, so they do return three with high experience. Fisher Camac had 6.5 tackles for loss and 4.5 sacks and could push for All-ACC consideration off the edge, and the tackle pair of Anthony Britton and Jason Hammond returns. The staff added veteran Matthew Fobbs-White (Baylor) and former four-star Devon Baxter (Michigan) to the end rotation.

There's plenty of shuffling in the secondary with two corners transferring out with high grades – Ja'Son Prevard (Kansas State) and Emmanuel Karnley (Washington) – plus All-ACC safety Devin Neal heading pro. Ethan Minter and nickel Corey Costner are returning starters, and the staff added 130 career starts (10,000+ career snaps) of experience via the portal. Brandyn Hillman (Michigan) and Jacobie Henderson (Rutgers) both graded as high three-star transfers and are projected to earn starting spots.

OUTLOOK

Though Virginia loses plenty of starters, they stayed with their veteran-transfer strategy and reloaded both sides -- their 2026 roster is #1 nationally in career snaps.

The Cardiac Cavs used up a lot of magic last season so while a return to Charlotte is unlikely, Elliott has elevated the program's floor and they remain a top-half ACC team.

VIRGINIA		RANK / 68
All-Time Wins	699	37
All-Time Win %	0.517	50
Wins (Last 100)	489	58
Wins (Last 50)	294	49
Wins (Last 25)	144	54
Wins (Last 10)	58	51
Wins (Last 5)	28	55
Game Grader (10 yr)	42.3	55
Game Grader (5 yr)	41.6	59
Game Grader (3 yr)	43.7	54
Draft Picks s' 2000	52	48
Draft Picks s' 2010	20	64
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		61
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		27

The receiver core needs to be fully rebuilt with the top three departing: Jahmal Edrine and a pair of All-ACC stars Trell Harris and Cam Ross. Kam Courtney is the leading returning receiver and should start in the slot. Isaiah Robinson got action in the bowl game and will battle incoming transfers Jacquon Gibson (UMass) and Rico Flores (UCLA). Gibson ranked 11th nationally with 6.3 catches/game, while Flores was a starter most of the season for UCLA.

The offensive line's improvement was a key factor in the 11-win season. They gave up 47 sacks in 2024 but cut that to 18 in 2025 for a jump from #127 all the way up to #11 in Sack Rate. The line helped establish the run, and they rushed for 200+ in three straight games for the first time since 2004. Virginia loses its headliner in second-team All-ACC center Brady Wilson, but gets two more all-league linemen back with tackle McKale Boley and guard Noah Josey. Drake Metcalf shifts over to center, and the two openings should be filled by 2025 highly-rated transfers Monroe Mills and Makilan Thomas who were both injured in fall camp last year.

DEFENSE

The offense led the fast start to the season, but once it slowed down, the defense rose to the occasion. This is a strange twist on "complementary football," per my opponent-adjusted metrics:

- UVA Offense, first seven games: #30 of 68 Power 4 then #60 final seven
- UVA Defense, first seven games: #45 of 68 Power 4 then #5 final seven

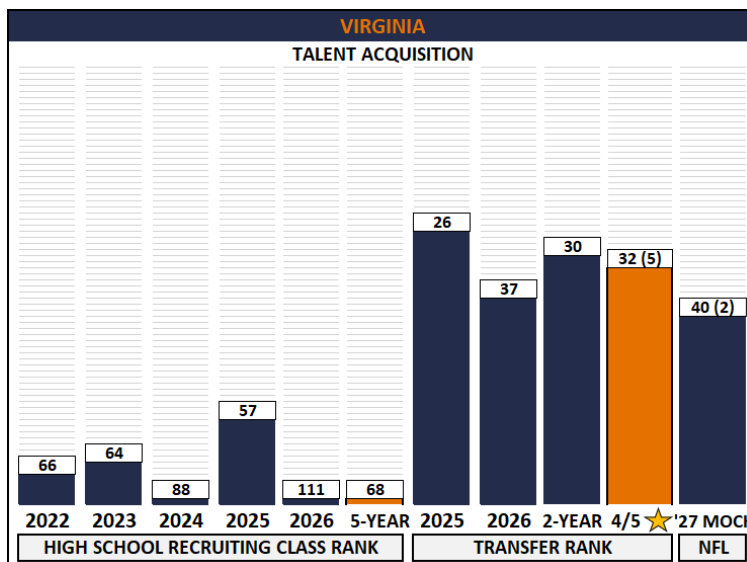
It starts with do-it-all linebacker Kam Robinson who was trending as a candidate for ACC Defensive Player of the Year before an ACL tear cut his season short. He became the only FBS player in the past 20 years with a Pick Six, blocked punt, and fumble touchdown. Throw in a game-winning safety to beat Washington State and this was arguably the most impactful defender in the league.

Robinson's rehab timeline may keep him out of a few early games, but Virginia returns the whole room. Maddox Marcellus returns and Landon Danley is back after filling in well for Robinson.

Virginia loses a pair of All-ACC defensive linemen with tackle Jahmeer Carter and end Mitchell Melton both graduating. While five of the eight two-deep

VIRGINIA	
2026 SCHEDULE	
A. 29	NC STATE
S. 5	--- BYE ---
S. 11	NORFOLK ST (FCS)
S. 19	*WVU (CLT)
S. 26	DELAWARE
O. 3	@ Florida State
O. 10	SYRACUSE
O. 17	@ SMU
O. 23	DUKE
O. 31	@ Wake Forest
N. 7	--- BYE ---
N. 14	CALIFORNIA
N. 21	UNC
N. 28	@ Virginia Tech

VIRGINIA		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	2015	10-YEAR
63.7 (17)	33.2 (61)	34.1 (58)	32.2 (59)	45 (48)	41.1 (47)	49.8 (36)	55.4 (27)	41 (51)	27.4 (64)	42.3 (55)	





NC STATE

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#7

ACC

#41

OVERALL



NC STATE				
5-YEAR WIN TREND				
13		(B) Maryland	(B) Kansas St	(B) E. Carolina
12	WAKE FOREST	LOUISVILLE	DUKE	GA TECH
11	MIAMI	BC	LOUISVILLE	DUKE
10	Miss State	SYRACUSE	Notre Dame	SYRACUSE
9	UNC	CLEMSON	UNC	WAKE FOREST
8	SYRACUSE	UNC	VA TECH	CLEMSON
7	FSU	WAKE FOREST	WAKE FOREST	Tennessee
6	LOUISVILLE	VA TECH	MIAMI	UNC
5	BC	FSU	CLEMSON	FLORIDA ST
4	LA Tech	UConn	Marshall	GA TECH
3	CLEMSON	Texas Tech	VIRGINIA	Campbell (FCS)
2	Furman (FCS)	Charl. S (FCS)	VMi (FCS)	WAKE FOREST
1	USF	E. Carolina	UConn	LA Tech
			W Carolina (FCS)	Virginia
				E. Carolina
	2021	2022	2023	2024
				2025
	DAVE DOEREN			

NC STATE					
2025 RESULTS		Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
E. CAROLINA	W	24-17	10	-1	59.8
VIRGINIA	W	35-31	-98	1	53.7
WAKE FOREST	W	34-24	95	2	75.7
DUKE	L	33-45	117	-4	41.9
VA TECH	L	21-23	-107	0	31.7
Campbell (FCS)	W	56-10	419	-1	75.8
NOTRE DAME	L	7-36	-252	-1	5.4
PITTSBURGH	L	34-53	-84	0	22.4
GA TECH	W	48-36	24	1	76.3
MIAMI	L	7-41	-438	-1	2.0
FLORIDA ST	W	21-11	-97	4	64.6
UNC	W	42-19	121	1	73.8
(B) MEMPHIS	W	31-7	20	2	71.3
OVERALL: 40th / 68 ACC: 11th / 17 50.3					

NC STATE			UNIT RANKS	
ACC RANK		NATIONAL		
(of 17)		TOP 15		
QUARTERBACK	4			
RUNNING BACKS	7			
RECEIVERS & TE	9			
OFFENSIVE LINE	8			
DEFENSIVE LINE	12			
LINEBACKERS	9			
DEFENSIVE BACKS	5			

NC STATE			RANK
Scoring Offense	30.2 ppg	45	
Points per Play	0.47	35	
Total Offense	391 ypg	66	
Yards per Play	6.1	35	
Rushing Offense	145 ypg	81	
Yards per Carry	4.4	62	
O-Line Run Push	4.1	84	
Explosive Rush	5.9	44	
Passing Offense	246 ypg	49	
Yards / Attempt	7.7	42	
QB Rating	149	28	
TD / INT Ratio	2.6	45	
Sacks / Attempt	6%	58	
Explosive Pass	7.5	45	
Return. Production	62%	39	
Returning Snaps	11,066	49	
26.9 SECONDS/PLAY #42 of 68 P4			
ROPER (2025 NC STATE)			

Head coach Dave Doeren did it again. Like clockwork, he finds ways to scrape out the most of his roster, overcome injury runs, and of course, beat UNC. NC State beat their rival for the fifth straight time, beat Florida State for the fourth straight time, ended #8 Georgia Tech's undefeated season, and won four of their last five.

After a 4-4 start and midseason defensive collapse, Doeren got NC State to yet another 8-win season – their fifth in six years.

In the process, they found a star quarterback to build the program around. In his first full season as the starter, CJ Bailey threw 25 touchdowns, placed third in the ACC in QB Rating, and his 340-yard explosion led the upset win over Georgia Tech. They scored on 8 of 10 drives and got revenge on the 2002 game that ended Philip Rivers' undefeated start.

The ensuing field-storming was the pinnacle of the season and sparked the strong finish.

The injury run on defense exposed some depth/recruiting limitations that NC State faces in the NIL era. It started back before the 2025 season when three established stars transferred out of the secondary: Devan Boykin, Bishop Fitzgerald, and Tamarus Cooley. A roster strength turned into a question mark, and then an injury run destroyed the room in September. NC State finished #132 in passing defense.

And here again entering the 2026 season, NC State was hit with the same problem. Their All-ACC running back, top two receivers, and best offensive linemen all transferred out with high four-star grades – yet they didn't sign any four-star transfers to offset the damage.

OFFENSE

Bailey enters 2026 as an All-ACC candidate and the dual-threat gives NC State a puncher's chance in every game. He posted the program's first 3,000-yard passing season since Devin Leary in 2021 and really caught fire over the final six games with 13 total touchdowns and just two picks. His stat sheet may have looked even better but NC State found a cheat code in short-yardage situations with their bulldozer Will Wilson who powered in 10 rushing touchdowns. The staff will again use Wilson there and we may see more of a passing threat from him in the second year.

The offense ranked in the Top 25 of my three opponent-adjusted metrics – #25 overall, #23 passing, and #19 rushing – but aside from Bailey, program stars must be replaced from every position group.

Hollywood Smothers started fast with multiple 100+ yard games, and despite a lingering injury, he still led the ACC in rushing. He earned first-team All-ACC honors and became NC State's first ACC lead rusher since 1997. Smothers transferred out to Texas as a high four-star and the #2 overall running back this cycle.

In his absence, Duke Scott impressed in his two starts – 196 yards against Georgia Tech and 108 in the bowl win. Scott moves into the top role, Jonathan Paylor is back from injury, and the staff added rotational back Davion Gause (UNC).

The top three wide receivers are all gone, too. Wesley Grimes graduated but two more left with high marks. Terrell Anderson led with 629 yards and transferred to USC as a Top 10 ranked transfer WR. Noah Rogers also got a four-star grade and left for Alabama.

The staff signed a pair of former high school blue-chips – Jojo Trader and Chance Robinson – who were teammates at Miami. Trader was originally a near five-star and was in the receiver rotation last year for the Hurricanes. They also signed first-team All-MAC Victor Snow (Buffalo) and a pair of incoming four-star true freshmen Amiri Acker and Tyreek Copper who posted a video-game senior season: 105 catches, 2,245 yards, 33 touchdown catches. Teddy Hoffmann is the lead returner after putting up 349 yards as a true freshman last year.

NC STATE										OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)	
O	25	24	47	65	31	45	62	31	23	32	46th
F	ROPER	ROBERT ANAE	TIM BECK	KITCHINGS	ELIAH DRINKWITZ						
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR
D	ELIOT	TONY GIBSON	DAVE HUXTABLE								
E	55	59	38	26	10	28	44	57	40	17	36th
F											

NC STATE		RANK	
Scoring Defense	27.2 ppg	83	
Points per Play	0.4	82	
Total Defense	412 ypg	111	
Yards per Play	6.0	112	
3rd Down Conv%	46%	128	
Rushing Defense	139 ypg	52	
Yards per Carry	4.3	80	
Negative Play %	7%	97	
Explosive Rush	7.0	88	
Passing Defense	273 ypg	132	
Yards / Attempt	7.6	102	
QB Rating	138	93	
Completion %	62.8%	79	
Explosive Pass	6.1	83	
Return. Production	46%	84	
Returning Snaps	8,362	80	

NC STATE		RANK / 68	
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play			
Offense Overall		25	
Rushing Offense	0.6	19	
Passing Offense	14.6	23	
Defense Overall		55	
Rushing Defense	0.2	47	
Passing Defense	1.5	41	

Brian Nelson is back at one corner spot but they lose their top cover corner in Devon Marshall. Ondre Evans (Georgia) is a former Top100 recruit and should fill into Marshall's spot.

The safety room was destroyed by the portal in the preseason, and then hit harder by injuries early in the season. This was the key reason why the defense fell apart and gave up five 300-yard passing games. The silver lining is that all those young guys thrown into action ahead-of-schedule are back, and that experience should pay dividends in 2026. Asaad Brown started ten games, Tristan Teasdel started the final five, and both freshmen are back. Original starter Ronnie Royal and nickelback Jackson Vick both return, they added Penn State starter King Mack, so look for fall camp competition and hopefully a second-year bonus for the room.

OUTLOOK

Just like last offseason, NC State lost another round of program stars to the transfer portal and failed to add back any four-stars. They remain in the top-half of the conference thanks to do-it-all quarterback CJ Bailey and the league's best schedule draw.

NC State only plays one of the ACC's top five, and gets six of the bottom seven.

First-team All-ACC tight end Justin Joly set program records but now heads to the pros along with top blocking tight end Cody Hardy. The staff added two transfers here in former Top200 Vander Ploog (Oregon) and Top 10 transfer Hunter Provience (Montana State).

Jacarrius Peak seemed like an All-ACC candidate but instead transferred out to South Carolina with a four-star grade. They did retain a rising star in Freshman All-American Spike Sowell who was the school's highest graded offensive line recruit of the past decade.

Teague Andersen returns at right tackle, and former four-star TK Whitset is drawing high praise. The staff added two key transfers in first-team All-AAC left tackle Jimarion McCrimon (East Carolina) and center Daniel Cruz (Texas).

DEFENSE

Injuries and the talent drain in the secondary ended up catching up to the defense. NC State fell to 55th of 68 Power 4 in my opponent-adjusted metric and were plagued by missed tackles, lack of a pass rush, and poor third-down defense (#128).

The entire front six is gone, leaving behind a rebuilding project for defensive coordinator DJ Eliot.

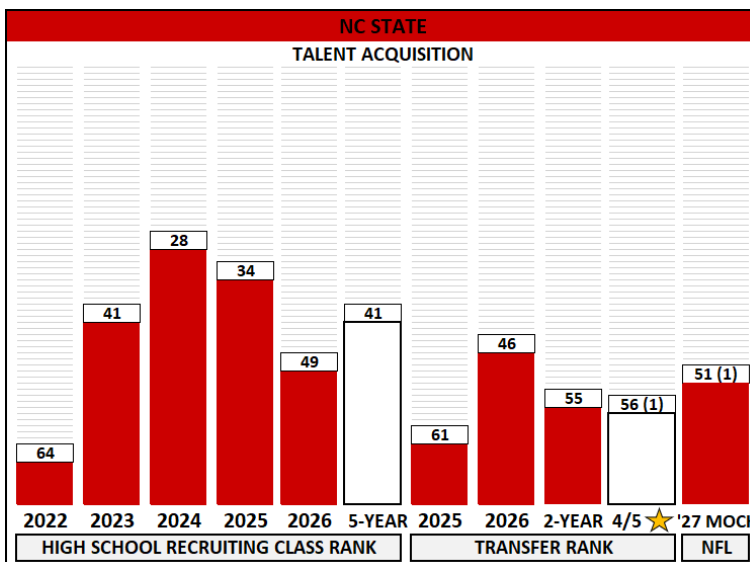
All three line starters graduated and the trio of Brandon Cleveland, Travali Price, and Sabastian Harsh combined for 1,600+ snaps. Isaiah Shirley and Chase Bond move up from their backup roles, and the staff added third-team All-ACC Harvey Dyson (Tulane) at edge.

Caden Fordham returned from a 2024 injury to lead all of Power 4 in tackles (130) and earn first-team All-ACC honors. Fordham is gone along with original starter Sean Brown but the staff added two Power 4 transfers who project as starters this fall. Popo Aguirre was Miami's third backer and will start in the middle, while former four-star Da'Karri Nelson (Penn State) is projected at outside backer. NC State also gets back Sterling Dixon, the former Alabama transfer who was injured for the 2025 season, at outside backer or edge.

NC STATE	
2026 SCHEDULE	
A. 29	@ Virginia
S. 5	--- BYE ---
S. 11	RICHMOND (FCS)
S. 19	@ Vanderbilt
S. 26	APP STATE
O. 3	LOUISVILLE
O. 10	WAKE FOREST
O. 17	--- BYE ---
O. 23	@ Stanford
O. 31	CALIFORNIA
N. 7	DUKE
N. 14	SYRACUSE
N. 21	@ Florida State
N. 28	@ UNC

NC STATE		RANK / 68	
All-Time Wins	652	45	
All-Time Win %	0.516	52	
Wins (Last 100)	548	45	
Wins (Last 50)	329	33	
Wins (Last 25)	176	36	
Wins (Last 10)	77	22	
Wins (Last 5)	40	25	
Game Grader (10 yr)	49.9	34	
Game Grader (5 yr)	50.4	35	
Game Grader (3 yr)	47.1	41	
Draft Picks s' 2000	67	36	
Draft Picks s' 2010	40	37	
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		53	
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		21	

NC STATE		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
50.3 (40)	38.7 (56)	52.3 (35)	46.7 (47)	63.8 (14)	44.9 (39)	28.9 (63)	55.3 (28)	63.6 (17)	55 (26)	49.9 (34)	



WEEKLY, IN-SEASON FEATURE -- ADVANCED STATS & INFO

SAMPLE PDF, INFO, AND ORDERS AT PICKSIXPREVIEWS.COM/PLUS



PITTSBURGH

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#8(TIE) #39

ACC

OVERALL



PITTSBURGH				
5-YEAR WIN TREND				
14 (B) Mich St	UNC	(B) Toledo	(B) E. Carolina	
13 MIAMI	LOUISVILLE	BC	MIAMI	
12 W. Michigan	GA TECH	LOUISVILLE	Notre Dame	
11 (CG) WAKE	Tennessee	CLEMSON	LOUISVILLE	
10 SYRACUSE	(B) UCLA	VIRGINIA	West Virginia	
9 VIRGINIA	MIAMI	SMU	GA TECH	
8 UNC	DUKE	SYRACUSE	STANFORD	
7 DUKE	DUKE	CAL	NC STATE	
6 CLEMSON	VIRGINIA	UNC	SYRACUSE	
5 VA TECH	SYRACUSE	Ytown St (FCS)	FLORIDA ST	
4 GA TECH	VA TECH	West Virginia	BC	
3 New Hamp. (FCS)	Rhode Isl. (FCS)	Cincinnati	C. Michigan	
2 Tennessee	W. Michigan	BC	Duquesne (FCS)	
1 UMass	West Virginia	LOUISVILLE		
		Wofford (FCS)		
2021	2022	2023	2024	2025
PAT NARDUZZI				

PITTSBURGH				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
Duquesne (FCS) W 61-9	252	-1	74.8	
C. MICHIGAN W 45-17	247	0	77.2	
W. VIRGINIA L 24-31	-85	1	24.3	
LOUISVILLE L 27-34	-53	-4	33.2	
BOSTON COLL. W 48-7	287	3	92.1	
FLORIDA ST W 34-31	61	-1	62.1	
SYRACUSE W 30-13	43	2	62.8	
NC STATE W 53-34	84	0	89.2	
STANFORD W 35-20	140	-1	68.8	
NOTRE DAME L 15-37	-168	1	18.7	
GA TECH W 42-28	34	2	80.0	
MIAMI L 7-38	-187	0	6.8	
(B) E. CAROLINA L 17-23	127	-4	47.3	
OVERALL: 29th / 68	ACC: 6th / 17	56.7		

PITTSBURGH		UNIT RANKS	
ACC RANK	NATIONAL		
(of 17)	TOP 15		
QUARTERBACK	5		
RUNNING BACKS	11		
RECEIVERS & TE	15		
OFFENSIVE LINE	9		
DEFENSIVE LINE	5		
LINEBACKERS	7		
DEFENSIVE BACKS	4		

PITTSBURGH		RANK
Scoring Offense	33.7 ppg	20
Points per Play	0.49	24
Total Offense	391 ypg	68
Yards per Play	5.7	67
Rushing Offense	117 ypg	115
Yards per Carry	3.5	119
O-Line Run Push	4.2	73
Explosive Rush	4.8	89
Passing Offense	273 ypg	20
Yards / Attempt	7.7	44
QB Rating	141	52
TD / INT Ratio	1.9	75
Sacks / Attempt	9%	121
Explosive Pass	7.5	47
Return. Production	60%	49
Returning Snaps	12,371	34
24.1 SECONDS/PLAY	#9 of 68 P4	
BELL (2025 PITTSBURGH)	FAST	

Pat Narduzzi made a surprise move at quarterback and it ended up salvaging Pittsburgh's 2025 season.

Eli Holstein, after going 7-2 as the starter last year, threw three picks in Pitt's two September losses. They blew a 10-point lead in the Backyard Brawl overtime loss and then again wasted a 17-point lead against Louisville.

Riding a seven-game losing streak vs. Power 4 opponents, Narduzzi made the switch.

True freshman Mason Heintschel took over and lit up Boston College for 323 passing yards and four touchdowns in the 48-7 win. The 18-year-old played with poise and elevated the playmakers around him. Pitt rattled off six straight ACC wins – four 300+ passing games for Heintschel – and found themselves in the league title race in late November.

They aced the first test, upsetting Georgia Tech on the road. Pitt raced to a 28-0 lead, and Braylan Lovelace took back a 100-yard Pick Six that effectively shattered Haynes King's Heisman campaign.

Playing for an ACC title bid on the final day of the regular season is certainly a win for the program, but the talent gap was too significant in the 38-7 loss to Miami. Pitt rushed for just 30 rushing yards here, and they were held under 100 rushing yards in their four regular season losses.

OFFENSE

Heintschel finished with 16 touchdowns (eight picks), a 64% completion rate, and placed #2 in Power 4 in QB Rating among true freshmen. Beyond the stat sheet, he impressed with pocket elusiveness, continued to make highlight reel plays, and made everyone around him better.

From 2024 to 2025, Pitt's passing yards/attempt and explosive passing both jumped up 50+ spots.

Look for a second-year bonus here as Heintschel now gets an entire offseason of starter reps. Holstein transferred out to Virginia which officially ends any quarterback battle here.

The offense was expected to rely on 2024 All-American Desmond Reid, the do-it-all playmaker, but he battled injuries and missed five games. Reid put up 200 yards and caught two touchdowns in the Florida State win, and now heads to the pros.

In Reid's absence, another true freshman stepped up big time. Ja'Kyrian Turner rushed for 652 yards, 7 touchdowns, and showed off speed and shiftiness. He rushed for 201 yards in the Georgia Tech win and solidified his starting role for 2026. Backup Juelz Goff transferred to Boise State and the staff added a physical downhill runner in La'Vell Wright (Western Kentucky) who cashed in 10 touchdowns last year. Their top high school signee this cycle -- Top200 four-star Damon Ferguson -- could push for carries.

Heintschel will be throwing to a whole new group of pass-catchers as Pitt loses their top three tight ends and three of their top four receivers. Kenny Johnson emerged as the #1 receiver and also helped flip the Syracuse game with a 66-yard punt return touchdown, but he transferred out to Texas Tech. Raphael Williams and Deuce Spann both graduated, leaving Cataurus "Blue" Hicks as the leader for 2026. Hicks is a big-play speedster (17.6 yards/catch) and Censere Lee was in the rotation in 2024. The staff added another Western Carolina player from the Kade Bell pipeline in All-SOCON Malik Knight.

The tight end room had its most productive season here since 2021 but all three are gone. Carson Kent (Oklahoma) and Elijah Lagg (UAB) both transferred in with three-star grades, but Max Hunt was the surprise spring hero.

The offensive line struggled again, allowing the third-most sacks in FBS (44), and ranked outside the Top 100 in pass protection for the second straight season. The #73 rank in OL Run Push was slightly better but in the four regular season losses they were held under 100 yards each time.

PITTSBURGH					OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)									
O	46	56	50	37	38	60	55	21	39	3				48th
F	KADE BELL		FRANK CIGNETTI		MARK WHIPPLE		SHAWN WATSON		CANADA					
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016				10-YEAR
D	RANDY BATES										JOSH CONKLIN			
E	14	29	25	16	14	5	9	34	49	52				18th
F														

PITTSBURGH		RANK	
Scoring Defense	24.8 ppg	68	
Points per Play	0.36	63	
Total Defense	330 ypg	32	
Yards per Play	4.9	19	
3rd Down Conv%	33%	15	
Rushing Defense	95 ypg	8	
Yards per Carry	2.7	4	
Negative Play %	11%	8	
Explosive Rush	4.3	12	
Passing Defense	235 ypg	100	
Yards / Attempt	7.1	66	
QB Rating	137	86	
Completion %	62.9%	82	
Explosive Pass	6.2	86	
Return. Production	56%	49	
Returning Snaps	11,394	50	

PITTSBURGH		RANK / 68
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play		
Offense Overall		46
Rushing Offense	(0.7)	62
Passing Offense	5.9	38
Defense Overall		14
Rushing Defense	1.3	9
Passing Defense	0.7	44

defensive tackle Francis Brewu left for Notre Dame and was ranked the #8 defensive lineman this cycle. Pitt still returns a pair of strong vets in the interior with Sean FitzSimmons and Nick James.

Jimmy Scott is a third-year starter at defensive end and Isaiah Neal showed he can play both end and tackle after sliding outside last year.

Pitt loses four starters from the secondary with Tamon Lynam, Rashad Battle, Javon McIntyre, and Kavir Bains-Marquez all departing. They did find a young star in Shawn Lee who was named a Freshman All-American by *On3* as a top cover corner. Former WPIAL star Raion Strader (Auburn) transferred home and should start opposite of Lee. Shadarian Harrison is another veteran corner, and hard-hitting safety Cruce Brookins earned All-ACC honorable mention.

OUTLOOK

Heintschel's 6-1 run against the ACC provides optimism for the program going forward, but three areas of uncertainty remain. The offensive line has struggled for several seasons now, in the transfer portal Pitt lost six proven star players yet signed zero four-star transfers (joining Boston College as the only Power 4 programs with zero), and now longtime ace defensive coordinator Randy Bates retired.

Pittsburgh is a solid ACC team but those issues hold them back from title contention.

PITTSBURGH		RANK / 68
All-Time Wins	776	19
All-Time Win %	0.574	29
Wins (Last 100)	587	34
Wins (Last 50)	339	28
Wins (Last 25)	180	31
Wins (Last 10)	72	30
Wins (Last 5)	38	29
Game Grader (10 yr)	50.0	33
Game Grader (5 yr)	51.6	30
Game Grader (3 yr)	44.3	51
Draft Picks s' 2000	70	34
Draft Picks s' 2010	43	33
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		4
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		16

Ryan Baer and BJ Williams both earned ACC honorable mention and return on the right side of the line with 69 combined career starts. The left side was hit with injuries but as a result it's a more experienced unit in 2026. Keith Gouveia was the original starter at left guard, Ryan Carretta and Kendall Stanley each started seven games filling in for injuries, and the staff signed All-MAC Keylen Davis (Akron) and FCS All-America tackle Netinho Olivieri (Penn). Even with starting center Lyndon Cooper transferring out to Vanderbilt, this room is more veteran and should see statistical improvements this fall.

DEFENSE

Death, Taxes, and a Top 10 Rushing Defense at Pitt.

Longtime defensive coordinator Randy Bates retired this offseason after building one of the most consistent defenses in the nation. No matter the player personnel, you knew what to expect from Pitt's defense every year: aggressive, blitz-heavy playcalling and disruption.

Pitt leads the nation in sacks (299) since 2019, they lead the ACC in defensive touchdowns (21) since 2021, four defenders were named All-Americans since 2020, and seven of his eight defenses placed in the Top 25 of my opponent-adjusted rankings.

2025 was no different. Pitt allowed just 2.7 yards/carry, 95 rush yards/game, and forced a Negative Play on 11% of snaps – all Top 10 national ranks.

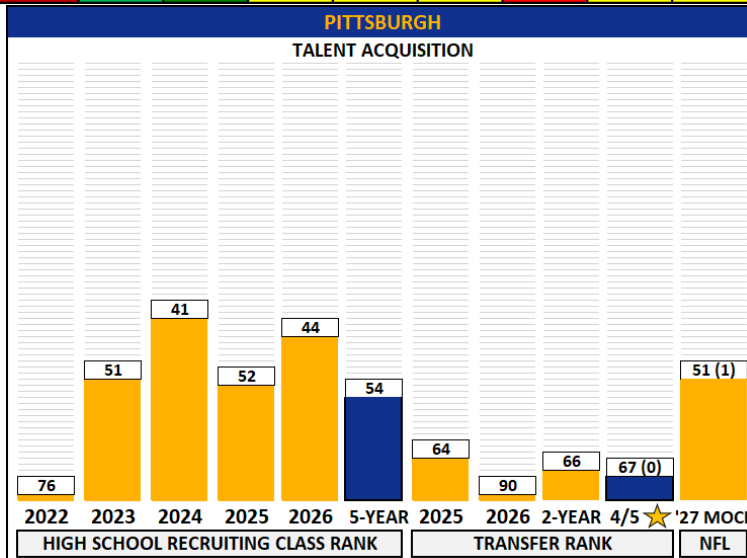
Cory Sanders is the next man up after serving the last eight seasons on staff coaching the safeties.

Pitt's linebacker room, aka "The Sharks," was once again a top national unit. The trio of Kyle Louis, Rasheem Biles, and Braylan Lovelace combined for 162 tackles, 31 for loss, 8.5 sacks, and 4 touchdowns. Former All-American Louis heads to the pros, Biles left for Texas, and Lovelace returns at middle backer after his All-ACC season. Cameron Lindsey started three games when Louis was injured, former Ohio State four-star Jayden Bonsu is back from injury, and they signed two FBS starters in Alex Sanford (Purdue) and DeMarco Ward (Memphis).

Like the offense, two impact starters were lost to the transfer portal. In addition to Biles, All-ACC

PITTSBURGH	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 5	MIAMI OHIO
S. 12	UCF
S. 17	SYRACUSE
S. 26	BUCKNELL (FCS)
O. 2	@ Virginia Tech
O. 10	UNC
O. 17	@ Boston College
O. 24	@ Miami
O. 31	GEORGIA TECH
N. 7	--- BYE ---
N. 13	FLORIDA STATE
N. 21	@ Louisville
N. 28	@ California

PITTSBURGH		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
56.7 (29)	44.9 (47)	31.4 (62)	56.7 (24)	68.3 (9)	50.1 (34)	47.8 (40)	47.6 (40)	44.4 (45)	52.1 (32)	50 (33)	



WEEKLY, IN-SEASON FEATURE -- ADVANCED STATS & INFO

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GEORGIA TECH

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#8(TIE) #40

ACC

OVERALL



GEORGIA TECH				
5-YEAR WIN TREND				
13	Georgia	Georgia	Georgia	(B) Vanderbilt
12	Notre Dame	MIAMI	BC	Georgia
11	BC	FSU	Bowling Green	VA TECH
10	MIAMI	VIRGINIA	Ole Miss	Notre Dame
9	VA TECH	UCF	LOUISVILLE	LOUISVILLE
8	VIRGINIA	Ole Miss	(B) UCF	SYRACUSE
7	PITTSBURGH	CLEMSON	SYRACUSE	NC STATE
6	CLEMSON	UNC	VIRGINIA	MIAMI
5	N. Illinois	VA TECH	UNC	UNC
4	DUKE	DUKE	MIAMI	DUKE
3	UNC	PITTSBURGH	WAKE FOREST	VMI (FCS)
2	Kenn. St (FCS)	W Carolina (FCS)	SC St (FCS)	GA State
1				FSU
	2021	2022	2023	2024
	2025			
	GEOFF COLLINS		BRENT KEY	

GEORGIA TECH				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
COLORADO W 27-20	158	-3	59.5	
G-Webb (FCS) W 59-12	354	-1	75.8	
CLEMSON W 24-21	-23	2	60.3	
TEMPLE W 45-24	140	-1	65.7	
WAKE FOREST W 30-29	-32	-1	44.0	
VA TECH W 35-20	114	1	70.4	
DUKE W 27-18	-65	1	64.3	
SYRACUSE W 41-16	162	0	74.5	
NC STATE L 36-48	-24	-1	31.9	
BOSTON COLL. W 36-34	91	-1	50.5	
PITTSBURGH L 28-42	-34	-2	26.1	
GEORGIA L 9-16	-10	0	44.4	
(B) BYU L 21-25	-40	0	43.7	
OVERALL: 33rd / 68	ACC: 8th / 17		54.7	

GEORGIA TECH	UNIT RANKS	
ACC RANK	NATIONAL	
(of 17)	TOP 15	
QUARTERBACK	13	
RUNNING BACKS	2	11
RECEIVERS & TE	13	
OFFENSIVE LINE	2	15
DEFENSIVE LINE	11	
LINEBACKERS	6	
DEFENSIVE BACKS	13	

GEORGIA TECH	RANK	
Scoring Offense	32.2 ppg	26
Points per Play	0.49	25
Total Offense	460 ypg	11
Yards per Play	7.0	5
Rushing Offense	197 ypg	21
Yards per Carry	5.5	8
O-Line Run Push	4.8	8
Explosive Rush	6.5	34
Passing Offense	263 ypg	31
Yards / Attempt	8.7	14
QB Rating	152	20
TD / INT Ratio	2.3	53
Sacks / Attempt	2%	3
Explosive Pass	8.9	15
Return. Production	37%	117
Returning Snaps	8,060	82
26.3 SECONDS/PLAY #32 of 68 P4		
KEY (2025 GEORGIA TECH)		

Georgia Tech's nine-win season was a total success for a program that is not far removed from nine wins over a three-year span. But the way the season started quickly shifted expectations onto the real prizes of an ACC Title and Playoff bid.

Game by game, Georgia Tech found a way. In the opener, Haynes King scrambled 45 yards for the winning touchdown in the final minute to beat Colorado. Then they upset #12 Clemson with a school-record 55-yard kick when the field goal team sprinted into formation in the final seconds. The ensuing field storming capped third-year head coach Brent Key's signature win.

The defense did their part with an overtime two-point stand to beat Wake Forest, and then again when Omar Daniels took back a fumble 95 yards for an essential 14-point swing to beat Duke.

Georgia Tech entered November with a perfect 8-0 record – their best start since 1966 – and a #7 AP ranking. King was the national leader in total offense and even ESPN's Pat McAfee put on a "Haynes for Heisman" shirt.

Then the defense collapsed. They allowed 583 yards to NC State, 537 to a one-win BC team, and 42 points to Pittsburgh. From 8-0 to 9-4, Tech lost four of its last five games with a finish that leaves the program and fan base with a bittersweet view. It was undoubtedly a successful season in totality, but after the 8-0 start it seems like a missed opportunity in the most wide-open ACC title race in over a decade.

Key's slogan is "JUMP" as in, the program continuing to make a jump each season. To jump higher than 9-4 in 2026, Tech must replace a program legend quarterback, the receiver trio, seven defensive starters, and will do so with a double coordinator switch.

OFFENSE

King led all Power 4 quarterbacks with 953 rushing yards, was second in rushing touchdowns, and his productive season earned him the ACC Offensive Player of the Year and placed him 10th on the Heisman leaderboard. King leaves The Flats with the school record for completions and joined Joe Hamilton as the second player with 10,000+ total yards.

The transition at quarterback was already going to be significant, but then offensive coordinator Buster Faulkner left for Florida – and brought quarterback Aaron Philo with him.

Philo had started a handful of games and was the clear projected starter until the transfer out. The staff hit the portal and signed Indiana backup Alberto Mendoza, brother of Heisman winner Fernando, to challenge incumbent Graham Knowles. Mendoza got 100 snaps during Indiana's national title run and was graded the #31 transfer quarterback this cycle, while Knowles' only snap was an 84-yard touchdown pass in the Gardner-Webb game.

Former Tech quarterback George Godsey takes over as coordinator after two decades coaching in the pros. Given the retention of excellent quarterbacks coach Chris Weinke, plus Key's success building offensive lines, the offensive style should remain the same.

Key's offensive line was one of the best in America last year and was one of just two lines to rank in the Top 10 of both my OL Run Push (#8) and Sack Rate (#3) stats. They lose their best one with first-team All-ACC guard Keylan Rutledge going pro, but return two starters – Malachi Carney and Ethan Mackenny – with ACC honors. Jameson Riggs and five-star Josh Petty are projected to start at guard, and three-star transfer Joseph Ionata (Alabama) rounds out the starting five at center.

Last year's duo of Jamal Haynes and Malachi Hosley combined for 1,138 yards and 12 touchdowns with both backs averaging over 7 yards/carry. Former Penn transfer Hosley added explosiveness to the offense.

With Jamal graduating, the staff successfully reloaded their dynamic duo in the backfield by signing the #4 ranked running back transfer Justice Haynes (Michigan). He was a five-star recruit, played two years at Alabama, then was Michigan's feature back (857 yards, 10 TD, 7.1 per carry) before an injury cut the season short. This is a top running back room again.

GEORGIA TECH					OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)									
O	12	30	22	60	51	40	53	32	25	11				
F														30th
F	BUSTER FAULKNER		LONG		DAVE PATENAUE		PAUL JOHNSON*							
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016				10-YEAR
D	GIDEON	SANTUCCI	SHERRER		ANDREW THACKER		WOODY		TED ROOF					
E	63	45	63	29	64	41	54	60	46	49				62nd
F														

GEORGIA TECH		RANK	
Scoring Defense	25 ppg	69	
Points per Play	0.37	71	
Total Defense	399 ypg	94	
Yards per Play	5.9	103	
3rd Down Conv%	40%	72	
Rushing Defense	164 ypg	90	
Yards per Carry	4.6	94	
Negative Play %	7%	103	
Explosive Rush	7.3	96	
Passing Defense	235 ypg	98	
Yards / Attempt	7.5	97	
QB Rating	139	96	
Completion %	62.3%	75	
Explosive Pass	6.2	85	
Return. Production	61%	28	
Returning Snaps	12,659	31	

GEORGIA TECH		RANK / 68	
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play			
Offense Overall		12	
Rushing Offense	1.2	9	
Passing Offense	13.3	27	
Defense Overall		63	
Rushing Defense	(0.7)	64	
Passing Defense	0.2	46	

It's a complete rebuild at receiver and tight end with the top three departing from both positions. Eric Rivers and Malik Rutherford graduated, then Isiah Canion transferred to Georgia with a high four-star transfer grade. Jordan Allen takes over the starting role in the slot, and a mix of incoming transfers are competing on the outsides. Isaiah Fuhrmann (Elon) put up 900 yards last year at the FCS level and was named first-team All-CAA, Jaiven Plummer (California) is a Power 4 veteran, and Jaylen Mbakwe (Alabama) is a true wild-card addition. Mbakwe was a five-star recruit in the 2024 class as the nation's #2 cornerback, but wants to play both ways and could be a playmaker here in the receiver rotation.

Luke Harpring followed Faulkner to Florida, meaning all three tight end spots are newcomers. All three were graded as three-star transfers: Chris Corbo (Dartmouth), pass threat Gavin Harris (New Mexico State) and blocker Spencer Mermans (Yale).

DEFENSE

King and the offense covered for a below-average defense over the 8-0 start, but then the unit collapsed in November per my opponent-adjusted metric:

- First 8 Games: #50 of 68 Power 4
- Final 5 Games: #67 of 68 Power 4

Jason Semore returns for his third stint at Georgia Tech and this time takes over as defensive coordinator. His coordinator experience has been successful, leading Valdosta State to a DII national title, and rebuilding defenses at Marshall and Southern Miss the past two seasons. Marshall played for a league title, and then his Southern Miss unit led the nation in interceptions last year.

Semore calls an aggressive defense focused on disruption and turnovers, and it's backed up by the stats. Southern Miss ranked in the Top 25 in sacks, tackles for loss, third-down defense, and picks. Georgia Tech's defense could use a boost in all four.

Four starters return, including the full two-deep at linebacker. Kyle Efford led the team in tackles, earned ACC honors, and returns with EJ Lightsey and Melvin Jordan. The trio looks for a bounce-back season to their 2024 standards.

Tech loses their top defender in first-team All-ACC Jordan van den Berg. They will miss his pass rush off the edge, but the staff signed three impact transfers in four-star Noah Carter (Alabama), Taje McCoy (Oklahoma State) and Rutgers starter Jordan Walker. Three more experienced ends return in Amontrae Bradford, Brayden Manley, and AJ Hoffer. Defensive tackle Christian Garrett is joined by two incoming transfers Tawfiq Thomas (Colorado) and Vincent Carroll-Jackson (UConn) who both have starting experience.

Five of the top six defensive backs are gone with backups Fenix Felton and Tae Harris moving up into starting roles. Jonas Duclona (USF) and Mbakwe are transfer additions, plus their two top-rated high school recruits this cycle are both corners Jaedyn Terry and Trae Stevenson.

OUTLOOK

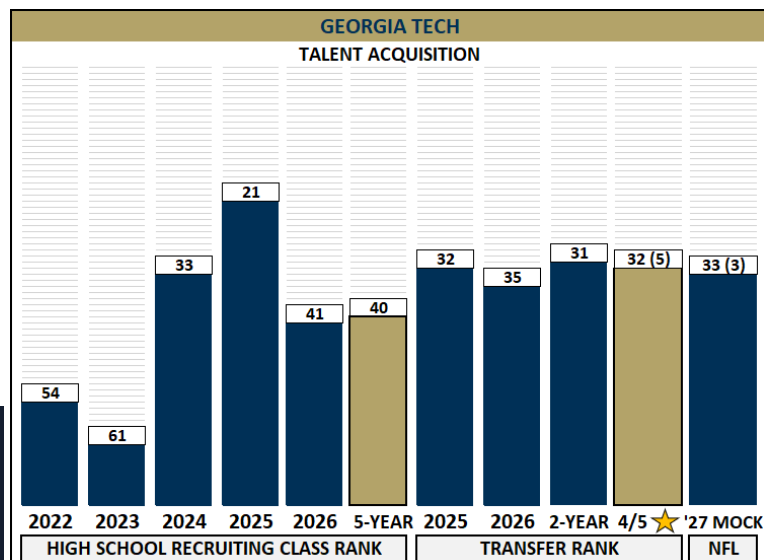
The losses of do-it-all King and coordinator Faulkner are major hits to the offense. Instead of the 10,000-yarder they will have a first-time starter. The defense collapsed in November and there was no apparent overnight fix.

Still, with Key's offensive line and a top running back duo, Georgia Tech will have its signature power run game and should return to bowl season as a mid-tier ACC team.

GEORGIA TECH	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 3	COLORADO
S. 12	TENNESSEE
S. 19	MERCER (FCS)
S. 26	@ Stanford
O. 3	--- BYE ---
O. 10	DUKE
O. 17	@ Virginia Tech
O. 24	BOSTON COLL.
O. 31	@ Pittsburgh
N. 7	LOUISVILLE
N. 14	@ Clemson
N. 21	WAKE FOREST
N. 28	@ Georgia

GEORGIA TECH	RANK / 68	
All-Time Wins	772	20
All-Time Win %	0.583	27
Wins (Last 100)	625	23
Wins (Last 50)	311	42
Wins (Last 25)	172	40
Wins (Last 10)	58	51
Wins (Last 5)	31	47
Game Grader (10 yr)	41.3	57
Game Grader (5 yr)	42.3	57
Game Grader (3 yr)	50.2	34
Draft Picks s' 2000	46	54
Draft Picks s' 2010	24	57
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)	58	
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)	44	

GEORGIA TECH				GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)						
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR
54.7 (33)	51.9 (37)	44 (44)	31.6 (60)	29.1 (60)	31.9 (58)	20.6 (66)	47.1 (42)	52.3 (32)	49.9 (37)	41.3 (57)



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FLORIDA STATE

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#10 #42

ACC

OVERALL



FLORIDA STATE				
5-YEAR WIN TREND				
14			(B) Georgia	
13		CLEMSON	(CG) Louisville	
12	Florida	NC STATE	Florida	(B) Florida
11	NC STATE	WAKE FOREST	N. Alabama (FCS)	NC STATE
10	CLEMSON	(B) Oklahoma	MIAMI	CLEMSON
9	LOUISVILLE	Florida	PITTSBURGH	STANFORD
8	WAKE FOREST	UL-Lafayette	WAKE FOREST	PITTSBURGH
7	Jax St (FCS)	SYRACUSE	DUKE	MIAMI
6	Notre Dame	MIAMI	SYRACUSE	VIRGINIA
5	BC	GA TECH	VA TECH	VA TECH
4	MIAMI	BC	CLEMSON	WAKE FOREST
3	UMass	LOUISVILLE	BC	Kent State
2	UNC	LSU	Southern Miss.	GA TECH
1	SYRACUSE	Duquesne (FCS)	LSU	Charl. S. (FCS)
	2021	2022	2023	2024
	2025			
	MIKE NORVELL			

From 13-0 to Playoff Snub to 2-10, Florida State went through an extreme two-year rollercoaster.

Mike Norvell had shifted the emphasis from high school recruiting over to the transfer portal, and that reliance on one-year portal hits led to the boom-or-bust outcomes. 2023 was a hit, 2024 was an all-time miss.

Florida State signed another top-rated transfer haul and the thought was that 2025 would indicate which of the two prior extreme seasons was the exception and which was the rule going forward.

On opening Saturday, they stunned #8 Alabama 31-17 in Tuscaloosa and then proceeded to drop 143 points in their next two wins. They rolled up more rushing yards and touchdowns in the first three games than the entire previous season. It appeared the 2025 transfer round was a hit, and that 2024 was a fluke after all.

Then ACC play started. Florida State lost in double overtime and Virginia recreated their historic 1995 upset with the wildest field storming of the year. Then they lost again (Miami by six), and again

(Pittsburgh by 3), and again (Stanford by 7).

FLORIDA STATE				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
ALABAMA W 31-17	41	-1	87.9	
E TX A&M (FCS) W 77-3	532	1	77.8	
KENT STATE W 66-10	569	0	80.0	
VIRGINIA L 38-46	74	0	45.9	
MIAMI L 22-28	66	-3	55.2	
PITTSBURGH L 31-34	-61	1	41.3	
STANFORD L 13-20	151	1	44.2	
WAKE FOREST W 42-7	174	1	101.3	
CLEMSON L 10-24	41	-2	36.6	
VA TECH W 34-14	68	2	70.4	
NC STATE L 11-21	97	-4	43.7	
FLORIDA L 21-40	-33	-1	23.5	
OVERALL: 25th / 68	ACC: 5th / 17		59.0	

The hot start and Top 10 ranking quickly collapsed into a second-straight losing season. Penalties and a goal line stand cost them the Stanford game, two fumbled punts flipped the NC State loss, and their comeback bids fell short after trailing 18-0 to Clemson and 28-3 to Miami. Then, with bowl eligibility at stake, they lost to rival Florida with the interim-led Gators dropping 40 points and a 266-yard explosion by their back.

Florida State is now on a 4-17 run against Power 4 opponents – 3-13 vs. the ACC – and the 7-17 overall record is the school's worst two-year run in 50 seasons.

This latest transfer haul ranked #30 with just three four-stars and it snapped Norvell's four-year streak of top ten transfer classes. Then shortly after Talent Acquisition season, offensive coordinator Gus Malzahn stepped down.

OFFENSE

It may ring hollow to Florida State fans, but FSU was statistically better than their record showed last year. Even at 5-7 overall, they finished #25 in my opponent-adjusted Game Grader formula, up from second-worst 67th of 68 in 2024. They out-gained 10 of 12 opponents, had four one-score losses, and each win was by 14+ points.

Malzahn's influence, plus transfer wins all across the offense, led to the nation's #1 most improved offense from 2024 to 2025. Florida State was one of just five Power 4 offenses to average 200+ rushing and 200+ passing for an overall #10 finish in my opponent-adjusted stat.

Norvell is taking back the play-calling and promoted receivers coach Tim Harris to coordinator. They plan to tweak some pass concepts and formations, but they are both Malzahn disciples and the offense will not have drastic scheme changes.

Just two starters return. 6'6 Duce Robinson posted a 1,000-yard season and earned first-team All-ACC honors, track-speed Micahi Danzy averaged a Power 4-best 21 yards/catch, and both star receivers are back. Lawayne McCoy was another breakout star but he transferred to Louisville. Jayvan Boggs moves up into the starting slot role, and another round of young four-stars fills out the rotation with Tae'Shaun Gelsey and Top200 true freshmen Devin Carter and Jasen Lopez.

Quarterback Tommy Castellanos graduated and like the overall team, he had extreme highs and lows in 2025. He threw for 15 touchdowns, ran for nine more, but tossed nine picks. Florida State went back to the portal and signed the #30 ranked transfer QB Ashton Daniels who started three games at Auburn, including a 31/44 353-yard win against Vanderbilt. He was a two-year starter at Stanford before that, but finished dead last in the ACC in QB Rating both seasons. Norvell named him the starter after spring.

FLORIDA STATE		UNIT RANKS	
ACC RANK	NATIONAL		
(of 17)	TOP 15		
QUARTERBACK	14		
RUNNING BACKS	4		
RECEIVERS & TE	4		
OFFENSIVE LINE	7		
DEFENSIVE LINE	6		
LINEBACKERS	8		
DEFENSIVE BACKS	10		

FLORIDA STATE		RANK
Scoring Offense	33 ppg	22
Points per Play	0.47	34
Total Offense	472 ypg	6
Yards per Play	6.7	14
Rushing Offense	219 ypg	11
Yards per Carry	5.2	18
O-Line Run Push	4.9	6
Explosive Rush	6.9	25
Passing Offense	253 ypg	40
Yards / Attempt	9	11
QB Rating	149	29
TD / INT Ratio	2.2	56
Sacks / Attempt	7%	87
Explosive Pass	10.5	5
Return. Production	57%	58
Returning Snaps	13,348	26
23.6 SECONDS/PLAY	#6 of 68 P4	
NORVELL (2025 FSU)		FAST

FLORIDA STATE					OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)									
O	10	68	26	5	33	39	39	57	38	6				26th
F	MALZAHN	ALEX ATKINS	KENNY DILLINGHAM	K. BRILES	BELL	DAWSEY / SANDERS								
F	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016				10-YEAR
D	WHITE	ADAM FULLER					HARLON BARNETT		CHARLES KELLY					
E	27	41	12	12	16	60	25	23	9	20				16th
F														

FLORIDA STATE		RANK	
Scoring Defense	22 ppg	43	
Points per Play	0.34	42	
Total Defense	329 ypg	28	
Yards per Play	5.0	31	
3rd Down Conv%	38%	60	
Rushing Defense	138 ypg	51	
Yards per Carry	3.6	27	
Negative Play %	9%	34	
Explosive Rush	4.8	19	
Passing Defense	191 ypg	28	
Yards / Attempt	7	61	
QB Rating	134	72	
Completion %	62.3%	74	
Explosive Pass	5.8	74	
Return. Production	57%	47	
Returning Snaps	11,760	44	

FLORIDA STATE		RANK / 68	
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play			
Offense Overall		10	
Rushing Offense	1.1	12	
Passing Offense	14.5	24	
Defense Overall		27	
Rushing Defense	0.4	33	
Passing Defense	(0.8)	47	

Of the five linebackers in the rotation, just two return in Blake Nicholson and Omar Graham. The staff signed the Sun Belt's tackle leader Chris Jones (Southern Miss) and four-star Mikai Gbaylor (UNC) who had his best season in White's scheme at Nebraska in 2024.

Six defensive linemen transferred out to Power 4 rosters but they were able to retain the Desir twins. Mandrell Desir earned All-Freshman honors at defensive tackle with a team-high 6.5 sacks, while his brother Darryll returns at edge. Rylan Kennedy (Texas A&M) is projected at the other end spot, and Deante McCray and Daniel Lyons are the vets in the middle. While two-time all-league Darrell Jackson graduates, four-star nose tackle Kevin Wynn flashed high upside as a true freshman.

OUTLOOK

Game Grader loved Florida State last season compared to their losing record. The close losses and big yardage margins had FSU at #25 despite going 5-7.

Norvell's cold streak has the program at pre-Bowden lows and the pressure is mounting. It's the worst possible timing to snap his streak of top ten transfer hauls, and they appear downgraded at almost every position group.

Worst of all is the schedule draw. In addition to Alabama and Florida in the non-conference, Florida State draws seven of the ACC's top nine and only one of the bottom eight.

FLORIDA STATE		RANK / 68	
All-Time Wins	588	58	
All-Time Win %	0.661	12	
Wins (Last 100)	588	33	
Wins (Last 50)	438	9	
Wins (Last 25)	196	23	
Wins (Last 10)	66	38	
Wins (Last 5)	35	37	
Game Grader (10 yr)	48.7	38	
Game Grader (5 yr)	52.7	28	
Game Grader (3 yr)	50.1	35	
Draft Picks s' 2000	128	10	
Draft Picks s' 2010	73	13	
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		51	
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		59	

It was a strange rotation week-to-week at running back, but FSU signed a headliner in Texas starter Tre Wisner who rushed for 1,600 yards the past two years. Wisner and near-five-star Ousmane Kromah should get the bulk of carries.

Last year the staff signed a bunch of Power 4 starters to rebuild the offensive line and it worked, surging from bottom 10 to top 10 in OL Run Push. All five starters are gone, including All-ACC headliners Luke Petitbon and Richie Leonard. This cycle they reloaded with another round of starters, though just two are from the Power 4: four-star Xavier Chaplin (Auburn) and center Bradyn Joiner (Purdue). Paul Bowling (Troy) started all year as a true freshman, Nate Pabst (Bowling Green) started 38 games and earned All-MAC, and Chimdia Nwaiwu (FCS SFA) was All-Southland. Herb Hand is an elite offensive line coach and with this high experience level there shouldn't be too much of a drop off.

Randy Pittman earned All-ACC honors but transferred out to SMU, former Top100 Landen Thomas steps up into the starting tight end spot along with Desirrio Riles (East Carolina).

DEFENSE

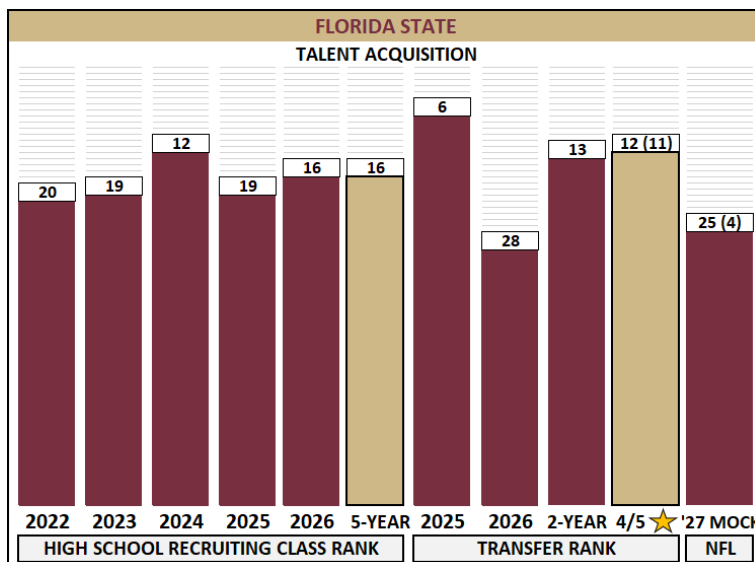
Though not as drastic as the offense, the defense improved in all 17 stat categories under Tony White's 3-3-5 scheme.

Seven starters are gone, and in total 12 defenders transferred out to other Power 4 programs. Yet they only signed four of their own, and just one four-star, for a net loss in the portal on this side of the ball.

Florida State loses both starting safeties Edwin Joseph (Ole Miss) and tackle-leader Earl Little (Ohio State) to the portal, and All-ACC corner Jerry Wilson graduated. They were able to pull back the other two starters from the portal – corner Ja'Bril Rawls and safety Ashlynd Barker – and then sign new starters of their own. Ma'Khi Jones (Duke) had a breakout freshman season, and Nehemiah Chandler (South Alabama) and Karson Hobbs (Notre Dame) had three-star transfer grades.

FLORIDA STATE	
2026 SCHEDULE	
A. 29	NM STATE
S. 7	SMU
S. 12	--- BYE ---
S. 19	@ Alabama
S. 26	C. ARKANSAS (FCS)
O. 3	VIRGINIA
O. 9	@ Louisville
O. 17	@ Miami
O. 24	--- BYE ---
O. 31	CLEMSON
N. 7	@ Boston College
N. 13	@ Pittsburgh
N. 21	NC STATE
N. 27	FLORIDA

FLORIDA STATE		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
59 (25)	20.6 (67)	70.8 (11)	71.2 (7)	42 (51)	26.2 (62)	42.2 (46)	33.5 (62)	49 (37)	72.9 (9)	48.7 (38)	



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CALIFORNIA

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#11

ACC

#50

OVERALL



CALIFORNIA				
5-YEAR WIN TREND				
13		(B) Texas Tech	(B) UNLV	(B) Hawaii
12	UCLA	OREGON ST	SMU	STANFORD
11	ARIZONA	USC	SYRACUSE	VIRGINIA
10	OREGON	UTAH	NC STATE	VA TECH
9	WASH ST	OREGON ST	PITTSBURGH	DUKE
8	WASHINGTON	WASHINGTON	MIAMI	San Diego St
7	TCU	COLORADO	FLORIDA ST	SMU
6	Nevada	WASH ST	STANFORD	LOUISVILLE
5	USC	Notre Dame	WAKE FOREST	UNC
4	STANFORD	STANFORD	Oregon St	BC
3	OREGON ST	ARIZONA	San Diego St	Minnesota
2	COLORADO	UNLV	Auburn	TX South. (FCS)
1	Sac. St (FCS)	UC Davis (FCS)	UC Davis (FCS)	Oregon St
2021 2022 2023 2024 2025				
JUSTIN WILCOX				

The Justin Wilcox era at California resulted in little change year-to-year and his nine teams followed the same general script. His program was defense-first, led by a secondary that continued to churn out NFL draft picks. The lines of scrimmage were consistently below average, pass protection and pass rush struggled, but a handful of skill players picked up the slack.

Even through five offensive coordinator changes, the pattern remained the same. And they always finished right near the .500 mark.

It got to the point where even Cal football analyst Nick Kranz admitted "it became increasingly difficult to find anything interesting to say about Wilcox's teams – they were always the same."

The sharp highs and lows of the 2025 season flipped the script.

Last spring, the program's top boosters threatened to pull their donations unless Ron Rivera was given full control. Top players transferred out, but four-star freshman Jaron-Keawe Sagapolutele flipped his commitment from Oregon to Cal, and provided a spark heading into the season.

CALIFORNIA				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
OREGON ST W 34-15	43	2	60.3	
TX South. (FCS) W 35-3	275	-1	70.3	
MINNESOTA W 27-14	5	2	70.1	
SAN DIEGO ST L 0-34	-32	-3	11.4	
BOSTON COLL. W 28-24	-3	1	47.0	
DUKE L 21-45	-157	-4	9.4	
UNC W 21-18	7	3	46.7	
VA TECH L 34-42	-151	1	20.5	
VIRGINIA L 21-31	-193	-2	21.7	
LOUISVILLE W 29-26	76	1	71.7	
STANFORD L 10-31	15	-3	19.5	
SMU W 38-35	-25	1	61.9	
(B) HAWAII L 31-35	86	-1	40.3	
OVERALL: 51st / 68 ACC: 12th / 17 42.4				

JKS became the first true freshman to start an opener here since Jared Goff and he tossed six touchdowns over their 3-0 start. Then they were shutout 34-0 by San Diego State, lost to Duke by 24, and threw a decisive Pick Six in the Virginia loss.

Wilcox's defense helped secure two more wins at the goal-line with Luke Ferrelli's endzone interception to beat Boston College and Brent Austin's forced fumble and recovery in the endzone to fend off UNC. JKS then put in his two best games as Cal snapped a five-year losing streak against ranked opponents beating both #15 Louisville and #21 SMU – eliminating them both from the ACC race.

But even with such highs, the low point against Stanford was enough to finally end the Wilcox era. Cal gave up two fumble touchdowns and committed a Wilcox era high 13 penalties in the 31-10 embarrassment.

Rivera moved quick and Cal hired alum Tosh Lupoi. After playing here in the early 2000s, Lupoi was a co-defensive coordinator on Alabama's title teams in 2015 and 2017, and has led Oregon's defense the past four years with consecutive Broyles Award semifinalist nominations.

Lupoi also has a strong recruiting profile. He earned the 2010 *Rivals* Recruiter of the Year by helping Cal sign a Top 15 class, then led several Top 5 classes at Alabama and Oregon. He backed up the reputation right away by flying out to Hawaii the day after the press conference to meet JKS and secure his commitment.

OFFENSE

The 6'3" lefty JKS was an instant program-changer. He threw 18 touchdowns, nine picks, and placed third nationally among true freshmen in QB Rating. For the first time in years, downfield explosive passing returned to the offense and he heads into 2026 riding a 178-pass streak without an interception – seven shy of Goff's school record. Lupoi loves his pocket presence and how he "does the most difficult things the best."

His freshman season, paired with Lupoi's recruiting chops, attracted a top-rated group of pass-catchers to transfer in. Cal's transfer class ranked #14 nationally and #3 in the ACC.

Ian Strong (Rutgers) earned All-Big Ten honors and thrived in one-on-one balls, Chase Hendricks (Ohio) was ranked as the #15 transfer receiver and led the MAC with 1,037 yards, and Cooper Perry (Oregon) was a Top200 recruit last cycle. Tight end Dorian Thomas (New Mexico) earned first-team All-Mountain West.

That's three four-star transfers and another recent Top200 four-star recruit.

All-ACC Jacob De Jesus departs after a 1,000-yard season, Trond Grizzell is also gone, but that transfer haul provides more than enough firepower for the pass game.

CALIFORNIA		UNIT RANKS	
ACC RANK	NATIONAL		
(of 17)	TOP 15		
QUARTERBACK	3		
RUNNING BACKS	10		
RECEIVERS & TE	6		
OFFENSIVE LINE	12		
DEFENSIVE LINE	13		
LINEBACKERS	14		
DEFENSIVE BACKS	6		

CALIFORNIA		RANK	
Scoring Offense	25.3 ppg	86	
Points per Play	0.37	88	
Total Offense	358 ypg	89	
Yards per Play	5.2	105	
Rushing Offense	82 ypg	135	
Yards per Carry	2.8	133	
O-Line Run Push	3.5	132	
Explosive Rush	2.6	136	
Passing Offense	276 ypg	19	
Yards / Attempt	7.1	70	
QB Rating	132	73	
TD / INT Ratio	2.0	71	
Sacks / Attempt	6%	80	
Explosive Pass	7.0	59	
Return. Production	70%	11	
Returning Snaps	16,406	10	

CALIFORNIA					OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)									
O	61	46	46	53	50	67	63	66	66	27				
F	HARSIN	BLOESCH	SPAVITAL	BILL MUSGRAVE	BEAU BALDWIN	SPAVITAL								66th
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016				10-YEAR
D	SO'OTO	PETER SIRMION					TIM DeRUYTER				KAUFMAN			
E	57	17	31	34	22	22	31	10	29	63				29th
F														

CALIFORNIA		RANK	
Scoring Defense	27.2 ppg	82	
Points per Play	0.41	90	
Total Defense	362 ypg	62	
Yards per Play	5.5	64	
3rd Down Conv%	42%	97	
Rushing Defense	157 ypg	79	
Yards per Carry	4.7	105	
Negative Play %	7%	109	
Explosive Rush	7.5	104	
Passing Defense	205 ypg	45	
Yards / Attempt	6.4	28	
QB Rating	122	39	
Completion %	61.7%	67	
Explosive Pass	4.7	23	
Return. Production	45%	90	
Returning Snaps	10,887	55	

CALIFORNIA		RANK / 68	
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play			
Offense Overall		61	
Rushing Offense	(1.5)	68	
Passing Offense	0.3	43	
Defense Overall		57	
Rushing Defense	(0.9)	65	
Passing Defense	1.0	42	

Both All-ACC backers Cade Uluave (BYU) and Luke Ferrelli (Ole Miss) transferred out and Lupoi is gambling on former Top200 prospects that lack collegiate experience: Tristan Jernigan (Texas A&M) and Kamar Mothudi (Oregon).

As usual for the Wilcox era, they had an elite coverage corner duo but both Hezekiah Masses and Brent Austin are both gone. Incoming corner Ricky Fletcher (Ole Miss) is their top All-ACC candidate on defense and Daniel Harris (Georgia) was a rotational corner last year. Isaiah Crosby was the original starting safety before an injury, Aiden Manutai filled in and helped seal the SMU win, and both are back for 2026. Both nickelbacks Cam Sidney and Jasiah Wagoner are also back, plus the staff added high four-star Kingston Lopa (Oregon).

OUTLOOK

Cal signed the #3 transfer class in the ACC and boosted the receiver room and secondary with instant impact starters. JKS should get a second-year boost and he earned my third-team All-ACC preseason spot.

The lines of scrimmage hold them back from a higher projection, but if Lupoi can develop them quicker than expected, Cal has a good shot at a bowl bid. They need to win two of the four swing games: UCLA, Pittsburgh, @ UNLV, and @ NC State.

Lupoi's coordinator hires followed a pattern: young 30-year-olds from NFL staffs with West Coast college roots. On offense, Jordan Somerville spent the last three seasons on the Tampa Bay Bucs staff and helped lead Baker Mayfield to two top ten passing seasons.

In addition to his first role as play-caller, Somerville is tasked with rebuilding an offensive line that struggled the past few seasons. The run game was completely broken in 2025 and the line has consecutive bottom ten finishes in my OL Run Push metric.

Four partial starters return with a combined 2,300 career snaps: Bastian Swinney, Frederick Williams, Tyson Ruffins, and Sioape Vatikani. The staff added another round of transfer additions with limited experience and mid-three star rankings. Jimothy Lewis (Mississippi State) emerged in spring as the likely fifth starter.

Two of the three backs were battling injuries so Kendrick Raphael stepped up to take 70% of the carries and earned All-ACC recognition. The explosiveness was lacking but he gained tough yards with minimal room from the line. Raphael transferred to SMU but Cal feels they upgraded with Adam Mohammed (Washington) who was the #6 ranked transfer running back.

DEFENSE

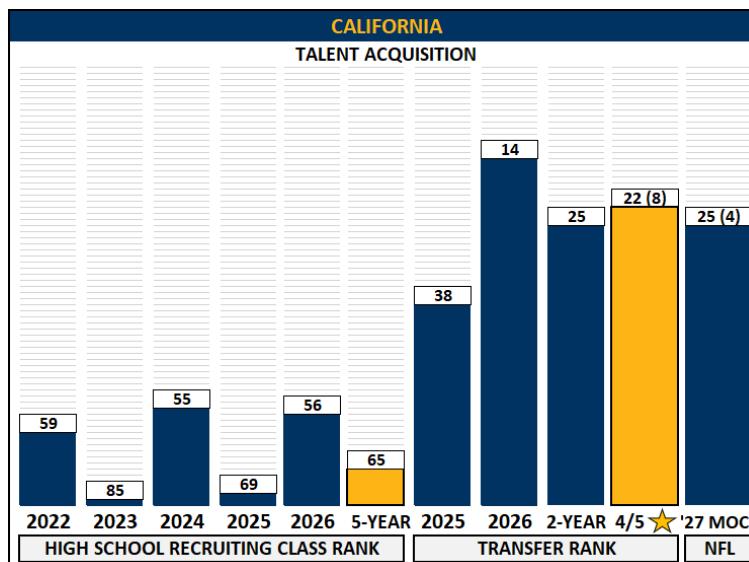
Lupoi and Dan Lanning came from the Nick Saban and Kirby Smart trees and together they put their own spin on the defense. They kept the same level of aggressiveness but tweaked the base formation to stress the RPO game. Lupoi uses a four-man front, two outside backers, and three safeties with the middle one almost at linebacker depth.

Cal will shift from their 3-3-5 to a 4-2-5 and they need to find a whole new defensive line. They struggled to create disruption last year with a #109 rank in Negative Play Rate and #100 in sacks. Both interior starters graduated and two ends transferred out – Ryan McCulloch (UCLA) and TJ Bush (Minnesota) – but the staff signed five defensive line transfers. Three of them were former four-star recruits from high school: Jericho Johnson (Oregon), Solomon Williams (Texas A&M) and Emmanuel Okoye (Tennessee). Nate Burrell and Derek Wilkins are both fifth-year veterans at end.

CALIFORNIA	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 5	UCLA
S. 12	@ Syracuse
S. 19	WAGNER (FCS)
S. 25	CLEMSON
O. 3	@ UNLV
O. 10	VIRGINIA TECH
O. 17	WAKE FOREST
O. 24	@ SMU
O. 31	@ NC State
N. 7	--- BYE ---
N. 14	@ Virginia
N. 21	STANFORD
N. 28	PITTSBURGH

CALIFORNIA		RANK / 68	
All-Time Wins	709	35	
All-Time Win %	0.547	44	
Wins (Last 100)	535	50	
Wins (Last 50)	270	55	
Wins (Last 25)	151	50	
Wins (Last 10)	54	56	
Wins (Last 5)	28	55	
Game Grader (10 yr)	43.5	52	
Game Grader (5 yr)	43.0	55	
Game Grader (3 yr)	45.0	45	
Draft Picks s' 2000	76	29	
Draft Picks s' 2010	41	34	
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		50	
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		36	

CALIFORNIA		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)								
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR
42.4 (51)	49.3 (41)	43.4 (47)	34.8 (56)	45 (49)	45.1 (38)	41.9 (48)	46.3 (46)	44.2 (46)	42.5 (47)	43.5 (52)



WEEKLY, IN-SEASON FEATURE -- ADVANCED STATS & INFO

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WAKE FOREST #12(TIE) #53

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ACC	OVERALL
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WAKE FOREST

5-YEAR WIN TREND

14	(CG) PITT			
13	CLEMSON	DUKE		DUKE
12	*UNC	UNC	SYRACUSE	FLORIDA ST
11	(B) Rutgers	NC STATE	Notre Dame	GA TECH
10	BC	LOUISVILLE	NC STATE	UNC
9	NC STATE	CLEMSON	DUKE	(B) Miss. St
8	DUKE	(B) Missouri	FSU	Delaware
7	Army	SYRACUSE	VA TECH	UNC
6	SYRACUSE	BC	CLEMSON	VIRGINIA
5	LOUISVILLE	Army	Ole Miss	SMU
4	VIRGINIA	FSU	GA TECH	Oregon St
3	FSU	Liberty	PITTSBURGH	VA TECH
2	Norfolk St (FCS)	Vanderbilt	Old Dominion	W Carolina (FCS)
1	Old Dominion	VMI (FCS)	Vanderbilt Elon (FCS)	Kennesaw
	2021	2022	2023	2024
	DAVE CLAWSON			DICKERT

A year ago, longtime Wake Forest head coach Dave Clawson retired citing college football's structural changes and the disappearance of the four-year student-athlete. His final team finished 4-8 and top talent was poached from the program via the transfer portal.

Clawson's concerns about the game are still valid, and his Wake Forest legacy will be remembered well, but new head coach Jake Dickert pulled off an instant transition and his nine-win debut was nothing short of shocking.

Dickert flipped the roster with 32 transfers plus a full recruiting class, and after some September growing pains, Wake Forest finished the season winning seven of their last nine. They knocked off a pair of ranked teams including the program's first Top 15 win since 1979 when they beat ACC runner-up Virginia.

They did it with defense, Dickert's area of expertise, by improving in every single stat category and turning a 2024 weakness into a 2025 strength. Wake Forest finished ranked #9 nationally in my opponent-

adjusted metric and they held those ranked opponents Virginia and SMU to just 9 and 12 points.

The surprise debut season ended with a five-gallon mayonnaise shower – the infamous reward for winning the Duke’s Mayo Bowl – to cap off the school’s fourth nine-win season ever.

Player movement may still be at an all-time high, but Dickert was clearly proud of his team's academic performance, posting a combined 3.3 GPA which he called a school record.

They were hit with a high-profile case of potential roster tampering when starting offensive tackle Melvin Siani took a multi-million deal with Texas in the final hours despite being under contract. The program lost a trio of star players who earned four-star transfer grades, but did not sign any four-stars of their own.

OFFENSE

No four-star transfers, but they did pull in one Power 4 starter via the portal.

Gio Lopez was Bill Belichick's hand-picked quarterback for his college debut season, but the sophomore struggled without much help around him. Lopez finished 14th of the 17 ACC starting quarterbacks in QB Rating with a low 6.7 yards/attempt and just 10 touchdowns.

Dickert is more intrigued with what he saw from Lopez the year prior when he was at South Alabama and paired up with current Wake offensive coordinator Rob Ezell. In 2024, Lopez earned All-Sun Belt honors with 18 touchdowns, just 5 picks, a 66% completion, and a high 8.2 yards/attempt. That offense averaged 34 points/game to place in the Top 20 of scoring.

Ezell's impact was felt immediately here as he helped fix the offensive line, and re-instill confidence in a sixth-year journeyman at quarterback in Robby Ashford. The veteran shouldered a heavy workload, especially when star running back Demond Claiborne was sidelined with injuries, and helped grind out win after win.

Ashford is gone, along with backup Deshawn Purdie, meaning they are all in on Lopez at quarterback.

It's a total transition season all over the offense. The quarterbacks are gone, Claiborne went pro, five of the six receivers are gone, three offensive linemen graduated and a fourth transferred out in the final hours.

With 2,599 yards, Claiborne leaves as the fourth all-time rusher in school history and earned All-ACC twice. Ty Clark shined in his bowl game start with 164 total yards and a score. The staff added KD Daniels (Florida) who was a former Top200 recruit and got backup carries last season.

WAKE FOREST				
2025 RESULTS		Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE
KENNESAW ST	W 10-9	41	0	42.2
W. Carolina (FCS)	W 42-10	304	-1	70.3
NC STATE	L 24-34	-95	-2	25.4
GA TECH	L 29-30	32	1	57.3
VA TECH	W 30-23	84	0	59.6
OREGON ST	W 39-14	159	2	72.2
SMU	W 13-12	55	-2	62.8
FLORIDA ST	L 7-42	-174	-1	5.1
VIRGINIA	W 16-9	-124	3	60.2
UNC	W 28-12	157	-1	68.2
DELAWARE	W 52-14	277	0	80.0
DUKE	L 32-49	90	-4	35.2
(B) MISS ST	W 43-29	43	-1	63.3
OVERALL: 34th / 68		ACC: 9th / 17	54.0	

WAKE FOREST	UNIT RANKS	
ACC RANK (of 17)	NATIONAL TOP 15	
QUARTERBACK	12	
RUNNING BACKS	15	
RECEIVERS & TE	11	
OFFENSIVE LINE	16	
DEFENSIVE LINE	8	
LINEBACKERS	12	
DEFENSIVE BACKS	7	

WAKE FOREST		RANK	
Scoring Offense	28.1 ppg	64	
Points per Play	0.42	54	
Total Offense	394 ypg	62	
Yards per Play	6.0	45	
Rushing Offense	156 ypg	69	
Yards per Carry	4.5	60	
O-Line Run Push	3.9	105	
Explosive Rush	5.8	47	
Passing Offense	238 ypg	58	
Yards / Attempt	7.6	53	
QB Rating	130	77	
TD / INT Ratio	1.6	88	
Sacks / Attempt	4%	22	
Explosive Pass	7.8	39	
Return. Production	45%	96	
Returning Snaps	7,037	96	
 25.9 SECONDS/PLAY #28 of 68 P4 EZELL (2025 WAKE FOREST)			

	WAKE FOREST					OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)						
O												
F	39	61	58	28	28	44	45	53	16	65	51st	
F	EZELL	WARREN RUGGIERO										
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
D	HAZELTON	BRAD LAMBERT			LYLE HEMPHILL			JAY SAWVEL		ELKO		
E	9	51	57	53	49	38	53	53	34	39	48th	

WAKE FOREST		RANK	
Scoring Defense	22.1 ppg	45	
Points per Play	0.31	28	
Total Defense	329 ypg	26	
Yards per Play	4.6	10	
3rd Down Conv%	36%	39	
Rushing Defense	122 ypg	28	
Yards per Carry	3.4	17	
Negative Play %	10%	11	
Explosive Rush	5.0	22	
Passing Defense	207 ypg	46	
Yards / Attempt	5.9	9	
QB Rating	115	21	
Completion %	59.1%	32	
Explosive Pass	4.1	7	
Return. Production	61%	33	
Returning Snaps	13,494	21	
WAKE FOREST		RANK / 68	
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play			
Offense Overall		39	
Rushing Offense	0.1	42	
Passing Offense	(7.0)	53	
Defense Overall		9	
Rushing Defense	0.8	21	
Passing Defense	15.3	21	

Leading receiver Carlos Hernandez is back but otherwise it is a complete rebuilding project behind him. Sawyer Racanelli graduated, then the next three left with high transfer grades: Sterling Berkhalter (Texas), Chris Barnes (Oklahoma State), and Micah Mays (Florida).

The staff signed four transfers, headlined by C-USA All-Freshman Wondame Davis (UTEP) whose explosive 23.5 yards/catch ranked #2 nationally. The other three come from Power 4 programs but were either backups or in the rotation last year: Chase Tyler (Duke), Ny Carr (Miami), and Kam Shanks (Arkansas). Despite all the change, Dickert says "we've gotten faster" at receiver.

Starting tight end Eni Falayi departs, Kamrean Johnson returns, and the staff added a sixth-year vet in Landon Morris (California).

Another position group, another complete rebuild. Ezell improved the offensive line 100 spots in Pass Protection, up to #22 (4% Sack Rate) from the 2024 line at #122 (10% Sack Rate). Now four of those starters depart including three All-ACC performers: Fa'alili Fa'amoe, George Sell, and Devin Kylany. They were planning to build the new line around their anchor at left tackle Melvin Siani but he left for Texas in the final hours and was rated the #3 transfer linemen this cycle.

Clinton Richard and George Steih return as partial-year starters, and the staff signed a trio of FCS transfers Tolu Olajide (New Hampshire), John Ohnegian (Bucknell), and Will Way (Weber State), along with Ryan Berger (Oregon State).

DEFENSE

Dickert led the third-largest defensive turnaround as Wake Forest cut off 10 points/game and 100 yards/game from their 2024 averages. They saved their best for the ranked opponents as they kept Virginia out of the endzone and then held SMU 2.6 yards/play below their average which was the #14 defensive performance of the entire 2025 season.

Unlike the offense, this side of the ball does return some key stars to build around. Both defensive ends are back with Gabe Kirschke and All-ACC Langston Hardy combining for 12 sacks and 26

tackles-for-loss. Starting tackles Jayden Loving and Nuer Gatkuoth are gone but they were able to retain their next pair of Zach Lohavichan and Dallas Afalava.

Aiden Hall returns at one linebacker spot though they lose All-ACC honorable mention backer Dylan Hazen. Frank Cusano got experience as a freshman and now moves up into the starting lineup. The staff signed Buom Jock (California) who redshirted last season but in 2024 earned All-Mountain West with 100 tackles at Colorado State.

One all-league star returns in Davaughn Patterson but two more graduated. Both corners Karon Prunty and Lardarius Webb are gone and the biggest loss of the defense is former walk-on turned program legend Nick Andersen, the first-team All-ACC safety. Braylon Johnson is a returning starter at free safety and the staff signed a pair of non-AQ starting corners in All-CUSA Deuce Blades (FIU) and Bernard Causey (Georgia State).

OUTLOOK

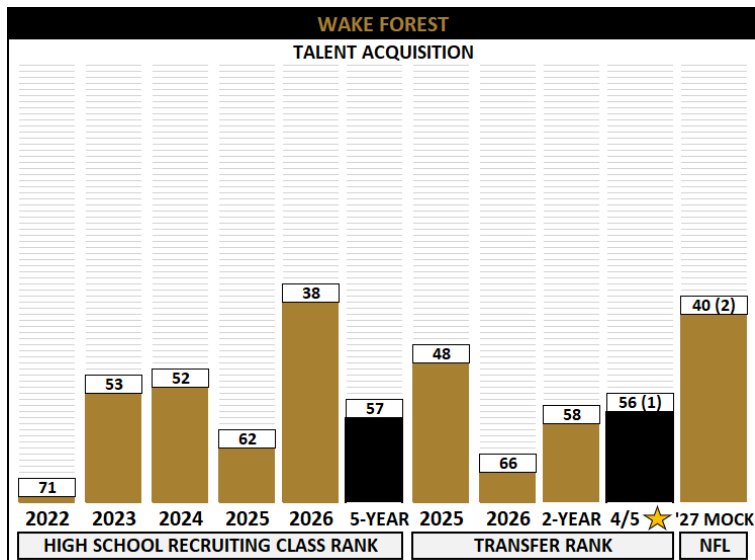
Can lightning strike twice in Winston-Salem?

Dickert will have to do so with just six returning starters – nine All-ACC performers are gone. With bottom-five ACC ranks in recruiting and transfers, look for a step back and a rebuilding season.

WAKE FOREST	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 3	AKRON
S. 12	@ Purdue
S. 18	MIAMI
S. 26	@ Louisville
O. 3	STANFORD
O. 10	@ NC State
O. 17	@ California
O. 24	--- BYE ---
O. 31	VIRGINIA
N. 7	MERRIMACK (FCS)
N. 14	@ SMU
N. 21	@ Georgia Tech
N. 28	DUKE

WAKE FOREST		RANK / 68	
All-Time Wins	503	66	
All-Time Win %	0.421	68	
Wins (Last 100)	446	62	
Wins (Last 50)	254	59	
Wins (Last 25)	153	49	
Wins (Last 10)	70	34	
Wins (Last 5)	36	35	
Game Grader (10 yr)	45.6	48	
Game Grader (5 yr)	45.6	50	
Game Grader (3 yr)	38.2	63	
Draft Picks s' 2000	41	57	
Draft Picks s' 2010	24	57	
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		13	
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		12	

WAKE FOREST		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
54 (34)	29.5 (62)	31.2 (63)	54.6 (28)	58.7 (23)	44.2 (41)	48.1 (38)	43.7 (52)	53.8 (30)	37.9 (52)	45.6 (48)	



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DUKE

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#12(TIE) #54

ACC OVERALL



DUKE				
5-YEAR WIN TREND				
14				VIRGINIA
13		PITTSBURGH	VIRGINIA	UConn
12	MIAMI	UNC	UNC	GA TECH
11	LOUISVILLE	GA TECH	LOUISVILLE	Tulane
10	VA TECH	Kansas	FSU	Illinois
9	PITTSBURGH	(B) UCF	Notre Dame	
8	WAKE FOREST	WAKE FOREST	(B) Troy	(B) Arizona St
7	VIRGINIA	VA TECH	PITTSBURGH	(CG) Virginia
6	GA TECH	BC	WAKE FOREST	UNC
5	UNC	MIAMI	NC STATE	CLEMSON
4	Charlotte	VIRGINIA	UConn	CALIFORNIA
3	Kansas	NC A&T (FCS)	Northwestern	SYRACUSE
2	Northwestern	Northwestern	Lafayette (FCS)	NC STATE
1	NC A&T (FCS)	CLEMSON	Elon (FCS)	Elon (FCS)
2021		2022	2023	2024
CUTCLIFFE		MIKE ELKO	MANNY DIAZ	

DUKE				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
Elon (FCS) W 45-17	273	-1	67.7	
ILLINOIS L 19-45	19	-5	24.0	
TULANE L 27-34	26	0	36.8	
NC STATE W 45-33	-117	4	69.6	
SYRACUSE W 38-3	189	3	83.2	
CALIFORNIA W 45-21	157	4	81.7	
GA TECH L 18-27	65	-1	42.1	
CLEMSON W 46-45	-121	1	45.3	
UConn L 34-37	-82	-3	27.3	
VIRGINIA L 17-34	-285	1	16.0	
UNC W 32-25	47	0	53.8	
WAKE FOREST W 49-32	-90	4	68.6	
(CG) VIRGINIA W 27-20	-11	1	69.6	
(B) ARIZONA ST W 42-39	-80	2	49.2	
OVERALL: 37th / 68 ACC: 10th / 17 52.5				

DUKE	UNIT RANKS	
ACC RANK (of 17)	NATIONAL TOP 15	
QUARTERBACK	16	
RUNNING BACKS	8	
RECEIVERS & TE	14	
OFFENSIVE LINE	11	
DEFENSIVE LINE	15	
LINEBACKERS	15	
DEFENSIVE BACKS	17	

DUKE	RANK	
Scoring Offense	34.6 ppg	16
Points per Play	0.5	20
Total Offense	424 ypg	25
Yards per Play	6.2	28
Rushing Offense	138 ypg	88
Yards per Carry	4.3	77
O-Line Run Push	4.1	90
Explosive Rush	5.7	50
Passing Offense	285 ypg	11
Yards / Attempt	7.9	38
QB Rating	153	19
TD / INT Ratio	5.7	5
Sacks / Attempt	6%	50
Explosive Pass	7.6	40
Return. Production	48%	87
Returning Snaps	12,155	38
25.3 SECONDS/PLAY #19 of 68 P4		
BREWER (2025 DUKE)		

In baseball they call it a "seeing-eye single" when a soft ground ball somehow slowly finds its way into the outfield. It appears harmless off the bat, but eventually finds its way.

That was the Duke football season. Duke committed five turnovers in the Illinois loss, botched three field goal attempts in the Tulane loss, lost to UConn, and then dropped two league games. They were 5-5 heading into their in-state rivalry games.

Three weeks later they were hoisting the ACC Championship trophy in Charlotte.

At several points throughout the season, this would have seemed impossible. Even aside from the five losses, there were moments within the wins where Duke survived by a thread. Down double-digits against NC State, Tre Freeman took a goal-line pick back 70 yards for an eventual 14-point swing. At Clemson, Duke went 5/5 on fourth downs and then Manny Diaz called for the game-winning two-point attempt in the final seconds to clinch Duke's first win in Death Valley since 1980. Trailing UNC, Diaz called a gutsy fake field goal that made them 5/6 on fourth downs and set up the game-winning touchdown. Another fake punt led to a score in the Wake Forest win.

And then by way of a wild five-way tiebreaker, Duke punched a ticket to the title game and earned a rematch with Virginia. They controlled time of possession, nailed yet another fake punt, and scored the game-winner on a fourth down in overtime.

Now that's a seeing-eye Conference Title.

Diaz now has consecutive 9+ win seasons to start his Duke tenure, and clinched their first outright ACC title since 1962. They again swept UNC, Wake Forest, and NC State to mark back-to-back state titles.

The five losses were enough to keep Duke below two non-AQ conference champs so they did not earn an automatic bid the Playoff. But after a decade of Clemson's Dabo Dynasty and the recent resurgence of Miami, an outright ACC title – no matter how they pulled it off -- makes this an all-time season for Duke.

OFFENSE

It started last offseason when Duke made the financial commitment to sign a top quarterback from the transfer market. Tulane's Darian Mensah came to Durham and proceeded to shatter the school's single-season passing records for yards (3,973) and touchdowns (34). On fourth down in overtime, he sat patiently in the pocket before scrambling left to find Jeremiah Hasley for the ACC-clinching touchdown. Money well spent.

Duke was one of just five Power 4 offenses to feature a 3,000-yard passer, 1,000-yard rusher, and 1,000-yard receiver. And from that list they joined Ohio State as the only programs set to return their trio.

Instead, the same transfer portal that brought Mensah to Duke, took him away. The contract breach was battled in the courtrooms but eventually Mensah left for Miami and took his 1,000-yard receiver Cooper Barkate with him.

In total, Duke now has to replace their record-setting quarterback, top four receivers, and three starting offensive linemen including an All-American tackle.

The staff signed San Jose State starter Walker Eget who passed for 5,551 yards, 30 touchdowns, and 19 picks over his two seasons. In QB Rating, Eget placed 7th in the Mountain West both years. He'll be challenged by redshirt freshman Dan Mahan who was a three-star recruit in the 2025 class.

Barkate and Que'Sean Brown (Virginia Tech) transferred out, four-year starter Sahmir Hagans graduated, and Andre Anthony went pro. That's nearly 3,000 receiving yards and 23 receiving touchdowns – and Hagan's return abilities – all gone. It's a complete rebuilt at receiver and the staff signed a pair of high three-star transfers in FCS All-American Jared Richardson (Penn) and All-AAC Javen Nicholas (Charlotte).

Three starting offensive linemen are gone including Brian Parker who started 33 games and left as an All-American. Left guard Jordan Larsen and center Matt Craycraft are returning starters, Bradley Smith started the bowl game at guard, and the open tackle spots will likely be the two transfers Braden Miller

DUKE											OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)
O											
F	22	59	37	30	64	61	66	48	61	56	62nd
F	JONATHAN BREWER		KEVIN JOHNS		BOYETTE		ZAC ROPER				
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR
D	JONATHAN PATKE		SANTUCCI		SMITH		BEN ALBERT / MATT GUERRIERI			JIM KNOWLES	
E	64	25	27	48	68	55	29	36	35	61	57th
F											

DUKE		RANK	
Scoring Defense	29.4 ppg	98	
Points per Play	0.44	100	
Total Defense	424 ypg	121	
Yards per Play	6.3	122	
3rd Down Conv%	45%	126	
Rushing Defense	147 ypg	66	
Yards per Carry	4.3	75	
Negative Play %	10%	19	
Explosive Rush	7.5	102	
Passing Defense	277 ypg	134	
Yards / Attempt	8.4	125	
QB Rating	146	113	
Completion %	67.2%	127	
Explosive Pass	6.8	108	
Return. Production	51%	72	
Returning Snaps	7,610	88	
DUKE		RANK / 68	
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play			
Offense Overall		22	
Rushing Offense	0.1	41	
Passing Offense	20.9	12	
Defense Overall		64	
Rushing Defense	0.0	50	
Passing Defense	(11.6)	59	

(California) and Nick Del Grande (Coastal Carolina). The line ranked #50 in pass protection, #90 in OL Run Push, and it's hard to project improvement after the talent drain this cycle.

Nate Sheppard posted Duke's sixth-ever 1,000-yard rushing season and broke the freshman rushing records. He shared carries with Anderson Castle and they both rushed for 10+ touchdowns. Castle graduated, so Sheppard should get an increased workload and post another 1,000-yard season.

Jeremiah Hasley is the leading returning tight end in the ACC after catching 40 balls last year. Landen King graduated but the staff signed veteran Nate Kurisky (Louisville) who has caught seven touchdowns over three years.

DEFENSE

As always, Diaz's defense shows up on the stat sheet with a Top 25 ranking in my Negative Play rate which tracks how frequently they disrupt behind the line of scrimmage. Duke was #3 in 2024 and #19 last year.

The defense ranked below average in every other stat category including a bottom five -- #64 of 68 Power 4 -- in my opponent-adjusted overall stat, and bottom ten marks in most passing categories.

How did a statistically poor defense win the ACC? Turnovers. Duke may have allowed a ton of yards but they grabbed 20 takeaways in league play. Together with the offense, Duke's +17 turnover margin in league games was #1 nationally. The offense gave away almost all their turnovers in non-conference games that ultimately didn't impact their path to Charlotte.

Like the offense, there's plenty of roster turnover here and Duke must replace 9 of its top 14 tacklers, and all four All-ACC stars.

Their elite defensive ends Wesley Williams and Vincent Anthony head to the pros, and starting tackles Josiah Green and All-ACC Aaron Hall are both gone too.

End Tyshon Reed and tackle Preston Watson are the next men up, and the staff added a tackle pair from the transfer portal: Owen Wafle (Penn State) and Dakota Quinonez (Dartmouth).

Linebackers Jaiden Francois and Tre Freeman graduated, but Duke brings back their top playmaker Luke Mergott who had four takeaways in the final three games -- two fumbles vs. Wake, and late interceptions to seal the ACC title and Sun Bowl wins. Former top recruit Bradley Gompers moves up in the rotation, and they get back Nick Morris, a 2023 starter who has had the past two seasons cut short with injuries.

The secondary loses All-ACC corner Chandler Rivers, and three safeties in 2025 starter Caleb Weaver, 2024 All-American Terry Moore (Ohio State) and Ma'Khi Jones (Florida State). Starting safety DaShawn Stone and corner Landan Callahan return, and two transfers join the starting lineup with Patrick Smith-Young (North Texas) and Che Ojarikre (Stanford) who had six starts last year.

OUTLOOK

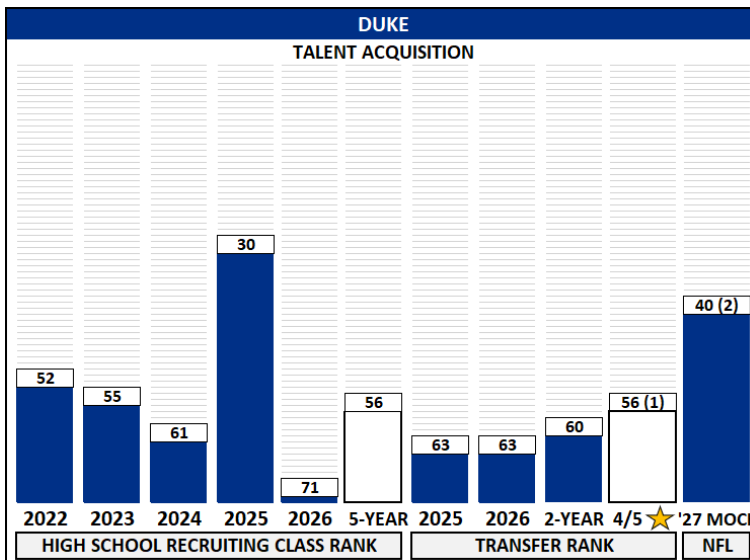
2025 was a dream season and the school's winningest Senior class (35 wins over four seasons) capped it off with an ACC title.

All pointers indicate a fall down the standings in 2026. Game Grader had them 10th in the league last year, they benefitted from nation-best turnover luck, and none of their regular season wins were over teams with ACC winning records. Then their star quarterback and 1,000-yard receiver both went to South Beach and they did not backfill enough from the portal.

DUKE	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 5	TULANE
S. 12	@ Illinois
S. 19	STANFORD
S. 26	W&M (FCS)
O. 3	--- BYE ---
O. 10	@ Georgia Tech
O. 17	UNC
O. 23	@ Virginia
O. 31	BOSTON COLL.
N. 7	@ NC State
N. 14	@ Miami
N. 20	CLEMSON
N. 28	@ Wake Forest

DUKE		RANK / 68	
All-Time Wins	555	64	
All-Time Win %	0.496	58	
Wins (Last 100)	515	53	
Wins (Last 50)	218	65	
Wins (Last 25)	122	66	
Wins (Last 10)	64	42	
Wins (Last 5)	38	29	
Game Grader (10 yr)	42.4	54	
Game Grader (5 yr)	45.0	51	
Game Grader (3 yr)	49.4	36	
Draft Picks s' 2000	17	68	
Draft Picks s' 2010	15	68	
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		25	
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		14	

DUKE				GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)						
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR
52.5 (37)	43.3 (50)	52.3 (33)	56.7 (25)	20.2 (66)	25.7 (64)	35.9 (56)	47.7 (39)	53.5 (31)	35.9 (56)	42.4 (54)



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NORTH CAROLINA

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#14

ACC

#57

OVERALL



NORTH CAROLINA				
5-YEAR WIN TREND				
14	(B) S. Carolina	(B) Oregon	(B) WVU	(B) UConn
13	NC STATE	(CG) Clemson	NC STATE	NC STATE
12	PITTSBURGH	GA TECH	CLEMSON	BC
11	Notre Dame	Notre Dame	GA TECH	GA TECH
10	FSU	WAKE FOREST	VIRGINIA	DUKE
9	GA TECH	VIRGINIA	DUKE	PITTSBURGH
8	VA TECH	PITTSBURGH	Campbell (FCS)	James Madison
7	Wofford (FCS)	DUKE	MIAMI	WAKE FOREST
6	*Wake Forest	MIAMI	SYRACUSE	FSU
5	MIAMI	VA TECH	PITTSBURGH	VIRGINIA
4	DUKE	GA State	Minnesota	NC Cent. (FCS)
3	VIRGINIA	App State	App State	Charlotte
2	Georgia St	FL A&M (FCS)	S. Carolina	Minnesota
1				
2021		2022	2023	2024
MACK BROWN		BELICHICK		

NORTH CAROLINA				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
TCU L 14-48	-320	-2	1.7	
CHARLOTTE W 20-3	32	2	54.4	
Richmond (FCS) W 41-6	113	2	68.4	
UCF L 9-34	-149	-2	7.5	
CLEMSON L 10-38	-223	1	8.2	
CALIFORNIA L 18-21	-7	-3	33.9	
VIRGINIA L 16-17	94	-2	61.0	
SYRACUSE W 27-10	274	0	72.4	
STANFORD W 20-15	-67	1	44.8	
WAKE FOREST L 12-28	-157	1	19.2	
DUKE L 25-32	-47	0	32.3	
NC STATE L 19-42	-121	-1	14.4	
OVERALL: 59th / 68 ACC: 13th / 17 34.9				

UNC	UNIT RANKS	
ACC RANK	NATIONAL	
(of 17)	TOP 15	
QUARTERBACK	9	
RUNNING BACKS	13	
RECEIVERS & TE	8	
OFFENSIVE LINE	13	
DEFENSIVE LINE	9	
LINEBACKERS	13	
DEFENSIVE BACKS	12	

NORTH CAROLINA		RANK
Scoring Offense	19.3 ppg	120
Points per Play	0.33	111
Total Offense	289 ypg	131
Yards per Play	4.9	120
Rushing Offense	105 ypg	122
Yards per Carry	3.7	110
O-Line Run Push	3.9	103
Explosive Rush	3.8	121
Passing Offense	184 ypg	111
Yards / Attempt	6.2	121
QB Rating	125	94
TD / INT Ratio	2.2	62
Sacks / Attempt	6%	76
Explosive Pass	4.0	133
Return. Production	47%	91
Returning Snaps	5,655	112
25.6 SECONDS/PLAY #22 of 68 P4		
PETRINO (2025 ARKANSAS)		

Last offseason North Carolina went all-in on football. They finally made the big-dollar financial commitment to being a serious player in college football – and perhaps to position themselves for a conference move in the next round of Realignment Musical Chairs.

They hired six-time Super Bowl winning head coach Bill Belichick, signed 70+ new players, and were one of the top national stories heading into the 2025 season. UNC got ESPN's Labor Day national television treatment and they took the opening possession right down for a touchdown. Chapel Hill was the epicenter of the football world.

Then reality hit. As *InsideCarolina* said, it was like the moment at the top of a rollercoaster before the free fall.

TCU scored 41 straight points and spoiled Belichick's debut and national moment. The 48 points were the most ever allowed by a Belichick defense.

After a pair of non-Power 4 wins, UNC got blown out by coaching-change UCF 34-9 and again by Clemson 38-10. Their nation-worst red zone turnovers showed up in close losses to California and

Virginia, but bowl eligibility was still in play in November.

For the first time in nearly 40 years, UNC lost to all three in-state rivals – Wake Forest, Duke, and NC State – all in the same season. Even worse, they did so in back-to-back-to-back weeks to close out a 4-8 season.

This was always set up to be an experiment, and while the first year was a failure, there is still a shot at overall success. Belichick made the necessary move to fire offensive coordinator Freddie Kitchens after failing to score 28+ against a single FBS opponent. He then hired one of the top offensive minds in football: Bobby Petrino.

That's a way to get fan attention back. Then UNC signed a massive recruiting class of 40 prospects, a haul that ranked #19 nationally (#3 ACC) and is packed with 12 four-stars. The recruiting/transfer balance suggests they are going for a longer-term build rather than a quick fix, and the schedule heats up in 2026, but the Big Belichick Experiment is far from dead.

OFFENSE

Petrino's top mantra for his offensive scheme is FTS: Feed The Studs. He designs his offense to the personnel strengths and has had success for decades. He is an elite playcaller and is able to scheme up a few wide-open explosive passes per game.

Last year was no different. As the offensive coordinator of a 2-10 Arkansas team, his side of the ball did its job, ranking in the top 25 of almost every stat category including 7 yards/play (#7), 5.7 yards/carry (#4), and #1 in rushing explosiveness. As an overall unit, Arkansas was #2 in my opponent-adjusted offense rankings.

It's quite the contrast to UNC's output last year: #120 in scoring, #131 in total offense, and a bottom five mark in explosiveness.

Like last offseason, the roster turnover is extreme with just three starters returning on offense and rebuilds at every position aside from running back.

Three backs had 60+ carries and two of them return including their top rusher Demon June who led the pack with a 5.5 yards/carry average. Benjamin Hall returns and the staff added former four-star recruit Kaleb Jackson (LSU) to complete the new trio.

Gio Lopez was the staff's handpicked quarterback last cycle and he failed to get the offense going. Lopez finished 14th of the 17 ACC starters in QB Rating, UNC was #121 in yards/attempt, #133 in explosive passing and rarely tried anything downfield. Lopez and backup veteran Max Johnson both transferred out, leaving behind a two-man battle between incoming transfers Billy Edwards (Wisconsin) and Miles O'Neill (Texas A&M).

NORTH CAROLINA					OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)									
O	66	36	15	18	12	4	12	40	56	14				
F	KITCHENS	CHIP LINDSEY		PHIL LONGO		KAPOLOVIC	BREWER / KAPOLOVIC							15th
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016				10-YEAR
D	BELICHICK	COLLINS	GENE CHIZIK		JAY BATEMAN		JOHN PAPUCHIS	CHIZIK						
E	29	57	51	65	54	48	49	63	54	32				58th
F														

NORTH CAROLINA		RANK	
Scoring Defense	24.5 ppg	66	
Points per Play	0.36	56	
Total Defense	337 ypg	38	
Yards per Play	4.9	26	
3rd Down Conv%	42%	104	
Rushing Defense	126 ypg	35	
Yards per Carry	3.5	24	
Negative Play %	8%	87	
Explosive Rush	4.5	16	
Passing Defense	211 ypg	53	
Yards / Attempt	6.6	47	
QB Rating	129	53	
Completion %	63.6%	94	
Explosive Pass	4.0	6	
Return. Production	42%	102	
Returning Snaps	7,405	89	

NORTH CAROLINA		RANK / 68
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play		
Offense Overall		66
Rushing Offense	(0.9)	65
Passing Offense	(3.7)	49
Defense Overall		29
Rushing Defense	0.3	37
Passing Defense	5.9	30

tackler Peyton Seelmann (Richmond) and a multi-year veteran in Derek McDonald (Syracuse) who missed most of 2025 with an injury. A pair of Top250 recruits could contend right away: DQ Forkpa and Calvin Thomas.

Three of the top defensive linemen transferred out – Tyler Thompson (Louisville), D'Antre Robinson (Oregon), and CJ Mims (Texas A&M) – and end Smith Vilbert graduated. At least this unit retained its top star with the ACC's sack leader Melkart Abou Jaoude back and poised for an All-ACC run. Leroy Jackson and Isaiah Johnson both had 300+ snaps at the interior spots, Xavier Lewis flashed as a true freshman, and they signed two Power 4 ends Tarvorise Brown (Florida) and Jaylen Harvey (Penn State).

Four starters are gone from the secondary. Nickelback Kaleb Cost is the only full-time starter back, but Jaiden Patterson started half the year at corner after Thaddeus Dixon was injured. Cost and Patterson are joined by rotational backups Greg Smith and Coleman Bryson, a three-star transfer Ade Willie (Michigan State) and a Top100 2026 commit Kenton Dopson at corner.

OUTLOOK

The Petrino hire should spark a broken offense, but UNC lost too many starters to the transfer portal to call for a usual second-year coach bonus. In fact, the schedule heats up and UNC draws just two of the ACC's bottom eight teams.

NORTH CAROLINA		RANK / 68
All-Time Wins	739	27
All-Time Win %	0.556	40
Wins (Last 100)	574	35
Wins (Last 50)	314	40
Wins (Last 25)	139	58
Wins (Last 10)	61	47
Wins (Last 5)	33	39
Game Grader (10 yr)	47.3	45
Game Grader (5 yr)	46.4	47
Game Grader (3 yr)	44.4	50
Draft Picks s' 2000	78	27
Draft Picks s' 2010	52	24
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		66
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		58



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Edwards put up 2,881 yards and 15 touchdowns as Maryland's starter in 2024 before a season-ending injury cut his Wisconsin career short. He's got the Power 4 experience, while O'Neill has the higher recruiting upside as a former four-star who Petrino personally recruited to A&M during his one season there.

UNC retained their top receiver Jordan Shipp but lost their next three wideouts and top two tight ends. Trech Kekahuna started eight games in the slot for Wisconsin and had all offseason developing chemistry with Edwards. Mason Humphrey (Lehigh) has a 6'4 frame and caught 80 passes for 1,237 yards the past two years at the FCS level. CJ Sadler should get reps immediately after a video-game 32-touchdown senior season earned him a Top200 four-star billing this cycle.

Tight ends Jake Johnson (Auburn) and Connor Cox (Virginia) transferred out but the staff pulled in a pair of former blue-chip recruits that were stuck on crowded rosters in Jelani Thurman (Ohio State) and Jordan Washington (Texas).

UNC loses 182 combined career starts from five veteran linemen. Original starting center Christo Kelly and starting guard Aidan Banfield are both back after their September injuries. Jordan Hall is back at left tackle as a projected starter. Petrino brought his starting right tackle Jacqawn McRoy (Arkansas) with him, and then the staff signed Andrew Threatt (Charleston Southern), a three-year starter from the FCS level.

DEFENSE

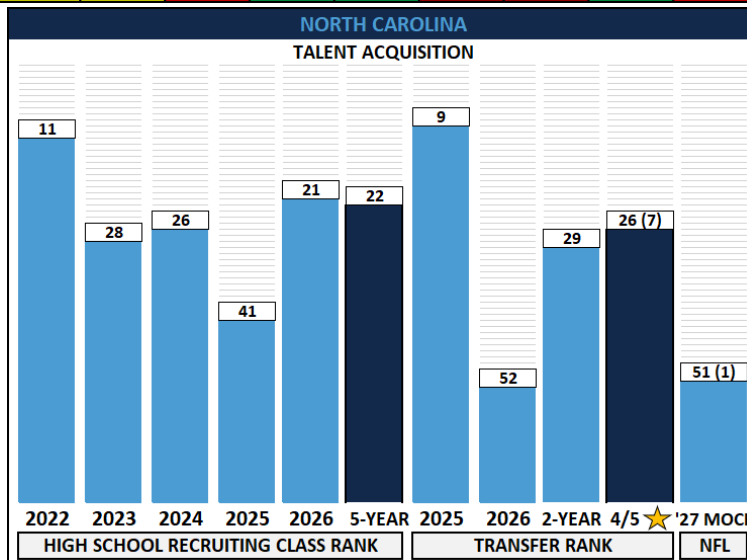
Belichick's defense posted average stats – 29th of 68 Power 4 in my opponent-adjusted stat – but got stronger as the season went on. In the same stat, UNC was 50th of 68 in the first half of the season, but was 12th over the final six games.

Eight starters depart and several of them transferred out with high rankings.

All three linebackers are gone with Khmori House (Arkansas) and Mikai Gbayor (Florida State) both grading as four-star transfers. The staff backfilled with a top FCS

NORTH CAROLINA	
2026 SCHEDULE	
A. 29	*TCU (IRELAND)
S. 5	--- BYE ---
S. 12	ETSU (FCS)
S. 19	@ Clemson
S. 26	--- BYE ---
O. 3	NOTRE DAME
O. 10	@ Pittsburgh
O. 17	@ Duke
O. 24	SYRACUSE
O. 31	MIAMI
N. 7	@ UConn
N. 14	LOUISVILLE
N. 21	@ Virginia
N. 28	NC STATE

NORTH CAROLINA		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
34.9 (59)	42.8 (52)	55.7 (27)	49.7 (37)	49 (41)	65 (15)	56.4 (23)	33.7 (61)	29.1 (60)	56.9 (22)	47.3 (45)	





SYRACUSE

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#15

ACC

#64

OVERALL



SYRACUSE				
5-YEAR WIN TREND				
13		(B) Minnesota	(B) USF	BC
12	PITTSBURGH	WAKE FOREST	GA TECH	PITTSBURGH
11	NC STATE	FSU	BC	STANFORD
10	LOUISVILLE	PITTSBURGH	VA TECH	BC
9	CLEMSON	Notre Dame	FSU	Notre Dame
8	WAKE FOREST	CLEMSON	UNC	MIAMI
7	FSU	BC	CLEMSON	GA TECH
6	Rutgers	NC STATE	WAKE FOREST	PITTSBURGH
5	BC	Wagner (FCS)	PITTSBURGH	SMU
4	VA TECH	VIRGINIA	Army	DUKE
3	Liberty	Purdue	Purdue	Tennessee
2	Albany (FCS)	UConn	W. Michigan	CLEMSON
1	Ohio	LOUISVILLE	Colgate (FCS)	Colgate (FCS)
	2021	2022	2023	2024
	2025			
	DINO BABERS		FRAN BROWN	

SYRACUSE				
2025 RESULTS		Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE
TENNESSEE	L	26-45	-116	-1 20.4
UConn	W	27-20	43	-2 51.6
Colgate (FCS)	W	66-24	212	1 72.9
CLEMSON	W	34-21	-70	2 74.7
DUKE	L	3-38	-189	-3 4.4
SMU	L	18-31	19	-2 36.4
PITTSBURGH	L	13-30	-43	-2 24.1
GA TECH	L	16-41	-162	0 11.1
UNC	L	10-27	-274	0 10.8
MIAMI	L	10-38	-99	-3 15.0
NOTRE DAME	L	7-70	-189	-3 2.1
BOSTON COLL.	L	12-34	-179	0 9.6
OVERALL: 66th / 68 ACC: 17th / 17 27.8				

SYRACUSE	UNIT RANKS	
ACC RANK	NATIONAL	
(of 17)	TOP 15	
QUARTERBACK	10	
RUNNING BACKS	17	
RECEIVERS & TE	10	
OFFENSIVE LINE	17	
DEFENSIVE LINE	17	
LINEBACKERS	16	
DEFENSIVE BACKS	14	

SYRACUSE		RANK
Scoring Offense	20.2 ppg	118
Points per Play	0.29	124
Total Offense	340 ypg	106
Yards per Play	4.8	126
Rushing Offense	123 ypg	108
Yards per Carry	3.4	125
O-Line Run Push	4.0	99
Explosive Rush	4.0	116
Passing Offense	217 ypg	80
Yards / Attempt	6.4	117
QB Rating	116	125
TD / INT Ratio	1.1	116
Sacks / Attempt	9%	118
Explosive Pass	5.6	101
Return. Production	56%	63
Returning Snaps	9,066	73
25.2 SECONDS/PLAY #18 of 68 P4		
NIXON (2025 SYRACUSE)		

In late September, Syracuse won in Clemson's "Death Valley" for the first time ever, and the major upset got them to a 3-1 start. It appeared that Fran Brown was backing up his 10-3 breakout debut 2024 season, and that quarterback Steve Angeli was keeping up last year's pace from Kyle McCord.

They were playing – and coaching – with confidence. A surprise onsides kick and gutsy fourth-down conversions helped them jump out to a 10-0 lead on Clemson, a lead they would not give up.

In the postgame interview an exuberant Brown joked about "eating for free" back in Syracuse. But one injury caused a sudden shift, and exactly one week later he issued a full apology to the Syracuse fan base for a 38-3 meltdown loss to Duke.

Late in the Clemson win, Angeli tore his Achilles' tendon and the season-ending injury wrecked the entire 2025 season. The quarterback problem cascaded with other position group weaknesses and the end result was an eight-game losing streak to close out a 3-9

season. The final two were quite the pair of gut punches. First, the school's most points allowed since 1891 in a 70-7 loss to Notre Dame in which the Irish led 21-0 before the offense even took a snap. Then in the finale, they were blown out 34-12 by one-win Boston College, with Syracuse running a high school style wildcat offense. Even eight weeks after the injury, the staff had no solution at quarterback.

The defense was no help. They allowed a Power 4 worst 35 points/game, and finished 66th of 68 Power 4 in my opponent-adjusted, per-play metric. Brown fired coordinator Elijah Robinson and hired Broyles Award nominee Vince Kehres from Toledo.

Brown then backed up his recruiting reputation by signing the school's best recruiting class of the modern era, *again*. Brown's three classes are the top three of the online recruiting era, and he's already signed 23 of the school's 50 highest-rated commits since 2000. Five-star Calvin Russell (Miami Northwestern) chose Syracuse over late in-state pushes from Florida, Florida State, and Miami and became the school's highest-rated recruit of all-time.

OFFENSE

In Angeli's 3+ games he threw 10 touchdowns, just 2 picks, 1,317 yards with a high 8.4 per attempt. His QB Rating would have ranked third in the ACC had he met the minimum threshold of games played. Against UConn he led two scoring drives in the final five minutes to force overtime, then hit Justus Ross-Simmons at the pylon for the game-winner. He also had 245 yards and 2 scores against Clemson before the injury.

When the starter goes down a statistical decline is expected, but the drop-off here was a season-ruiner for Syracuse. Angeli had more yards and touchdowns than the rest of the room put up in 8+ games without him. After the injury, Syracuse ranked dead last in my opponent-adjusted passing (68th of 68 Power 4) as they rotated through Rickie Collins, walk-on Joe Filardi, and tight end Dan Villari.

Brown added to the quarterback room with first-team All-CUSA Amari Odom (Kennesaw State).

The offensive line was a total weakness that limited the potential of talented athletes at the skill positions. The line ranked #99 in OL Run Push and #118 in Pass Protection. TJ Ferguson and Da'Metrius Weatherspoon were bright spots but both graduated, along with Austin Collins, meaning Syracuse needs to find three new starters up front. Byron Washington took over the right guard spot as a true freshman and they've got experience at the tackle spots with Trevion Mack and Kam Pringle. Brown's hire of longtime NFL coach Juan Castillo is intriguing and comes at their most critical position.

In 2024 three receivers went over 900+ yards but in 2025 no one even hit 600. The entire receiving core is gone as Ross-Simmons graduated, and Johntay Cook and four-star Darrell Gill both transferred to Ole Miss. Brown added a pair of former four-star recruits who lack college experience

SYRACUSE					OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)									
O	68	15	62	35	49	65	54	56	31	40				60th
F	JEFF NIXON	BECK	ANAE	STERLIN GILBERT	MIKE LYNCH	LYNCH / LEWIS								
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016				10-YEAR
D	ELIJAH ROBINSON	LONG		TONY WHITE										
E	66	61	47	25	33	32	61	49	66	68				64th
F														

SYRACUSE		RANK
Scoring Defense	34.9 ppg	130
Points per Play	0.53	131
Total Defense	428 ypg	126
Yards per Play	6.5	129
3rd Down Conv%	41%	86
Rushing Defense	175 ypg	99
Yards per Carry	5.3	132
Negative Play %	8%	84
Explosive Rush	9.8	134
Passing Defense	253 ypg	122
Yards / Attempt	7.8	113
QB Rating	148	119
Completion %	66.2%	122
Explosive Pass	5.8	71
Return. Production	67%	9
Returning Snaps	9,273	74

SYRACUSE		RANK / 68
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play		
Offense Overall		68
Rushing Offense	(0.5)	59
Passing Offense	(32.1)	68
Defense Overall		66
Rushing Defense	(1.3)	67
Passing Defense	(10.7)	56

and Davien Kerr.

The line is a complete rebuild again. The team mustered just 20 sacks in 12 games, and aside from a 7-sack explosion vs. Pitt, it was basically just one per game. Syracuse loses its top lineman Kevin Jobity along with veterans David Reese and Denis Jaquez. The tackle spots benefit from a second-year bonus for Nissi Ogbebor and Rashard Perry's injury return. The staff signed four mid-three star transfer linemen: Dillan Fontus (Maryland), Tunmise Adeleye (UNLV), Keyshawn Johnson (Tennessee Tech) and Jartavius Flounoy (Georgia State). Fontus should be a starter after holding his own in the Big Ten, while former five-star Adeleye had eight sacks the past two years.

OUTLOOK

Brown is elevating the overall talent profile here and wants to prove that 2024 wasn't just a one-hit wonder. Angeli is back healthy and though it was a small sample size, the offense looked completely different with him under center.

Both lines of scrimmage are major liabilities for 2026, and it may take another year of experience until the record-setting recruiting classes change the on-field momentum.

SYRACUSE		RANK / 68
All-Time Wins	768	22
All-Time Win %	0.564	37
Wins (Last 100)	555	41
Wins (Last 50)	301	46
Wins (Last 25)	130	61
Wins (Last 10)	55	55
Wins (Last 5)	31	47
Game Grader (10 yr)	39.7	63
Game Grader (5 yr)	42.1	58
Game Grader (3 yr)	39.8	61
Draft Picks s' 2000	46	54
Draft Picks s' 2010	24	57
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		23
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		20

in Elijah Moore (Florida State) and Matt Outten (Penn State), and starters from lower levels Cole Weaver (Miami, OH) and 6'3 Zamondre Merriweather (JUCO). Incoming five-star Calvin Russell should earn a starting spot right away.

No running back had a single 100-yard game all season, and Yasin Willis' 558 rushing yards were a program-low since 2020. Willis transferred out to Kansas, #2 back Will Nixon graduated, and a pair of transfers will reshape the room. Ahmad Miller (Jackson State) rushed for 1,000+ yards at the FCS level, while Ju'Juan Johnson (LSU) is a do-it-all athlete.

DEFENSE

Robinson was fired after consecutive bottom ten defenses and the 2025 unit hit national lows. An already thin defensive line lost its best player Maraad Watson to a late transfer, then lost starter Rashard Perry to injury. Both veteran safeties were injured, too. A struggling unit was weakened further by being on the field more than most, due to the broken offense.

Kehres won DIII titles at Mount Union and then turned around Toledo's defense from worst to first in the MAC. The 2025 unit was towards the top of the national leaderboards in almost every key stat category.

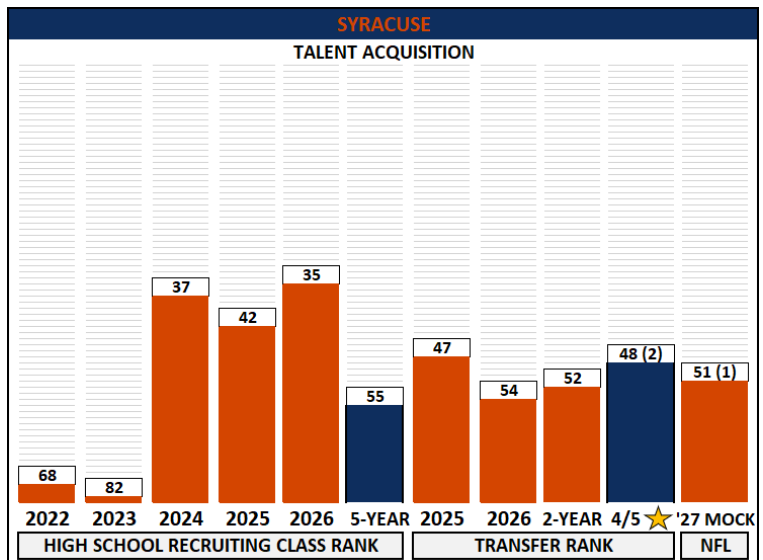
He's got some rising stars to build around in the back seven. Chris Peal was one of the top cover corners in the ACC, and he forms a top corner duo with Demetres Samuel, the two-way true freshman phenom. At inside backer, Antoine Deslauriers earned Freshman All-America honors after leading the team with 60 tackles.

All three starting linebackers return with Gary Bryant and Jamie Tremble flanking Deslauriers. Kehres brought Chris D'Appolonia with him from Toledo and he can rotate onto the field on pass downs with a boost to pass coverage.

Both veterans Duce Chestnut and Devin Grant graduated from the secondary, and they need to find two new starters. They signed Western Kentucky starter Nazir Ward to compete with Cornell Perry

SYRACUSE	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 5	NEW HAMP. (FCS)
S. 12	CALIFORNIA
S. 17	@ Pittsburgh
S. 26	--- BYE ---
O. 3	@ UConn
O. 10	@ Virginia
O. 17	LOUISVILLE
O. 24	@ UNC
O. 31	SMU
N. 7	CLEMSON
N. 14	@ NC State
N. 21	@ Boston Coll.
N. 28	NOTRE DAME

SYRACUSE		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
27.8 (66)	57.6 (28)	34.1 (59)	49.1 (41)	42.1 (50)	17.9 (67)	34.1 (59)	61.4 (18)	40.4 (53)	32.3 (60)	39.7 (63)	



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STANFORD

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#16

ACC

#66

OVERALL



STANFORD				
5-YEAR WIN TREND				
12	Notre Dame	BYU	Notre Dame	San Jose St
11	CAL	CAL	CAL	CAL
10	OREGON ST	UTAH	OREGON ST	NC STATE
9	UTAH	WASH ST	WASHINGTON	WAKE FOREST
8	WASHINGTON	UCLA	UCLA	SMU
7	WASH ST	OREGON ST	OREGON	Notre Dame
6	ARIZONA ST	OREGON	ARIZONA	VA TECH
5	UCLA	WASHINGTON	Sac St (FCS)	CLEMSON
4	Kansas St	USC	USC	TCU
3	OREGON	ARIZONA ST	WASH ST	LOUISVILLE
2	Vanderbilt	Notre Dame	COLORADO	SYRACUSE
1	USC	Colgate (FCS)	Hawaii	Cal Poly (FCS)
2021		2022	2023	2024
DAVID SHAW		TROY TAYLOR		REICH

Andrew Luck returned to The Farm and took over full control of the football program through the newly created General Manager role. Just before spring practice he fired head coach Troy Taylor and hired his former NFL head coach Frank Reich to take over as a one-year interim.

Despite the late start to 2025, Reich was able to break Stanford out of their three-win cycle, went 4-2 in home games, and won The Big Game over Cal to snap a four-year drought. He noted the importance of that win and the foundation it could lay going forward: "got the Axe back... the chemistry, the brotherhood in the locker room, the way we practice... we made progress."

The defense led the way in their wins, with a Pick Six and goal-line stand against Boston College, another goal-line stand and three red zone stops against Florida State, and a pair of fumble touchdowns to beat Cal.

STANFORD				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
HAWAII L 20-23	-20	0	34.4	
BYU L 3-27	-171	-3	8.5	
BOSTON COLL. W 30-20	10	3	57.5	
VIRGINIA L 20-48	-269	-1	5.5	
SAN JOSE ST W 30-29	-43	0	33.5	
SMU L 10-34	-16	-2	23.1	
FLORIDA ST W 20-13	-151	-1	47.6	
MIAMI L 7-42	-260	-2	2.0	
PITTSBURGH L 20-35	-140	1	23.2	
UNC L 15-20	67	-1	37.9	
CALIFORNIA W 31-10	-15	3	66.4	
NOTRE DAME L 20-49	-212	-1	6.3	
OVERALL: 65th / 68 ACC: 16th / 17 28.8				

In the background, Luck was conducting a full-scale head coaching search and eventually landed on a familiar Stanford name: Tavita Pritchard.

Pritchard threw the game-winning touchdown in the historic upset win over #2 USC in 2007 as 41-point underdogs and then ironically lost the starting quarterback job to Luck himself. The benching actually accelerated Pritchard's coaching career and he stayed on for a decade including five years as David Shaw's offensive coordinator.

Since leaving Stanford he spent the last three seasons in the NFL, most recently as the QB coach for the Washington Commanders and helped guide Jayden Daniels to his breakout Offensive Rookie of the Year season in 2024. While Pritchard does not have any head coaching experience, he does have a clear passion for his alma mater – a critical ingredient to recent success stories like Clark Lea (Vanderbilt), Brent Key (Georgia Tech), and Kenny Dillingham (Arizona State).

Pritchard has a multi-year rebuilding project on his hands. While 2025 season was a five-year high, the gap between Stanford and the league contenders is still noticeable.

In their six games against ranked opponents, Stanford lost all six by double-digits and five by 24+ points. Their high academic ratings help attract national talent on the high school recruiting trail, but also act as a barrier to incoming transfers. Usually a coaching change transfer class acts as a spark with 30+ transfer additions. Stanford finished dead last in Power 4 this cycle with just three incoming FBS transfers.

OFFENSE

The Stanford offensive line has been the focal point of the program's highs under Harbaugh and Shaw, and the main catalyst of the decline since. Pritchard understands the importance and specifically mentioned the offensive line in his opening press conference: "I know we'll be built up front – we will make that the heart and soul of the offense."

He inherits a veteran unit but one that has struggled statistically for the past several seasons. In 2025 they were the only offensive line in America to finish in the bottom ten of both my OL Run Push and Pass Protection metrics. They allowed a sack on 10% of pass attempts and their 2.5 yards/carry finished dead last in America.

Pritchard hired Virginia's offensive line coach Terry Heffernan to take over the offensive coordinator role. Heffernan's UVA line was the most improved from 2024 (#127) to 2025 (#11) in Pass Protection and he'll attempt to work his magic here.

Niki Prongos is the headliner at left tackle and should get some All-ACC hype this season. 2025 was the third season in a row in which Stanford had a true freshman lineman start 6+ games and all that youth experience pays dividends in 2026. Kahlil House is a third-year starter, Simone Pale

STANFORD	UNIT RANKS
ACC RANK (of 17)	NATIONAL TOP 15
QUARTERBACK	17
RUNNING BACKS	16
RECEIVERS & TE	17
OFFENSIVE LINE	14
DEFENSIVE LINE	14
LINEBACKERS	11
DEFENSIVE BACKS	16

STANFORD	RANK
Scoring Offense 18.8 ppg	123
Points per Play 0.29	122
Total Offense 307 ypg	125
Yards per Play 4.7	128
Rushing Offense 85 ypg	132
Yards per Carry 2.6	136
O-Line Run Push 3.5	131
Explosive Rush 2.7	135
Passing Offense 222 ypg	73
Yards / Attempt 6.8	92
QB Rating 120	114
TD / INT Ratio 1.2	114
Sacks / Attempt 10%	129
Explosive Pass 6.3	85
Return. Production 58%	54
Returning Snaps 9,435	69
24.7 SECONDS/PLAY #15 of 68 P4	
PRITCHARD (2022 STANFORD)	

STANFORD					OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)									
O	62	65	60	62	54	26	41	13	15	41				
F														56th
F	BYHAM	TROY TAYLOR*	TAVITA PRITCHARD					MIKE BLOOMGREN						
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016				10-YEAR
D	BOBBY APRIL					LANCE ANDERSON								
E	46	62	54	58	61	63	55	46	42	23				63rd
F														

STANFORD		RANK	
Scoring Defense	29.2 ppg	97	
Points per Play	0.42	95	
Total Defense	408 ypg	105	
Yards per Play	5.9	102	
3rd Down Conv%	42%	101	
Rushing Defense	119 ypg	25	
Yards per Carry	3.8	45	
Negative Play %	7%	106	
Explosive Rush	5.1	28	
Passing Defense	289 ypg	136	
Yards / Attempt	7.8	112	
QB Rating	146	114	
Completion %	66.1%	119	
Explosive Pass	6.7	100	
Return. Production	62%	21	
Returning Snaps	12,003	37	

STANFORD		RANK / 68	
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play			
Offense Overall		62	
Rushing Offense	(1.3)	67	
Passing Offense	(10.2)	58	
Defense Overall		46	
Rushing Defense	0.6	27	
Passing Defense	(9.0)	54	

Up front, All-ACC Clay Patterson is gone, but plenty of experience returns with nose tackle Braden Marceau-Olayinka and ends Omar Staples and Zach Rowell.

The secondary was torched all season and allowed a nation-worst 289 passing yards/game along with bottom 25 ranks in all key categories. Two starters depart – safety Mitch Leigber and corner Collin Wright – but All-ACC honorable mention safety Jay Green returns. The safeties were tackle-machines and accounted for four of the team's top six. Green, Scotty Edwards and Charlie Eckhardt are all back. The staff signed corner Leroy Bryant who started five games for Washington.

OUTLOOK

Stanford's .308 win percentage (24-54 overall) over the past seven seasons is the worst in Power 4. Without the usual coaching change transfer haul to pump the roster with fresh talent, Stanford signed the fewest transfers in Power 4.

Instead, they actually have the #5 five-year recruiting average in the ACC, some proven playmakers on defense, and avoid the last-place projection.

Pritchard has a multi-year rebuilding project on his hands here.

STANFORD		RANK / 68	
All-Time Wins	679	40	
All-Time Win %	0.565	36	
Wins (Last 100)	565	38	
Wins (Last 50)	296	48	
Wins (Last 25)	159	46	
Wins (Last 10)	51	59	
Wins (Last 5)	16	68	
Game Grader (10 yr)	39.0	65	
Game Grader (5 yr)	26.8	68	
Game Grader (3 yr)	26.3	68	
Draft Picks s' 2000	88	22	
Draft Picks s' 2010	59	19	
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		57	
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		66	

is back from injury, Fisher Anderson is a returning starter at center, and Josh Williams took over a starting spot as a true freshman and held it the final six games.

Both starting quarterbacks are gone and now it's a complete rebuild. Ben Gulbranson finished dead last in the ACC in QB Rating and graduated, and then backup Elijah Brown transferred out to Washington. Stanford signed Michigan's 2024 starter Davis Warren who threw 7 touchdowns, 10 picks, and spent 2025 rehabbing an ACL tear. Dylan Rizk (UCF) has a few Power 4 starts on his resume and adds a dual-threat skillset, the 6'6 Charlie Mirer led a touchdown drive to close the season against Notre Dame, and three-star Mike Mitchell made it a four-man race.

Micah Ford rushed for 643 yards – a Stanford high since 2019 – and returns along with Sedrick Irvin who had the game-winning score to beat San Jose State in the final seconds.

Stanford lost some firepower from the pass game with their top two receivers CJ Williams and Bryce Farrell and top tight end Sam Roush all departing. Williams and Roush earned All-ACC honors and leave the room low on experience. Caden High steps into the lead receiver role, a pair of Yale transfers Nico Brown and David Pantelis bring All-Ivy resumes, and Carter Shaw (David's son) transferred in from UCLA. Roush will be tough to replace after leading ACC tight ends in receptions (49) and yards (545) but Benji Blackburn and Chico Holt are the next men up.

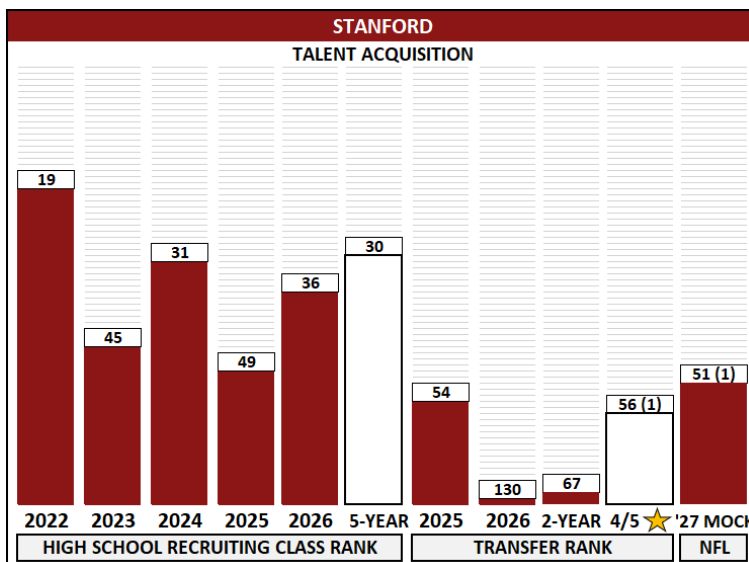
DEFENSE

Stanford allowed 408 yards/game, a program best since 2017, and it was their best rushing defense in over a decade. They saved their best work for the red zone with Top 25 finishes in red zone scoring and red zone touchdown percentage, and their performance near the goal-line flipped the Florida State and BC games to wins.

They return their top four tacklers, none more important than second-team All-ACC inside linebacker Matt Rose who finished with the league's second-most tackles (106). The linebacker core returns intact with Rose and Jahsiah Galvan in the middle, and Tevarua Tafiti and Ernest Cooper on the outsides.

STANFORD	
2026 SCHEDULE	
A. 29	HAWAII
S. 4	MIAMI
S. 12	--- BYE ---
S. 19	@ Duke
S. 26	GA TECH
O. 3	@ Wake Forest
O. 10	@ Notre Dame
O. 17	ELON (FCS)
O. 23	NC STATE
O. 31	@ Louisville
N. 7	--- BYE ---
N. 14	@ Virginia Tech
N. 21	@ California
N. 28	SMU

STANFORD		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
28.8 (65)	24.8 (66)	25.4 (67)	28.1 (63)	26.8 (62)	50.5 (32)	36.5 (55)	51.5 (33)	60.2 (23)	57.1 (21)	39 (65)	



WEEKLY, IN-SEASON FEATURE -- ADVANCED STATS & INFO

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BOSTON COLLEGE

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#17 #67

ACC OVERALL



BOSTON COLLEGE				
5-YEAR WIN TREND				
13				
12	WAKE FOREST	SYRACUSE	MIAMI	(B) Nebraska
11	FSU	Notre Dame	PITTSBURGH	SMU
10	SYRACUSE	DUKE	VA TECH	LOUISVILLE
9	LOUISVILLE	UConn	LOUISVILLE	VA TECH
8	NC STATE	WAKE FOREST	FSU	VIRGINIA
7	CLEMSON	CLEMSON	N. Illinois	Missouri
6	GA TECH	FSU	(B) SMU	PITTSBURGH
5	VA TECH	VA TECH	SYRACUSE	UNC
4	Missouri	Rutgers	UConn	SYRACUSE
3	Temple	NC STATE	GA TECH	W. Kentucky
2	UMass	LOUISVILLE	Army	Mich St
1	Colgate (FCS)	Maine (FCS)	VIRGINIA	Duquesne (FCS)
		Holy Cross (FCS)	FSU	SYRACUSE
				Fordham (FCS)
	2021	2022	2023	2024
	JEFF HAFLEY		BILL O'BRIEN	

Boston College won their opener by 56 over Fordham, won their finale by 22 over Syracuse – and lost all ten games in between. So much for the second-year coach bonus.

The losses came in all varieties. Costly goal-line turnovers in winnable games (Michigan State, Stanford, California), 30+ point blowouts (Pittsburgh, Clemson, SMU), a walk-off field goal (Georgia Tech), and competitive losses to rivals (UConn and Notre Dame).

Two years in and BC is farther away from head coach Bill O'Brien's program blueprint he pitched at the opening press conference. He constantly mentioned being tough and physical – a nod to the school's offensive line NFL pipeline – but the offense finished in the national bottom 10 in rushing yards/carry. Combined with a poor run defense, BC finished second-worst in Power 4 in my "Run the Ball, Stop the Run" metric.

The win over Syracuse helped avoid the school's first 0-11 (vs. FBS opponents) season in 50 years, but before any positive momentum could be carried into the offseason, Boston College was hit with a mass

BOSTON COLLEGE				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
Fordham (FCS) W 66-10	387	1	77.7	
MICHIGAN ST L 40-42	77	0	48.9	
STANFORD L 20-30	-10	-3	25.0	
CALIFORNIA L 24-28	3	-1	33.9	
PITTSBURGH L 7-48	-287	-3	0.3	
CLEMSON L 10-41	-283	1	5.6	
UConn L 23-38	-60	0	18.8	
LOUISVILLE L 24-38	-144	0	22.3	
NOTRE DAME L 10-25	-177	-2	19.2	
SMU L 13-45	-184	-3	5.0	
GA TECH L 34-36	-91	1	42.1	
SYRACUSE W 34-12	179	0	72.4	
OVERALL: 64th / 68 ACC: 15th / 17 30.9				

exodus to the transfer portal.

30 scholarship players transferred out, which is an abnormally high number in a non-coach change offseason. Most of the proven playmakers from the 2025 team graduated or left The Heights. Then O'Brien went with a double coordinator switch heading into spring ball, hiring journeyman coordinator Ted Roof to call the defense, and naming himself as the offensive coordinator and play-caller.

OFFENSE

Alabama transfer Dylan Lonergan impressed in fall camp and won the starting job over incumbent starter Grayson James. Lonergan started fast, threw for 390 yards and four scores in the overtime loss to Michigan State, and actually led the nation in completions/game in late September. In the fifth game, O'Brien benched him for James, and the position remained unsettled the rest of the way.

BOSTON COLLEGE UNIT RANKS		
ACC RANK	NATIONAL	
(of 17)	TOP 15	
QUARTERBACK	15	
RUNNING BACKS	14	
RECEIVERS & TE	16	
OFFENSIVE LINE	15	
DEFENSIVE LINE	16	
LINEBACKERS	17	
DEFENSIVE BACKS	15	

There was no help from the run game, which finished in the bottom ten of all key categories, and the offensive line also struggled in pass protection with a #100 national rank.

Both the quarterback room and the offensive line are complete restarts heading into 2026. Lonergan transferred out to Rutgers, James graduated, and the staff's two transfer signees have zero FBS snaps on the resume. Grayson Wilson was a three-star high school recruit who redshirted at Arkansas last year, while Mason McKenzie earned the GLIAC Player of the Year honors from the same DII conference where Ole Miss breakout star Trinidad Chambliss played in.

McKenzie picked Boston College over Northwestern and Temple and posted a gaudy stat-line over his two years at Saginaw Valley State: 4,301 yards passing, 1,773 yards rushing, and 41 total touchdowns. McKenzie appears to be the favorite heading into fall camp and brings more mobility to the position compared to the 2025 room.

Four starters depart from the offensive line, including the young bright spot Eryx Daugherty who transferred out to Louisville. The staff pumped the room with experienced transfers, even if those snaps came at a lower level. The one with Power 4 starting experience, Kristian Phillips (Michigan State) joins returning center Michael Crounse as two projected starters. Robert Smith got game reps as a true freshman at guard, Pape Sy is a returning backup tackle, and the four other transfers bring experience from the non-AQ and FCS levels: Trevon Humphrey (NC Central), Owen Snively (Eastern Michigan), Reggie Jackson (Jacksonville State), and perhaps the biggest upside in 6'7 290-pound Veguer Jean-Jumeau (Tennessee State) who was apparently drawing some SEC interest.

The line rebuild is even more critical than usual, given the lack of FBS experience at quarterback, and the loss of their best skill players. Lewis Bond was named offensive MVP and graduates as one

BOSTON COLLEGE		RANK
Scoring Offense	25.4 ppg	85
Points per Play	0.37	91
Total Offense	384 ypg	73
Yards per Play	5.6	77
Rushing Offense	104 ypg	127
Yards per Carry	3.3	127
O-Line Run Push	3.7	126
Explosive Rush	3.2	132
Passing Offense	280 ypg	15
Yards / Attempt	7.4	58
QB Rating	135	66
TD / INT Ratio	1.7	83
Sacks / Attempt	7%	100
Explosive Pass	7.1	52
Return. Production	44%	101
Returning Snaps	7,087	94
24.2 SECONDS/PLAY #10 of 68 P4		
O'BRIEN (2025 BC)		FAST

BOSTON COLLEGE					OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)					
O	49	55	39	61	60	41	33	61	48	67
F										64th
F	WILL LAWING	SHIMKO	McNULTY	FRANK CIGNETTI	BAJAKIAN	SCOT LOEFFLER				
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016
D	TIM LEWIS	DUGGAN	TEM LUKABU							
E	67	50	62	51	45	47	66	22	28	19
F										56th

BOSTON COLLEGE		RANK	
Scoring Defense	32.8 ppg	123	
Points per Play	0.49	123	
Total Defense	433 ypg	128	
Yards per Play	6.5	132	
3rd Down Conv%	41%	91	
Rushing Defense	178 ypg	106	
Yards per Carry	5.0	125	
Negative Play %	6%	130	
Explosive Rush	6.2	59	
Passing Defense	256 ypg	123	
Yards / Attempt	8.2	121	
QB Rating	150	121	
Completion %	64.2%	103	
Explosive Pass	7.8	125	
Return. Production	57%	48	
Returning Snaps	9,789	66	

BOSTON COLLEGE		RANK / 68	
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play			
Offense Overall		49	
Rushing Offense	(0.4)	51	
Passing Offense	(5.9)	53	
Defense Overall		67	
Rushing Defense	(1.3)	66	
Passing Defense	(15.2)	63	

of the most reliable BC receivers in recent memory. Reed Harris flashed breakout potential and was set to be the next star receiver but he left for Arizona State as the #4 ranked transfer WR this cycle.

Jaedn Skeete steps into the top role and was playing well before injuries derailed his season. The staff added a trio of three-star transfers with speedsters Landon Wright (Washington State) and Javarius Green (UNC) and 6'6 Reed Swanson (Colgate). Johnathan Montague was drawing big reviews before a 2025 season-ending injury and is another potential contributor.

BC also lost their top two running backs, as Turbo Richard transferred to Indiana and Jordan McDonald graduated. They signed a one-two punch from the portal in Evan Dickens (Liberty) and Nolan Ray (Maryland). Dickens posted a 1,339-yard, 16-touchdown season to earn All-CUSA honors while Ray brings short-yardage physicality.

They lose tight end Jeremiah Franklin who placed in the national top ten of receptions, but do bring back a star to build around in Freshman All-American Kaelan Chudzinski who is a pure pass threat.

DEFENSE

The defense finished second-worst – 67th of 68 Power 4 – in my opponent-adjusted metric and regressed in all 17 of my stat categories. Injuries were a factor with nine defenders missing significant time.

Missed tackles and a lack of a pass rush were the two worst flaws. BC's two defensive ends combined for just 3 sacks and 4.5 tackles for loss all season. As a unit they ranked #130 in my Negative Play Rate, #125 in yards/carry, and #121 in opponent QB Rating.

Roof has a complete rebuild here as the top six defensive linemen, top three linebackers, and three defensive backs are all gone.

Nose tackle Owen Stoudmire would have been the lone returner on the line but was a late transfer out to Nebraska. Chris Marable steps up into the starting role after some solid experience down the stretch, while Favor Bate and E'Lla Boykin move up into the end spots.

The staff signed plenty of transfers to compete with them, headlined by a pair of former four-star recruits in KJ Sampson (Florida State) and Christian Hudson (Colorado). Their only two four-star recruits from the 2026 class are both defensive ends with Mason Leak (Avon, CT) and Demeterius Thompson (Clayton, MO) adding some pass rush.

It's a reset at linebacker, too. Daveon Crouch went to Kansas, Owen McGowan graduated, and a pair of three-star transfers are projected starters with Anthony Palano (Washington State), and athletic cover backers Justin Medlock (SMU) and Bodie Kahoun (Notre Dame).

BC's cornerback duo was injured early in season which left them over-exposed to explosive passing (#125). This is the most experienced unit on the team with corner Syair Torrence, nickel Cam Martinez, and safeties KP Price and Carter Davis all returning. One key departure was hard-hitting safety Omar Thornton who transferred to Miami with a high four-star transfer grade.

OUTLOOK

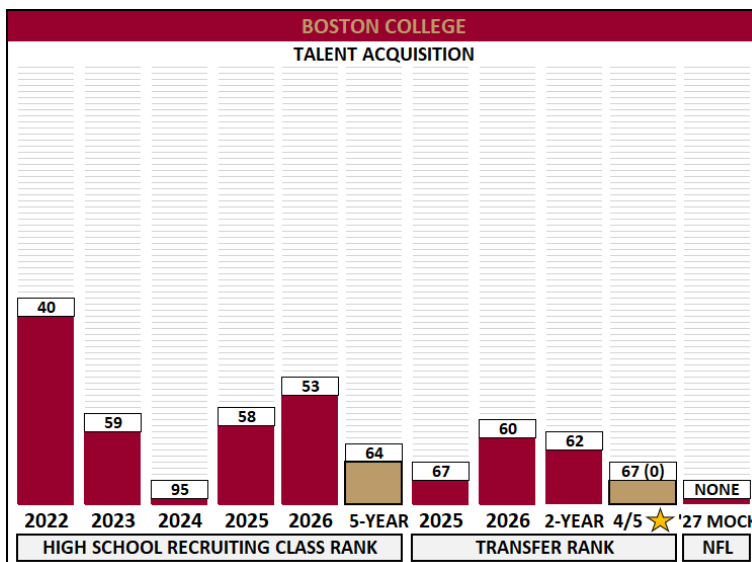
Boston College joins Pittsburgh as the only Power 4 programs to not sign a single four-star transfer in the past two transfer cycles. They are a bottom-five high school recruiter and are fresh off a 2-10 season.

Throw in a double coordinator switch, and an exodus of star players, and this looks like another last-place finish.

BOSTON COLLEGE	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 5	@ Cincinnati
S. 11	RUTGERS
S. 19	MAINE (FCS)
S. 26	VIRGINIA TECH
O. 3	@ SMU
O. 10	--- BYE ---
O. 17	PITTSBURGH
O. 24	@ Georgia Tech
O. 31	@ Duke
N. 7	FLORIDA STATE
N. 14	@ Notre Dame
N. 21	SYRACUSE
N. 28	@ Miami

BOSTON COLLEGE		RANK / 68	
All-Time Wins	712	33	
All-Time Win %	0.567	35	
Wins (Last 100)	599	31	
Wins (Last 50)	313	41	
Wins (Last 25)	169	42	
Wins (Last 10)	58	51	
Wins (Last 5)	25	63	
Game Grader (10 yr)	40.7	59	
Game Grader (5 yr)	36.8	65	
Game Grader (3 yr)	39.7	62	
Draft Picks s' 2000	56	43	
Draft Picks s' 2010	35	45	
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		8	
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		33	

BOSTON COLLEGE		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	2015	10-YEAR
30.9 (64)	44.6 (49)	43.5 (46)	25.9 (65)	39.1 (56)	43.2 (42)	39.5 (50)	48 (38)	52.1 (33)	39.7 (50)	40.7 (59)	



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